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Happening today

● **AN NIA COURT** will pronounce its judgment in the 2013 Maoist attack in Chhattisgarh's Jhiram Valley, in which several Congress leaders, including former Union Minister V C Shukla, were killed.

● **THE SC WILL HEAR** a plea challenging the validity of a provision of the Income Tax Act that allows political parties to receive cash donations below Rs 2,000.

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Business as Usual

By EP UNNY

Some books are freer than their authors, some authors are freer than their books.



NATION

PAGE 8

KIN OF DALITS KILLED IN 2012 GUJARAT FIRING LINK SUICIDE TO A FATHER'S GRIEF

NEET-PG: POWER CUT HITS TWO JAIPUR CENTRES, RETEST ON SEPT 5; PANEL FORMED



Vasudev and Arjun Pyakurial perform their mother's last rites after failing to find her, in Nepal's Umerkot. TASHI TOBGYAL [MORE REPORTS, P 8, 12](#)

'Can't stop looking... not so soon': In Nepal, hope against hope as families search for the missing

Await sign of their relatives, dead or alive



DEVANSH MITTAL

EXPRESS IN NEPAL

Betrawati, August 30

OVER THE last four days, Lekhnath Adhikari, 43, has travelled hundreds of kilometres

on his uncle's bike. He has been going to almost every search and relief camp, hospital and locality near his native village Betrawati, and areas downstream.

Betrawati is located in Nuwakot district, north of Kathmandu. It is on the border of Rasuwa district — which was the epicenter of the flash floods.

While it usually takes two hours to reach the village, after the floods, it takes roughly four hours. On Wednesday, when

Govt prepares for mass cremations; toll now 788

Yubaraj Ghimire

Kathmandu, August 30

THE GOVERNMENT of Nepal has decided to go for mass cremations amid a dearth of mortuary facilities in hospitals on one hand and recovery of bodies of flood victims in hundreds, on the other.

A day after 70 bodies were cremated en masse in Chitwan district, the Federal Home Min-

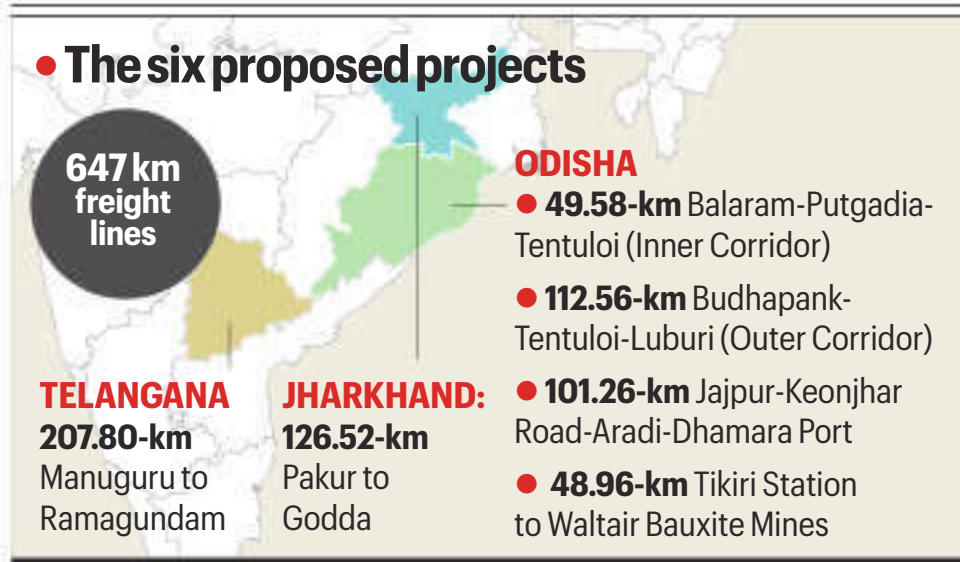
THE EDITORIAL PAGE

AS GLACIERS MELT, PREPARE FOR HIMALAYAN CHALLENGE [PAGE 10](#)

istry has decided to do the same in Kathmandu, the hub where bodies of victims of the devastating floods are being brought

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

In a first, Rlys to build 6 freight lines with pvt firms using highways' hybrid funding model



Dheeraj Mishra & Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, August 30

GIVING A push to private investment in Indian Railways, the Public Private Partnership Appraisal Committee (PPPAC) under the Ministry of Finance, earlier in August, approved six railway lines spanning 647 km along freight corridors. These are to be developed under the Hybrid Annuity Model (HAM) — similar to the model used in the highways sector wherein the government and the private builder split the project costs and risks.

Of the six proposed railway projects, four are in Odisha: 49.58-km Balaram-Putgadga-Tentuloi (Inner Corridor), 112.56-km Budhapank-Tentuloi-Luburi (Outer Corridor), 101.26-km Jaipur-Keonjhar Road-Arudi-Dhamara Port and 48.96-km Tikiri Station to Waltair Bauxite Mines. The other two projects are the 207.80-km Manuguru-Ramagundam line in Telangana and the 126.52-km Pakur/Nagarnabi to Godda line in Jharkhand.

The project will now be sent to the Union Cabinet for final approval, before the bids are invited. This will be the first time

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FIR AGAINST LoP BASED ON COMPLAINT BY VALMIKI RESIDENT

Kharge 'purification' row: Day after he calls for FIR, Rahul booked in Haldwani

Lalmani Verma

Lucknow, August 30

AN FIR was lodged against Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi in Uttarakhand's Haldwani town on Sunday under sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the SC/ST Act.

The FIR was lodged a day after Gandhi, in a press confer-



Rahul Gandhi called it an act related to untouchability without verification: Complaint

ence in New Delhi, urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to order an FIR over a "shuddhikaran havan" (purification ritual) held at Ramila Maidan in Haldwani, days after a rally there by Congress president and Dalit leader Mallikarjun Kharge.

Calling the act a "crime," Gandhi said that it illustrated the "untouchability" Dalits face

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



'Despite US tariffs, our fish export has increased... now exporting to the UK, Japan, China, Thailand and EU'

RAJIV RANJAN SINGH
UNION MINISTER OF FISHERIES, ANIMAL HUSBANDRY AND DAIRYING
[PAGE 14](#)

NLU DELHI CONVOCATION ADDRESS

Threatening students is misuse of power, says Justice Bhuyan

Amaal Sheikh

New Delhi, August 30

SUPREME COURT judge Justice Ujjal Bhuyan said Sunday that students cannot be threatened with punitive action for expressing a different point of view or asking questions, and called such action "unconstitutional" and a "misuse of power".

Speaking at the 13th Convocation of the LL.M programmes at National Law University Delhi, Justice Bhuyan said, "In a democracy, the right to question is not an act of defiance. It is an essential expression of citizenship, liberty and constitutional responsibility... When students express a different point of view, when students ask questions, they cannot be threatened. They cannot be threatened with punitive action. That is unconstitutional. That is misuse of power and office."

Earlier this month, the Bar Council of India withdrew a directive issued by its chairman,



“Constitutional democracy requires the State to listen to the citizens, the citizens to listen to one another, to have institutions that are accountable and a society that does not treat every dissent as a threat.”

JUSTICE UJJAL BHUYAN,
SUPREME COURT JUDGE

Manan Kumar Mishra, asking state bar councils not to enrol graduates of the 2026 batch of NALSAR University of Law.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

● COUNTRY HAS REMOVED LEGAL OBSTACLE TO VOLUNTARY RETURN OF REFUGEES WHO FLED CIVIL WAR WITHOUT VALID PASSPORTS OR THROUGH UNAUTHORISED DEPARTURE POINTS

Lanka beckons, but for refugees in TN, too much time and distance lie in between

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, August 30

FIVE DAYS before his family fled Sri Lanka, men from the Eelam People's Revolutionary Liberation Front arrived looking for boys above the age of 12. Mahendran was 11. His parents hid him, his brother and cousins in the narrow space between the roof and a false ceiling of their home. The children stayed there from morning until 9 at night.

Soon afterwards, the family left home, escaping 15 km to Peralai in the Mannar island. Two of Mahendran's cousins travelling in another vehicle were

captured by the LTTE, put into battle with the Sri Lankan army, and died fighting.

Mahendran's family waited 15 days on the Mannar island for a boat, surviving on limited food, and dodging the LTTE and the Sri Lankan military.

On the night of July 22, 1990, they finally crossed the Palk Strait, getting off near Dhanushkodi on the Indian shore. The water, Mahendran still remembers, reached above his father's waist as he carried the children to land.

Thirty-six years later, Mahendran lives in Pudukkottai. His father, who was 42 when the family fled, died just seven

years later. Mahendran went to school in Tamil Nadu, studied at Loyola College in Chennai, and now sells furniture on instalments. Ask the 47-year-old where he comes from and his answer is still "Ceylon".

His son and daughter, he says, would answer differently: Tamil Nadu.

That gap between two generations is what Sri Lanka is seeking to bridge, removing this month a longstanding legal obstacle to the voluntary return of refugees who fled the civil war without valid passports or through unauthorised departure points.

As per a Cabinet decision by the Lankan government, re-



A house in one of the refugee camps in Tamil Nadu. EXPRESS

turnees whose Lankan nationality is established can enter through an authorised port after clearance by the State In-

telligence Service. Those cleared will not face prosecution under immigration law merely for having left the

country without authorisation during the war. It applies to all those who left before May 19, 2009, when the civil war ended.

This is a major leap for many refugees. As late as August 2025, four returnees were detained on arrival in Sri Lanka because they had originally left the country illegally.

The Lankan government's new decision has been welcomed by the UN as an important step towards "safe and dignified return" of its people.

But, for the nearly 90,000 Sri Lankan refugees in India, moving back is not an easy decision. More than 58,000 of them live in 103 camps spread across 29 districts of Tamil

Nadu, and another 30,000 outside the camps, with one special camp within the Tiruchi Central Prison complex.

The long road home

Sri Lanka is a difficult choice even though, more than three decades after many of them arrived in India, they continue to be registered with police and subject to periodic renewals, sometimes weekly. Those living in camps are allowed to leave the premises at 6 am but generally required to be back at 6 pm. There are curbs on travel outside Tamil Nadu.

Says Mahendran: "The important thing is not a warm welcome, but how the government

expects us to live. How do they expect us to survive, how do we buy food there?" A friend who returned eight years ago managed to find his feet in Lanka, he says, and the dream of "Ceylon" is always there. But Mahendran can't set aside questions about land, shelter, employment and his children's education.

"Should we go back and start a life from scratch, worse than a refugee life here?... Am I asking for too much? I don't know," he says.

While successive Lankan governments have offered returning refugees resettlement assistance, including with housing and livelihood, the

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[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

PM-Putin

“India has been an active and constructive member of the SCO since 2017. I look forward to advancing India’s vision for the region, anchored in Security, Connectivity and Opportunity, and to working with fellow members for a region free from the scourge of terrorism, separatism and extremism, which continue to threaten peace and stability in our neighbourhood and beyond.”

“I also look forward to meeting (Kyrgyzstan) President Sadyr Zhaparov and other SCO leaders, and to attend the Opening Ceremony of the 6th World Nomad Games, a celebration of the rich living heritage of Central Asia that India holds in deep respect,” he said.

The SCO comprises 10 member states: Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan; 15 Dialogue Partners: Armenia, Azerbaijan, Bahrain, Egypt, Cambodia, Kuwait, Laos, the Maldives, Myanmar, Nepal, Qatar, UAE, Saudi Arabia, Türkiye, and Sri Lanka; two Observers: Mongolia and Afghanistan.

The war in West Asia is ex-

pected to figure in the discussions, especially since Iran is a member of SCO.

India has been a member of the SCO since 2017 and Delhi’s priorities in SCO are based on what it has espoused in the 2018 summit – a ‘SECURE’ SCO, i.e., Security; Economy and Trade; Connectivity; Unity; Respect for Sovereignty and Territorial Integrity.

The war that followed US and Israeli strikes against Iran in February this year has become a global talking point on the respect for ‘sovereignty and territorial integrity’. For India, connectivity with Central Asia, through Iran, has been a subject of great interest.

In Bishkek, Iran will be in the room with Saudi Arabia and UAE and all eyes will be on the dynamics between these countries. For India too, this will be important. These countries are going to be in Delhi for the BRICS summit where the Indian side will try to bring some consensus on the war in West Asia. The BRICS Foreign Ministers meeting in Delhi in May had ended with no consensus on the war.

It will be important to see how the Indian delegation navigates given that Pakistan too will be present at the SCO. India has always put forward its policy of

“fight against terrorism, separatism, extremism”, describing them as “three evils”.

During the period of its membership, India has held the chair of the SCO Council of Heads of Government in 2020 and of the SCO Council of Heads of State during 2022-2023. And, one of India’s priorities has been “Central Asia as Core of SCO”, and that will be tested in Bishkek again because Tajikistan has put its hat in the ring for the UNSC non-permanent member’s elections for 2028-29. India is also contesting for the same spot.

Given that the theme of the SCO Heads of State Meeting this year is “25th anniversary of the SCO: strengthening stability, expanding cooperation for further joint development”, the Indian side will be looking at Kyrgyz Republic’s negotiating strategy to come up with joint documents.

According to sources, there are 27 documents proposed to be signed/adopted, including the Bishkek Declaration, Protocol to Amend SCO Charter, MoUs (Climate, Information Sphere, and Artificial Intelligence, Protocol to amend the Agreement on Combating Crime, Regulations on Universal Center and Anti Drug Center, Regulations on SCO ‘Partner’, Cooperation between SCO and African Union.

New notes

BRBNMPL has underlined an “immediate” requirement and indicated an approximate requirement for 68,000 reams of polymer substrate for printing Indian banknotes. Each ream should consist of 500 sheets of polymer film with samples to be provided with the bids.

The samples will be tested in various climatic zones and those found eligible will be allowed to apply for the final BRBNMPL tender. In a corrigendum published before the deadline, the BRBNMPL clarified that bidders were not required to provide proof of their financial standing at this “qualifying” stage.

It is learnt that in the running for the polymer substrate EOI is Cosmo First, the largest Indian exporter of BOPP (bi-

axially oriented polypropylene) and a major supplier to De La Rue. The world’s largest banknote dealer, the UK-headquartered De La Rue claims to have helped several countries make the transition to the polymer option which it says is cleaner, greener, more secure and durable.

Those in the know say Cosmo First has listed the currency major as its “technical partner” which will provide security features in its polymer substrate as required by BRBNMPL.

The other foreign major which is learnt to have bid is Australia-based CCL Secure, another pioneer in polymer banknote supplies. CCL Secure currently supplies polymer solutions to 40 central banks. It flags features to prevent counterfeiting and claims that the banknotes last six times

longer than cotton-based currency paper.

The CCL Secure website states it offers solutions to countries to use a combination of polymer based and conventional currency paper sourced from cotton pulp. This is what the RBI is said to be currently proposing for India, with polymer banknotes being introduced initially in Rs 10 and Rs 20 denominations.

Vietnam was among the countries importing polymer substrate from CCL Secure, but three years ago a private Hanoi-based company, Q&T Hi-tech Polymer Company Limited, began supplying banknotes domestically, maintaining there is a 78% lifecycle savings over cotton paper currency. The company is expanding its footprint out of Vietnam and, according to industry sources, has also bid for the BRBNMPL EOI.

SC judge

Hearing a challenge to the directive, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant questioned the BCI’s intervention saying “BCI is unnecessarily taking action. If the students have a cause to protest, they have the right to protest. Students might have written a letter to me. It’s a dialogue between students and me. Who are they (BCI) to unnecessarily raise an issue?”

On Saturday, speaking at the convocation of NLU D’s undergraduate and PhD programmes, Justice B V Nagarathna said bar councils must introspect on their role in upholding professional ethics, observing that “when a bar council does not earn the respect of its members, it is not a good sign for the legal profession”.

Justice Bhuyan said legal education must equip students not only with knowledge of the law but also with the ability to question established assumptions and examine whether the law, in a given situation, has served the cause of justice. An academic environment, he said, does not require everyone

to reach the same conclusion and must allow different views to be expressed, examined and debated.

Speaking about dissent in a constitutional democracy, he said, “A democratic society cannot be built on the edifice that everyone will think alike. It is built on the understanding that differences will exist and that those differences must be accommodated within the broader constitutional framework.”

The Constitution, he said, “does not seek uniformity of thought” and instead creates a framework in which people with different beliefs and opinions can participate in public life with equal dignity. “Constitutional democracy therefore requires the State to listen to the citizens, the citizens to listen to one another, to have institutions that are accountable and a society that does not treat every dissent as a threat,” he said.

Describing tolerance as a constitutional value, Justice Bhuyan said democracy becomes meaningful when different voices can coexist and be heard with dignity. He said the strength of a democracy is reflected not only in how it treats

popular opinions but also in how it responds to views that are unpopular or inconvenient. “An intolerant mind, by its very nature, is at odds with the spirit of the Constitution. It is a manifestation of another form of violence.”

He said the Constitution protects the freedom to speak, think and believe differently, and that intolerance begins to undermine that framework when dissent is treated as something that must be “silenced, rejected or punished”.

Calling universities the starting point for independent thought, he said these were spaces where ideas could be examined and questioned through debate. “If we want a democratic society that respects liberty and difference, that culture has to begin from the universities,” he said. “For a student of law, these ideas cannot remain merely academic. The law constantly places us in situations where one person’s freedom may appear to conflict with another, where the exercise of power must be balanced against individual rights, and where an established position may have to be examined in the light of constitutional principles,” he said.

Tashkent

in Tashkent for bilateral talks.

Modi was conferred Uzbekistan’s highest award for foreign leaders, Oliy Darajali Do’slik Order, which he dedicated to the “enduring bond” between India and Uzbekistan.

“Uzbekistan is at the heart of Central Asia, and at the heart of India’s engagement with the region. There is a deep alignment between the thinking and aspirations of India and Uzbekistan. Youth, innovation, inclusive growth, and modern technology lie at the core of both ‘Yangi Uzbekistan’ and ‘Viksit Bharat 2047’.

Guided by this shared vision, we are working for the welfare of the people of both our nations,” Modi said.

“This year marks the 15th anniversary of our Strategic Partnership. On this special occasion, we have decided to elevate

our relationship to the status of a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. Today, we have prepared an ambitious agenda to advance this new phase of our partnership with rapid momentum and concrete results,” he said.

Mirziyoyev said his country is determined to boost ties with India in diverse sectors. “We are aiming to advance cooperation in sectors such as energy, culture, critical minerals, pharmaceuticals, jewellery and agriculture.”

“We will prepare roadmaps for each of these sectors; specific teams from India will visit here, and our teams will travel to India, enabling us to clearly define our objectives in these fields,” he said.

In his remarks, Modi said, “We will also establish a long-term arrangement for the supply of uranium.”

Later, Sibi George, Secretary (West) in the Ministry of External Affairs, said, “Positive discussions have happened on long-term arrangement of

supply of uranium to India. We are closing in on the signing of an agreement very shortly.” New Delhi has been looking to procure uranium from Uzbekistan civilian nuclear power programme.

The two sides also set a target of USD 5 billion bilateral trade by 2030. India is among the top 10 trading partners of Uzbekistan. Bilateral trade in 2025-26 stood close to USD 1 billion.

On defence and security ties, he said, “The close defence and security cooperation between our nations reflects our deep mutual trust. In the future, we will promote direct linkages, co-production, and co-development between the defence industries of both countries.”

On terrorism, he said, “We believe that terrorism, extremism and separatism pose serious challenges to the entire region. Maintaining a policy of zero tolerance against these threats has been, and will continue to be, our shared resolve.”

According to the joint statement, the leaders “unequivo-

cally condemned terrorism, including cross-border terrorism, in all its forms and manifestations, reiterated zero tolerance approach to terrorism and rejected justification of terrorism on any ground whatsoever”. “Leaders called for concerted actions against terrorist entities and for disrupting terrorism financing networks, safe havens and infrastructure. Leaders stressed that those responsible for terrorism should be held accountable and their perpetrators, their backers, facilitators and affiliates should be brought to justice,” it stated.

“The Leaders expressed satisfaction with the activities of the Joint Working Group on Military Cooperation, wherein new avenues of cooperation in the defence industrial domain are being explored. They welcomed the successful conduct of the Uzbekistan-India Joint Military Exercise ‘Dustlik’, the latest of which was held in Namangan Region, Uzbekistan, in April 2026,” it said.

MEA spokesperson Randhir

Jaiswal said, “The talks focussed on expanding cooperation in the areas of trade and investment, infrastructure, critical minerals, mining, defence and security, innovation, agriculture, pharmaceuticals, health, information technology, digital public infrastructure including UPI and education, among others.”

“Both leaders witnessed the exchange of several MoUs and agreements covering a wide range of areas, including mining, culture, education, tourism, ayurveda, among others. A Letter of Intent for the restoration and conservation of the Buddhist sites of Fayaz Tepa and Kara Tepa in Uzbekistan was also agreed upon,” he said. A total of 11 pacts were signed during the visit.

Besides 11 pacts, announcement of a grant of USD 1 million for afforestation in the Aral Sea region, 100 Lal Bahadur Shastri Scholarship for Hindi Language Scholars and a ICCR Sanskrit Chair at Tashkent State University of Oriental Studies were made.

‘Can’t stop looking...’

the flash floods on Bhotekoshi river hit his village, his wife, son and daughter were able to run to higher ground to escape the raging waters, but his elderly parents were not.

Five days after the devastating floods, thousands of Nepalese security personnel remain neck-deep in search and rescue missions. There is also a parallel effort — mounted by the family members of those missing.

Thousands like Adhikari have set out on desperate search missions of their own as they scour the steep Himalayan valleys and the scores of villages dotting them for some sign of their family members, either dead or alive.

A few days ago, there was

some discussion among his neighbours of three bodies being discovered on the roof of a building in the village. Adhikari’s hopes had risen and he had made his way to the spot as quickly as he could, on bike and on foot through the forest, but they were not his parents.

“I just want to find their bodies so that I can start their last rites and give them a peaceful send-off from this world,” said a red-eyed Adhikari, sitting inside the Suryagarhi Relief Camp. He has sent his wife and children to Kathmandu to stay with some relatives. “But I can’t stop looking, at least not so soon... I will keep looking for another two weeks, and then start the final rites if I can’t find them by then,” he said.

Railways

the Indian Railways is implementing a project under HAM, a variant of Public Private Partnership (PPP).

The total bid project cost of six lines is Rs 15,976 crore and the total capital cost covering the entire concession period (which is 17-19 years) is Rs 40,866 crore. The key commodities on these routes are primarily coal, along with iron ore, bauxite, coke, chemical manure, cement and food grains.

The PPPAC had earlier accorded in-principle approval to these projects under the Design, Build, Finance, Operate, and Transfer (DBFOT) model. Later, based on market feedback, the ministry switched to HAM. Under this, Indian Railways will pay 40% of the bid project cost as grant during the construction period and the private party will finance the remaining 60% of the cost.

“Subsequently, based on market feedback, the Ministry of Railways (MoR) revisited the project structure and proposed their implementation under the HAM. Under the proposed HAM structure, MoR would bear the traffic and tariff risks and provide 40% of the bid project cost as grant during the construction period,” say the minutes of the meeting held on August 1.

The construction of all six projects is proposed to commence from April 2028.

Once the line becomes operational, Indian Railways will pay back the remaining 60% through annuity or instal-

ments, plus interest on annuity. Apart from this, it will also make regular payments to the concessionaire for maintenance of stations, tracks and other assets. Railways will operate trains and collect all freight revenue. It will also bear traffic and tariff risks — which means that if freight-loading or revenue is lower than what’s targeted, the private party will not be penalised.

“The RFP (bid document) would specify the applicable conditions including the minimum tenure of the agreement, the roles and responsibilities of the EPC (Engineering, Procurement and Construction) contractor, and the circumstances in which such arrangements would be permitted,” the Indian Railways said.

A senior railway official said the bidding for the projects is likely to take place in the next financial year, 2027-28. Apart from these six projects, there are 49 other projects in the pipeline for execution under PPP mode. The total cost of these projects are around Rs 1.80 lakh crore.

The official added that a total of 18 projects worth Rs 16,686 crore have been completed through the PPP model in the Indian Railways and seven projects worth Rs 16,362 crore are under implementation, including coal and port connectivity projects. The Indian Railways recently added HAM, along with Development Partner (DPM), in its participative policy. The transition to newer models like HAM is its attempt at overcoming financial bottlenecks and attracting long-term private sector capital in infrastructure development.

Sri Lanka

latest Cabinet decision does not spell out any new package.

A senior expert who has worked closely on the repatriation of Sri Lankan refugees for nearly three decades says the response has been tepid. Only about 400 refugees have returned over the past two years, the expert says, with just 36 currently on the waiting list, having applied over the past nine months.

“After the Cabinet decision in Sri Lanka, there is no surge reported in applications,” he says.

The reluctance of refugees to return has less to do with immigration issues than Lanka’s economic crisis and uncertainty over livelihoods, says the expert. Only around 15-20% of refugees own land back in Lanka.

Even the modest financial assistance available for return is shrinking. The repatriation grant of Rs 11,250 per person is now Rs 8,000 because of the

UN’s funding crunch, he says.

The longer trend is striking. Annual returns to Sri Lanka fell from 1,673 in 2011 to 1,264 in 2012, 711 in 2013, 396 in 2014 and 452 in 2015. They rose to 852 in 2016 and 1,520 in 2017, before falling again to 1,283 in 2018, and 963 in 2019. The numbers collapsed thereafter: 196 in 2020, 96 in 2021, 208 in 2022, 326 in 2023, 203 in 2024 and just 92 in 2025.

But 246 people belonging to 46 families returned between July 2025 and February 2026 without facing any official push-back, demonstrating Lanka’s new resolve.

Too much change, or too little?

The political situation in Sri Lanka is much more favourable towards Tamils than when they fled. But, apprehensions remain. A visible military presence remains in the north, where the Tamils are concentrated, and Tamil groups continue to complain of surveillance, unresolved land disputes and restrictions around political

Nepal toll

in from districts including Rasuwa, Nuwakot and Dhading.

An ice-rock avalanche following a glacial collapse near the Nepal-Tibet border sent a torrent of water, mud and debris downstream, wiping out towns and villages, damaging crucial infrastructure and washing away hydropower stations through northern and central Nepal on August 26.

The death toll from the flash floods rose to 788 on Sunday, with more bodies being recovered. More than 2,500 people still remain missing, while nearly 9,500 people were rescued, according to the Na-

tional Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA).

“Our mortuary has more than four times (the number of) bodies as against its capacity. It will not be possible to make space for more,” a doctor with the Institute of Medicine, the only government hospital in Nepal with a mortuary facility, said.

The maximum number of bodies, around 250, have been recovered so far from Chitwan district. “We are going for mass burial, but will preserve DNA in case relatives want to perform rituals based on their traditions and religious practices,” a government official said.

Families, on Sunday, crowded hospitals searching

for missing relatives as rescuers continued digging through mud and debris amid intermittent rainfall and renewed concerns over rising river levels.

In a rescue operation at Timure border town, an Armed Police Force team searching the wreckage of a collapsed security post heard a child’s cries. The Kathmandu Post newspaper reported that the rescuers dug through the debris and pulled out a six-year-old girl alive.

For those pulled from the rubble, swept towards hillsides or stranded overnight in forests, surviving the flood was only the first part of the ordeal. For thousands of families still searching, the wait for news continues. WITH PTI INPUTS

FIR against Rahul

across India and exposed the “BJP-RSS mindset.” Gandhi had reiterated that the Congress wants an FIR filed under the SC/ST Act against those responsible for the Haldwani ceremony.

Superintendent of Police, City, Haldwani, Manoj Kumar Katyal told *The Indian Express* that the FIR against Gandhi was lodged based on a complaint by Amit Kumar, a resident of Jawahar Nagar Colony in Haldwani.

In his complaint, filed on Sunday, Kumar, 26, claimed that he is a member of the Valmiki community, and that he, along with other Scheduled Caste community members, participated in the “cleanliness drive and religious ritual” held

at Ramlila Maidan in Haldwani on August 11. He claimed the act had no connection with any individual or caste.

“Despite that, Rahul Gandhi, in a press conference on August 29, without any verification, called it an act related to ‘chuwachhoot’ (untouchability) and a crime against Scheduled Castes, and demanded an FIR against those who participated in that ritual,” Kumar stated in the complaint.

He said that he himself belongs to the Valmiki community, but has been portrayed as someone who indulges in untouchability and is anti-Dalit. Kumar claimed enmity and tensions had increased between communities after Gandhi’s allegations.

On the basis of his complaint, the police lodged the FIR against Gandhi under BNS section 196 (promoting enmity between different groups on grounds of religion, race, and doing acts prejudicial to maintenance of harmony), section 299 (deliberate and malicious acts, intended to outrage religious feelings of any class by insulting its religion or religious beliefs) and section 3 (1) (Q) of the SC/ST Act, which pertains to giving false or frivolous information to a public servant, causing that public servant to use their power to harm or annoy a member of a Scheduled Caste or a Scheduled Tribe.

On Saturday, Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Dhama had responded to Gandhi, saying the Congress was a “mudda viheen” (issue-less) party and that those who conducted the havan were not BJP workers.

possible, he would have considered remaining, Elangeswaran adds. But, a lifetime of remaining under official watch and suspicion of being a LTTE sympathiser has left him tired.

Plus, unlike Mahendran, Elangeswaran has land in Sri Lanka, even if abandoned and encroached upon. “We have to go and reoccupy it,” he says.

Elangeswaran’s daughter Juvitha, 27, has never visited Sri Lanka. A graduate in English literature, her entire life and her friend circle are here. Still, she wants to leave.

“There are no jobs for me here. I cannot get a government job, and private jobs offer a pittance. I hope to settle down in Sri Lanka, even if the first years are difficult,” Juvitha says.

The 27-year-old doesn’t hesitate about what Lanka means to her: “My native place.”

Mahendran hopes he can offer the choice to his children too. Or, he says: “My dad was a refugee. I am one, my children and grandchildren are also going to be refugees.”

Skywatch

Forecast: August 31, 2026

Partly cloudy sky

MAX: 35-37

2.5°C above normal

MIN: 25-27

1.5°C below normal

Sunrise: 5:59 AM (September 1)

Sunset: 6:45 PM (August 31)

Moonrise: 7:54 PM (August 31)

Moonset: 8:47 AM (September 1)

AQI Tracker

Rohini

Moderate

AQI: 151

Wazirpur

Poor

AQI: 242

JNU

Moderate

AQI: 105

Anand Vihar

Severe

AQI: 420

● Good (0-50)

● Satisfactory (51-100)

● Moderate (101-200)

● Poor (201-300)

● Very Poor (301-400)

● Severe (401-500)

TEACHER SERVED NOTICE, POCSO CASE REGISTERED

School attendant held after ‘assault’ on child

Pragynesh
New Delhi, August 30

AN ATTENDANT at a play school in north-east Delhi was arrested and a teacher was served a notice by the police, after a three-year-old boy was allegedly “assaulted” at the centre, the police said on Sunday.

Police said that a case under relevant sections of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act and the Juvenile Justice Act has been registered against the attendant and the teacher. According to the police, the child has undergone a medico-legal test and a probe is underway.

The police added that the incident came to light on August 16 when the child’s parents noticed “bruises” on his arms and face. “On August 16, I saw bruises on his face and arms. Two days later, when he came home, he started vomiting. We took him to an ENT (Ear, Nose, and Throat)

specialist. The doctor said his eyes were swollen. Some tests were run and it was found that his eardrums were damaged,” the boy’s father told *The Indian Express*.

The father also claimed that once he and his wife approached the school authorities, they allegedly refuted their claims, but “reluctantly agreed to share the CCTV footage”.

“On August 26, we saw the footage. About 9.45 am on August 18, he was tied to a chair. He was tied for three hours. He managed to open it... then was beaten up by the attendant. On August 17, he was slapped by the teacher,” the child’s father said.

The family claimed that even on August 16, when the child was taken for a routine height measurement exercise, he allegedly “punched and slapped unnecessarily”. “They were rude to my wife when she confronted them,” said the father.

The FIR in the case names

four persons, including the owner of the school and the principal, as the accused.

On August 27, the family got a medico-legal certificate for the child and then got an FIR filed.

“He is so scared that he is not even going to the washroom. He hasn’t bathed since we took him out of the school. He refuses to leave his room. When we asked them why they roughed up my child, they said he was ‘hyperactive’. Seriously?,” said the father.

Delhi police sources, meanwhile, said that they are questioning the attendant, adding that the teacher will be questioned soon. Other school administrators, including the principal, will also be asked to cooperate in the probe.

“What if he had died? I have been shown CCTV recordings for just three days. I have no clue what they did to him before that,” the father also said.

The school authorities were unavailable for a comment.

POLICE SAY SEARCH FOR A RELATIVE OF THE VICTIM IS ON

Accused gestured to her, she went as she knew him: Father of six-year-old who was raped and killed in Greater Noida

Pragynesh
New Delhi, August 30

IN A narrow lane in a Greater Noida village, 20-odd men sat on Sunday afternoon.

Among them was the father of a six-year-old girl who was allegedly kidnapped, raped and murdered on Friday by a man the family had known for years. Police had killed the accused in an encounter on Saturday night.

The father, who runs a family-owned business, said he had seen the girl last on Friday afternoon.

“She was playing outside. But when I came out to check on her, she was not there. We searched for her everywhere, but in vain,” he said.

Family members and neighbours of the child approached the police on Friday evening.

Officers scanned footage

The accused, a friend of victim’s relative, was killed in a police encounter on Saturday

from a CCTV camera near the entrance to the lane in which the child was playing.

Police said they spotted a man, who was later identified as a friend of a relative of the child.

“We saw him in the CCTV footage. *Usne bachhiko ishara kiya kuchh gali ke baahar se.* (He gestured to the girl from a distance.) He was a familiar face, so she went with him,” the girl’s father said.

On Saturday morning, police reached the house of the child’s relative where the man in the footage lived on rent, an

officer said.

They apprehended him, but they did not know then what had happened to the little girl.

After questioning the suspect, police found the girl’s body near a pond in the village in the afternoon.

“They took him to the pond next to farmland. He would still not tell them where he had dumped my daughter’s body. Later, he broke down and revealed the exact spot, after which her body was retrieved,” the father said, crying.

Police said the accused was questioned after the body was recovered. He allegedly confessed to killing the girl using a knife after raping her, police said.

He hid the body in some shrubs about 6-7 km away, they said.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Central Noida) Shail-

endra Kumar Singh said: “On Saturday night, he was taken to the area [where he had dumped the body] for the second time. The knife he used to kill the girl was recovered from the shrubs at his instance.”

“While coming back, he pushed an officer, took out a pistol he had hidden in the bushes there and fired at the police team. One of the officers sustained a gunshot injury. Police fired in retaliation, and the accused was hit by a bullet. He was rushed to a nearby hospital where he was declared dead,” DCP Singh said.

A police officer said that the accused sustained the injury in his chest, which proved fatal. The injured police officer is under treatment, police said.

Talking about the victim’s relative, a police officer said, “We are still looking for him... His role is yet to be ascertained.”

IIT-D students pause protest, cite progress on their demands

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, August 30

STUDENTS AT IIT Delhi, who have been protesting for a week over the alleged suicide of 31-year-old MSc Physics student Rishikesh Kumar on August 22, announced a pause in their on-ground mobilisation on Sunday, citing progress on their key demands, including the constitution of an external inquiry committee to probe the circumstances leading to his death.

The decision comes amid Kumar’s mother, Asha Poddar, declining any financial compensation, which had been one of the primary demands of the protesters. Instead, she has asked the institute to look into creating residential facilities for students navigating mental-health issues. This follows concerns raised by the family over Kumar’s access to hostel accommodation, including allegations that he was told there was no provision for “such children” to stay there.

Compensation had been a point of contention during the protests, with students demanding that Rs 1 crore be provided to Poddar. The administration had proposed a formula comprising Rs 6 lakh from its Benevolent Fund, reimbursement of medical expenses, and additional funds to be raised through voluntary contributions from the institute’s alumni and employee network.

Poddar, however, declined monetary compensation and instead asked the administration to consider assigning living quarters, or a section of living quarters, for students navigating mental-health issues, so that no student in need would be removed from campus.

IIT Delhi Director Rangan Banerjee said he would look into Poddar’s proposal, sources said. He also said the institute would explore how Kumar’s memory could be commemorated on campus, according to the students’ statement.

The protest was being held over the alleged suicide of an MSc Physics student. FILE

The proposal assumes significance as hostel accommodation at IIT Delhi is available to less than 50 per cent of the student population, with preference given to undergraduate students. While the institute has provided ground-floor room allotments and accessibility support for students with benchmark physical disabilities, it lacks dedicated residential facilities for students requiring sustained mental-health or psychiatric support.

In her police complaint on August 22, Poddar said the IIT Delhi administration did not allot her son a hostel room and that he was humiliated by the institute’s Dean. She said Kumar was told there was no provision for “such children” to stay in the hostel, and that the incident left him deeply distressed. She urged the police to investigate whether these circumstances were linked to his death.

The students said they would leave the matter of compensation between Kumar’s family and the IIT Delhi administration, and would support whatever decision the family reached.

Earlier this week, IIT Delhi Director Rangan Banerjee had also warned protesting students of disciplinary action, saying the situation had “escalated significantly” on the night of August 27.

In his August 28 communication to students, Banerjee alleged that between 10.30 pm and 12.30 am, protesters had extended their agitation into campus residential zones and

used “unsavoury, humiliating and threatening language” in slogans outside faculty housing.

In a statement on Sunday, students said the demonstrations were confined to main transit roads and that they did not enter residential hostel premises. The students added that they had also consciously decided against marching near Kailash and Himadri hostels, citing concerns over the privacy and safety of women students.

Further, they said their slogans were limited to appeals for institutional accountability and community support. According to the students, protesters did not attempt to enter residential blocks or hostels.

The students also alleged that they faced “disproportionate surveillance and police presence” during the protests. They alleged that Delhi Police personnel entered the campus in civilian clothes without authorisation from the IIT Delhi administration.

On the demand for resignations of senior officials, the administration said new appointments had already been made following the previous appointees’ tenures, while the inquiry committee would examine their roles in the alleged lapses.

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 30

THE DELHI government on Sunday said that over 100 acres of land has been reclaimed at the Okhla, Bhalswa and Ghazipur landfills after 2.16 crore metric tonnes of waste has been removed.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said that so far, around 70 lakh metric tonnes of waste has been processed at Okhla, leading to the reclamation of 35 acres of land. She said that at Bhalswa, the quantity of waste processed is around 102 lakh metric tonnes and 45 acres of land has been reclaimed. The numbers at Ghazipur stand at around 44 lakh metric tonnes of waste and 20 acres of land reclaimed.

This comes in the backdrop of civic authorities in Delhi setting up a timeline to clear legacy waste piled up over decades at landfills in the Capital. The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has set a goal of clearing the Okhla and Bhalswa landfills by December this year, and the Ghazipur landfill - the largest in the city - by December next year.

Speaking at a press conference on Sunday, Gupta said that the inert material being recovered after processing the waste is being put to use.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday. X/@GUPTA_REKHA

“It has been used for filling low-lying areas and preparing the base beneath roads. This has ensured not only the scientific processing of waste but also the utilisation of material recovered

Biomining involves excavating legacy waste, biologically treating it and separating recyclable and reusable materials, allowing portions of landfill land to be reclaimed. The MCD began biomining in 2019, after directions from the National Green Tribunal.

As per the civic body’s dashboard, over the last three days of the week, an average of 787 (tonnes per day) TPD of waste was lifted at Bhalswa, 575 TPD at Okhla and 3,382 TPD at Ghazipur. However, during the same period, an average of 4,243 TPD, 2,115 TPD, and 2,541 TPD were dumped in them respectively.

On Sunday, Gupta also said preparations have been completed for setting up four new Waste-to-Energy plants in Delhi.

Robbery at Alka Lamba’s father’s home in Capital

New Delhi: Congress leader Alka Lamba’s father’s home in west Delhi’s Tagore Garden was allegedly burgled, with three masked men breaking into the house and escaping with cash and jewellery, police said on Sunday.

The incident was alleged captured in a CCTV camera installed at the property, with the purported footage — showing masked men entering the premises and later fleeing on a motorcycle — going viral on social media platforms.

As per officers, the incident took place in C-Block, Tagore Garden, under Rajouri Garden police station area.

A case has been registered, and police are examining CCTV footage from the premises and surrounding areas to trace the suspects. PTI

MAURITIUS HIGH COMMISSION

NEW DELHI, INDIA

INVITATION TO TENDER

RENOVATION OF CHANCERY HOUSE AND STAFF RESIDENCE, CHANAKYAPURI, NEW DELHI, INDIA

PROCUREMENT REFERENCE: MAU/MOF/AND/ONB 01 of 2026-2027

The Mauritius High Commission, New Delhi invites sealed tenders from eligible and experienced contractors for the upgrading works of the Chancery House and Staff Residence located at Chanakypuri, New Delhi, India.

Scope of Works: Civil, architectural, electrical, mechanical, plumbing, fire protection, security, external and associated infrastructure works including demolition and alteration works, replacement and restoration of finishes, upgrading of building services, installation and commissioning of electrical and mechanical systems, fire protection installations, security systems, drainage improvements and all related works necessary for successful completion of the project.

ELIGIBILITY

1. The contractor must be a legally registered contractor in India with valid business registration, GST registration (where applicable), and required tax compliance.

2. The contractor should have experience in similar works for government buildings, embassies, or institutional buildings located in the diplomatic district during the last 10 years.

KEY DETAILS

Estimated Cost of Works

INR 175,000,000.00 (One Hundred and Seventy-five Million inclusive of all charges, GST, fees etc.)

Tender Security

INR 3,00,000.00 (Three Million)

Cost of Tender Document

INR 15,000.00 (Fifteen Thousand)

Performance Security

10% of Contract Amount

Time for Completion

750 days with sectional completion at 300 days

TENDER DOCUMENT

Tender documents may be obtained from: Mauritius High Commission Jeeva and Mary Mang, Chanakypuri, New Delhi, India upon payment of INR 15,000.00 (Non-refundable) by demand draft in favour of "Mauritius High Commission"

LAST DATE & TIME FOR SUBMISSION

30 October 2026 at 14:00 HRS

PLACE OF SUBMISSION

Mauritius High Commission Jeeva and Mary Mang, Chanakypuri, New Delhi, India

The Employer reserves the right to accept or reject any tender and is not bound to accept the lowest or any tender received.

GENERAL INSURANCE CORPORATION OF INDIA (Government of India Company)

CIN: L67200MH1972GOI016133 IRDAI REG. NO. 112

Regd. Office: 'Suraksha', 170, J. Tata Road, Churchgate, Mumbai-400020

Tel: +91-22-2286 7000 Fax: +91-22-2288 4010

Website: www.gicre.in E-mail: investors.gic@gicre.in

NOTICE TO THE SHAREHOLDERS OF 54th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING

NOTICE is hereby given that the 54th Annual General Meeting (54th AGM) of the members of General Insurance Corporation of India will be held on **Monday, 21st September 2026 at 3.00 p.m. (IST)** through Video Conferencing (VC)/Other Audio Visual Means (OVAM) to transact business, as set out in the Notice of the 54th AGM being sent through email.

In compliance with applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 and the rules notified thereunder and the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirement) Regulations, 2015, read with all applicable circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA") and the Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI"), the Corporation has decided to convene its 54th AGM through VC/OAVM and members can participate through VC/OAVM.

The Notice of the 54th AGM alongwith the Annual Report for the Financial Year 2025-26 is being sent only by electronic mode to those members whose email addresses are registered with the Depositories/Corporation/Registrar & Transfer Agent (RTA) in accordance with the Circulars issued by MCA and SEBI. Members may note that the notice of the AGM and the Annual Report for the financial year 2025-26 will also be available on the Corporation's website www.gicre.in and websites of the Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE Limited and National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com respectively. A letter providing the web-link for accessing the Annual Report will be sent to the Members whose email-id is not registered with the Depositories/Corporation/ Registrar & Transfer Agent (RTA). The Physical copy of the Annual Report shall be sent to the Members on specific request. Members can attend and participate in the AGM through Video Conferencing/Other Audio-Visual means (VC/OAVM) facility only. The instructions for joining the AGM are provided in the Notice of the AGM. Members attending the AGM through VC/OAVM shall be counted for the purpose of reckoning the quorum under Section 103 of the Companies Act, 2013.

The Corporation is providing remote e-voting facility ('remote e-voting') to all its members to cast their votes on all the resolutions set out in the Notice of the AGM. Additionally, the Corporation is providing the facility of voting through e-voting system during the AGM (e-voting). The Corporation has engaged the services of National Securities Depository Limited ('NSDL') for facilitating participation by the Members at the AGM through VC/OAVM including remote e-voting/e-voting. Detailed procedure for 'remote e-voting'/e-voting' is provided in the Notice of the AGM.

Members who have not yet registered their email addresses are requested to register the same with their DPs in case the shares are held by them in electronic form and with M/s KFin Technologies Limited in case the shares are held by them in physical form.

In view of the SEBI mandate for payment of Dividend only in electronic mode, Members are requested to update their KYC including bank details with their DPs in case the shares are held by them in electronic form and with M/s KFin Technologies Limited in case the shares are held by them in physical form for timely receipt of dividend.

For General Insurance Corporation of India

Sd/-

(Satheesh Kumar)

Company Secretary

Place: Mumbai

Dated: 30.08.2026

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CAN INDIA AND BANGLADESH

Find Common Ground Again ?

Pinak Ranjan Chakravarty

Former Indian High Commissioner to Bangladesh

In conversation with

Shubhajit Roy

Diplomatic Editor, The Indian Express

How much does Sheikh Hasina’s shadow impact ties?

How does PM Tarique Rahman look at the current situation?

How can India and Bangladesh reset and repair ties?

Should India be worried about the security situation in Bangladesh?

Can Delhi and Dhaka work on economic and development projects?

How do China and Pakistan view and influence the current situation in Bangladesh?

02 Sept 2026, 6:00 PM

Join us on Zoom

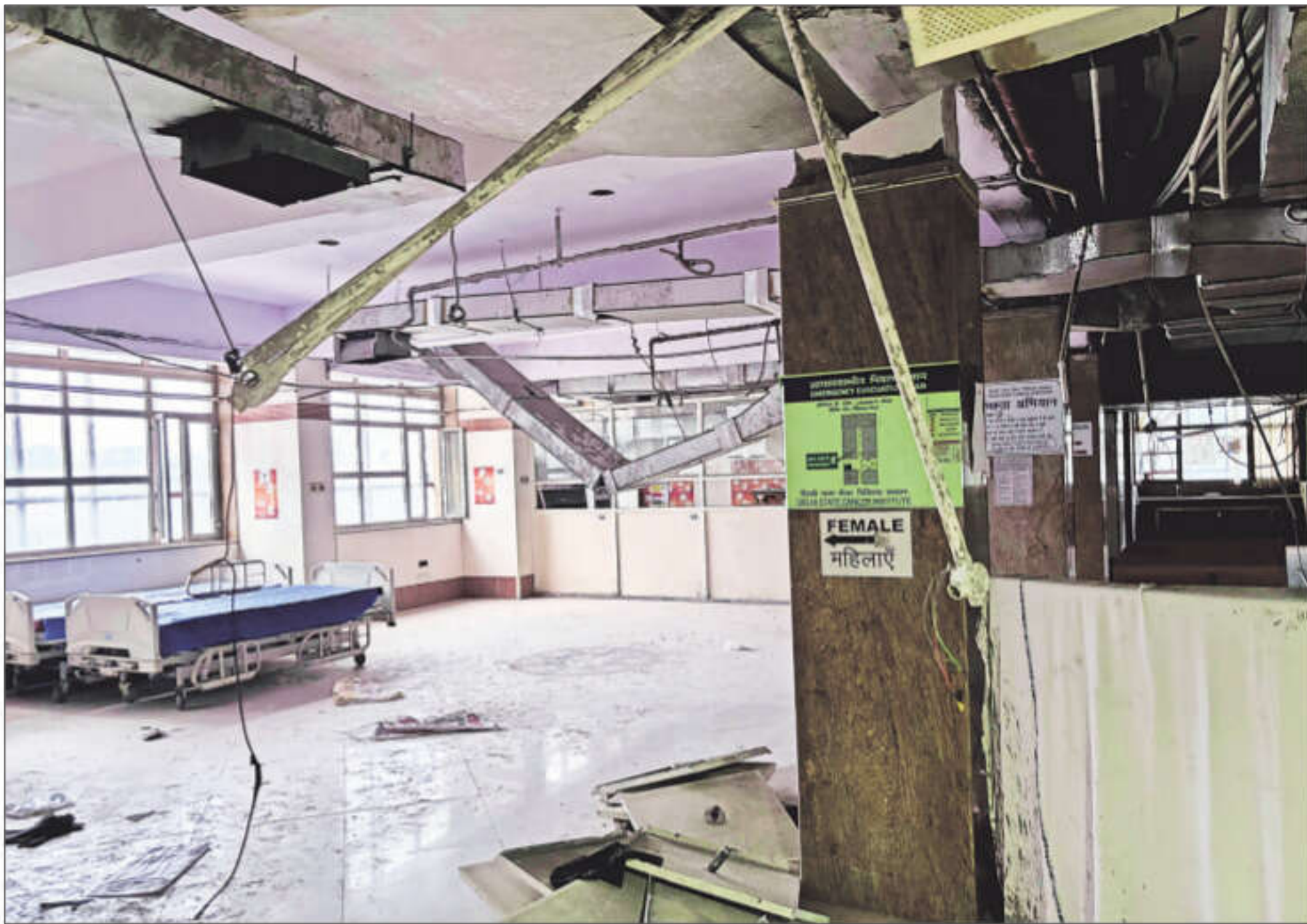
The Indian EXPRESS

JOURNALISM OF COURAGE

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New Delhi



A section on the second floor of Delhi State Cancer Institute lying in ruins. TABSHIR SHAMS

DELHI'S CANCER CARE CRISIS

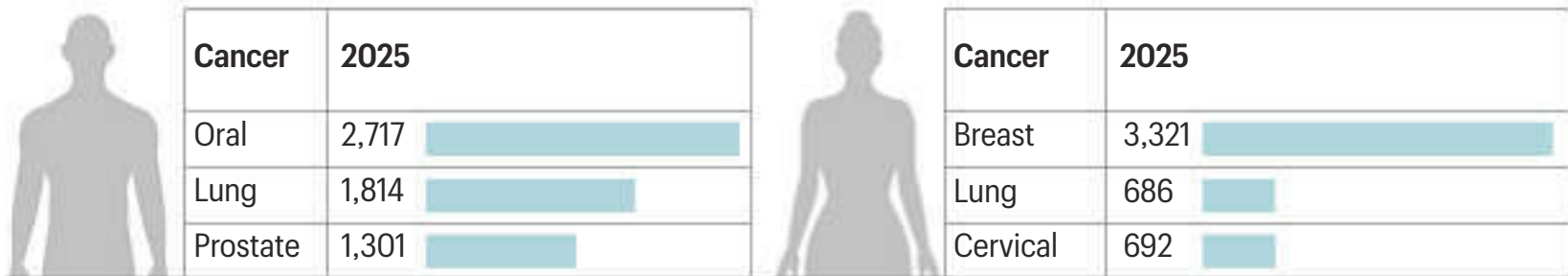
At Delhi State Cancer Institute, expensive equipment lies unused amid staff shortages. **TABSHIR SHAMS** and **SOHINI GHOSH** report on how this is pushing patients into mounting out-of-pocket expenses and delays in care

• CANCER-CARE EQUIPMENT: CRORES SPENT, MACHINES UNUSED

Equipment	Cost	Current status	What it is used for	Cost in private sector
Dual-head Gamma Camera + SPECT	₹11 crore	Unused; under evaluation	Advanced imaging, treatment monitoring, radiation therapy simulation	₹8,000–25,000 per test
PET-CT Scanner	₹21 crore	Unused; under evaluation	Cancer detection, staging, treatment monitoring and response assessment	₹8,000–24,000 per scan
PET Cyclotron	₹15.42 crore+	Unused; manpower shortage	Produces short-lived radioactive isotopes for PET diagnosis/treatment	—
DNA/RNA Extractor	₹30.90 lakh	Non-functional; awaiting repair directions	Extracts genetic material for PCR, sequencing and cancer mutation testing	~₹20,000 per cancer panel
Dual Photon Energy Linear Accelerator	₹9.2 crore	Non-functional since 2020	Delivers high-power X-rays to target cancer cells while sparing healthy tissue	₹2–3 lakh per treatment course

₹56.93 cr+ : Approximate cost of the five equipment **COST TO PATIENTS** Services that could have been provided through these machines instead have to be sought at private centres, where individual tests or treatment courses can cost thousands to lakhs.

CANCER IN DELHI: WHAT THE DATA SHOW



SOURCES: **DELHI CANCER FIGURES (2023–25):** MINISTRY OF HEALTH & FAMILY WELFARE, GOVERNMENT OF INDIA, PARLIAMENTARY REPLY, 2025; **NATIONAL CANCER ESTIMATE:**

NATIONAL CANCER REGISTRY PROGRAMME (NCRP); **CANCER REPORTING-RATE RANKING:** NATIONAL LIBRARY OF MEDICINE (NLM), 2025; **DELHI CANCER REGISTRY NETWORK:** DELHI

CANCER REGISTRY, AIIMS DELHI. **IMPORTANT:** THE 175+ GOVERNMENT CENTRES AND 250 PRIVATE HOSPITALS/NURSING HOMES DESCRIBE THEMSELVES

AS CENTRES/HOSPITALS CONTRIBUTING CANCER-RELATED DATA TO THE DELHI CANCER REGISTRY, RATHER THAN SAYING ALL OF THEM HAVE DEDICATED CANCER DEPARTMENTS.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

Most common cancer among men	Oral — 2,717 cases (2025)
Most common cancer among women	Breast — 3,321 cases (2025)
Second most common cancer in Delhi	Oral cancer
Fastest rise among women, 2023–25	Lung cancer — +13.6%
India's estimated cancer burden, 2022	14.6 lakh cases

A recent audit of 26 govt hospitals, ordered by the Delhi High Court, found medical equipment lying unused across the Capital's public health system

175+

Major government hospital centres contributing cancer data

250

Private hospitals & nursing homes contributing cancer data

ment, I was told the test was not available,” said her son, Mohan. A PET-CT at a private centre can cost between Rs 8,000 and Rs 30,000. Mohan is a daily-wage labourer. A Rs 12,000 scan, he said, would eat up nearly three-quarters of his monthly income. “They are asking me to get the test done at a private centre,” he said. “The security guard said he could get it done at a discounted price of Rs 12,000. But how can I afford it?”

Across the road from DSCI, in the DDA market at Pocket E, those private centres have become part of the hospital's ecosystem. A cluster of diagnostic centres has sprung up around the hospital, catering in part to patients sent there for tests.

At one of the diagnostic centres, a staff member described the routine. “We get two to three patients from DSCI a day. For a PET-CT, we offer a special discounted price of Rs 8,000. They deposit Rs 1,000 at the counter, and the next day, we arrange an ambulance. The patient comes to DDA market, and we take them to the testing centre,” he said.

Some patients, however, specifically ask to have the scan done at another centre, considered one of the best. “The price then rises to Rs 22,000,” he said.



Pocket E, DDA market where a cluster of medical shops and diagnostic centres have come up around DSCI. SOHINI GHOSH

For patients like Sarita, the cost is harder to bear because DSCI has the machines to do the scan. They are simply lying idle.

According to records submitted to the High Court, DSCI's Department of Nuclear Medicine has three high-end machines installed in 2017 at a cost of \$6.3 million, plus Rs 4.06 crore in local and turnkey costs. One, a medical cyclotron used to produce isotopes for PET scans, has been sitting unused since 2018.

“The radioactive sugar molecule has a short life. It decays quickly and requires specialised handling,” the official said. “The machine was operational until 2018 but has been unused since then because of a lack of

qualified manpower. We are filling these positions now.”

Two other sophisticated imaging machines, used to guide cancer treatment and track how patients respond to radiotherapy, are also sitting idle and under evaluation: a dual-head gamma camera with SPECT capabilities and a PET scanner integrated with a multidetector, multislice CT scanner.

It is not only expensive equipment that lies unused. Parts of the hospital itself have been left to deteriorate.

On the second floor, across from the private rooms, a section of the hospital lies in ruins. It was more than 150 patients were treated each day. Now, it stands abandoned. A warning on the door reads: “Don't enter without permission.” Inside, steel vents hang loose from the ceiling. Beds sit unused. Wires and pipes dangle from the ceiling to the floor. Plastic waste is scattered across the room, while dust has accumulated on the floor. “Due to a lack of medical supplies and manpower, this facility is shut,” a source said.

The staff shortage

At DSCI in Dilshad Garden, there are 236 beds: 169 inpatient beds, 29 for observation

and 38 chemotherapy recliners.

But patient numbers have fallen sharply, from around 1,500 a day to about 500, sources said, largely due to staff shortages. More than 40% of DSCI's 814 sanctioned posts are vacant, as per data shared by hospital sources. Even the positions being filled are often temporary. The latest recruitment drive, with interviews held on August 5, selected or waitlisted 13 senior residents across departments. Their appointments are for 44 days, extendable under institute rules.

“These temporary posts create a sense of instability in the careers of young oncologists,” a source said. “Hence, they are not invested and quit the hospital within a few months for more stable and attractive jobs.”

For doctors who have watched the institute change, the effects are no longer confined to staffing charts.

“The treatment is compromised, and the turnaround time for patients increases,” said a senior doctor. “The institute was built with patient care at its centre. There was a time when even if a patient came at 2 am, we would not turn them away. Now there is a cap of around 25 to 30 patients per doctor per day. The vacancies need to be filled, but bureaucratic hurdles have made that difficult.”

Another senior doctor, who was directly involved in the administration, remembers a different DSCI — its most successful years, between 2006 and 2015. “We drew such a large number of patients, not only from neighbouring states but also abroad, that we had planned to expand it by adding another 1,000 beds ... We wanted to make this the largest cancer-care facility in the country.”

Then, the doctor said, came 2019. “We drastically started witnessing its downfall,” the doctor said. “A sudden vacuum of leadership was created, followed by a musical-

At DSCI, the consequences of medical equipment lying unused are being felt in patient care — and in the bills patients are left to pay

chair arrangement that resulted in the present unfortunate situation.” The doctor alleged that there was a perception the changes were being made “deliberately to benefit private centres”.

Fight against time

For patients, the consequences are increasingly visible. Many are being referred to other hospitals altogether — some of which provide treatment free of cost.

Take Sunita Ghai's case. In 2025, when the 70-year-old was diagnosed with uterine cancer, her son, Nikhil Ghai, a photographer from East Delhi, took her to DSCI. The hospital could not provide the radiation therapy she needed and referred her to a private hospital run by a public charitable trust because of the “non-availability of the facility.”

“She was treated for free,” Nikhil said. The reason: Eight items in the hospital's radiotherapy department reached the end of their usable life and were lying idle on the premises for years. Among them is a dual-photon-energy linear accelerator, which uses high-powered X-rays at two energy levels to destroy cancer cells. A course of treatment using such a machine can cost Rs 2–3 lakh at a private centre. DSCI bought the machine for Rs 9.2 crore in 2007. It has been non-functional since 2020, officials said.

Now, Ghai and his mother are back at DSCI. Fluid has built up in Sunita's lungs, and she has been advised to undergo a minor surgery. After spending six days in a private hospital's ICU, the family has exhausted its savings, leaving Ghai with little choice but to return to the government hospital.

The family has been waiting outside a room marked “Minor OT” for hours. “I could not find a wheelchair for my mother... Why should the facility open at 2 pm instead of its regular hours? Cancer patients are fighting against time. It took two weeks to get the biopsy results here.”

At DSCI, patients are fighting that clock in more ways than one — waiting for tests, waiting for treatment and, increasingly, waiting for the hospital itself to function.



The investment-related agreements made with the industry groups during the investor conference are now rapidly coming to the ground. This is also creating new employment opportunities in Uttarakhand. We are providing all possible assistance to set up industries. With strong infrastructure and peaceful environment, Uttarakhand has emerged as the choice of investors.

Pushkar Singh Dhami, chief minister

The Uttarakhand government has unveiled a comprehensive action plan to bolster the Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises (MSME) sector, with a focus on positioning the state as a global hub for startups, green industries, and high-quality local products. The new MSME policy emphasises sustainable, inclusive, and employment-generating enterprises, while ensuring ease of doing business for investors.

MSMES AT THE CORE OF STATE ECONOMY

Micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs) are the backbone of Uttarakhand's economy, driving employment, local enterprise and value creation. The government's renewed focus on the sector is encouraging startups that harness local resources, alongside investments in renewable energy, green industries and clean manufacturing. By strengthening infrastructure, easing business processes and promoting local enterprise, these initiatives are attracting fresh investment, expanding manufacturing and creating new employment opportunities. Together, they are enabling MSMEs to contribute more strongly to economic growth, livelihoods and inclusive development across the state.

POLICY PUSH AND ACTION PLAN

To accelerate economic growth, Uttarakhand is strengthening both new and existing enterprises through technology

Devbhoomi Uttarakhand Hub of Growth and Investment

Policy Reforms

Financial Incentives

Institutional Support

Under the visionary leadership of PM Narendra Modi and the impeccable governance of CM Pushkar Singh Dhami, policy reforms, financial incentives, and institutional support have made Uttarakhand a robust ecosystem for MSMEs and startups



I congratulate the Uttarakhand government on the remarkable progress achieved in the last few years through sustained policy push and focus on key sectors such as tourism and renewable energy. The state has made significant strides in infrastructure, setting new benchmarks for sustainable growth. U'khand's commitment to harnessing its natural resources and promoting tourism will bolster its economy and showcase its potential on the global stage.

Narendra Modi, Prime Minister

upgradation, easier access to finance and markets, streamlined procedures and investment incentives. The One District One Product (ODOP) and One District Two Products (ODTP) initiatives, supported by GI-tagging, are helping showcase the state's distinctive products, strengthen local value chains and expand market opportunities. Aligned with national programmes such as Startup India, Stand-Up India, Make in India and MUDRA, these efforts are attracting investment, encouraging entrepreneurship and strengthening the "Make in Uttarakhand" identity in wider markets.

INCLUSIVE AND SUSTAINABLE GROWTH

The government is committed to ensuring that growth in the MSME sector is inclusive, providing special support to women entrepreneurs, the Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe communities, and entrepreneurs with disabilities (Divyang). To assist these groups in scaling their businesses and accessing new opportunities, additional financial incentives, subsidies, and dedicated helplines are being introduced.

STRENGTHENING INSTITUTIONAL SUPPORT

District Industry Centres (DICs) are being modernised to provide technical facilities, project preparation, and advisory support to

Financial incentives and subsidies

The new MSME policy provides a range of financial benefits to enterprises:

- Stamp duty reimbursement of upto 100% based on the category
- Capital subsidy of up to 50% on plant and machinery
- Extra capital investment subsidy of upto 5% under 'Priority' categories and upto 10% under 'Most Priority' categories
- An additional 5% subsidy for SC, ST, women, and divyang entrepreneurs
- Interest subsidy reimbursement of up to ₹21 lakh, depending upon the category
- Reimbursement of electricity duty for five years for new enterprises with a sanctioned load of up to 500 KW
- Recognition through ZED certification
- To encourage quality manufacturing, MSMEs are being offered certification under the Zero Defect Zero Effect (ZED) scheme. Units certified under gold, silver, and bronze categories receive recognition along with a monetary award of upto ₹75,000 per unit

entrepreneurs. A single-window clearance system is being streamlined to ensure faster approvals.

Additionally, an Investment Promotion and Facilitation Centre has been established at the Directorate of Industries to serve as a one-stop solution for investors and businesspersons. Special helpline services for women and differently-abled entrepreneurs are also being introduced.

FOCUS ON SKILL DEVELOPMENT AND MODERN TECHNIQUES

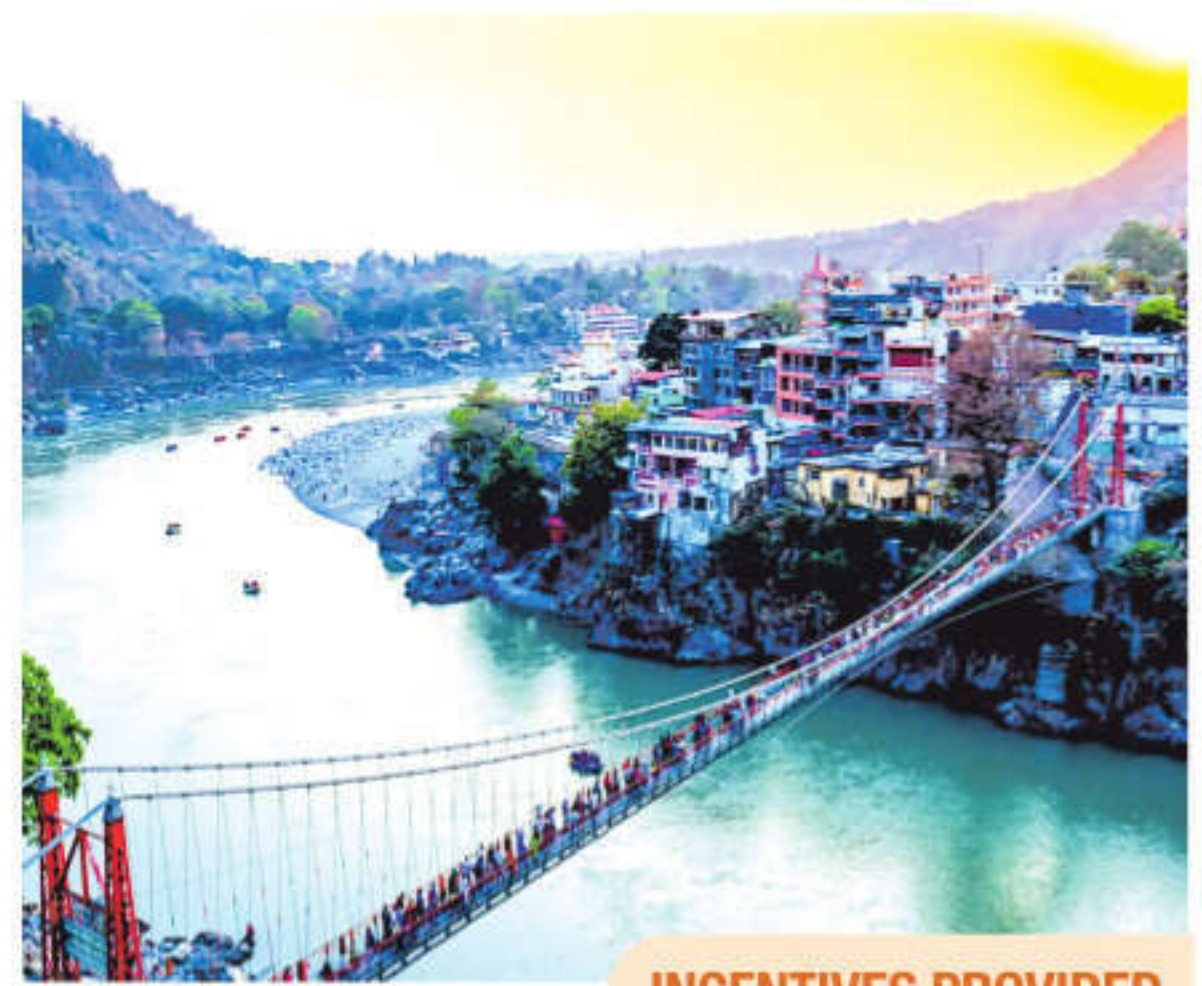
The policy also emphasises the need to equip young entrepreneurs with modern skills. To this end, the state is collaborating with reputed government and non-government organisations to provide training in:

- Manufacturing techniques
- Product design and packaging
- Marketing and branding strategies

MARKETING AND GLOBAL OUTREACH

The Uttarakhand Handloom and Handicraft Development Council is being engaged to promote state products in both national and international markets. Increased use of e-commerce platforms and commercial online portals will ensure that local enterprises gain greater visibility and a global reach. By encouraging innovation while preserving local traditions, the state aims to establish itself as a hub for sustainable and inclusive industries.

STATE'S NEW TOURISM SECTOR POLICY



The geographical, cultural, and environmental diversity of Uttarakhand has positioned it as one of the most visited states in North India. The number of tourists visiting Uttarakhand has consistently increased from ~22 million in 2014 to ~39 million in 2019 and registered a CAGR of 11.97%. A recent World Tourism and Travel Council (WTTC) report has pegged India as the 7th largest tourism economy globally in terms of absolute size and further forecasts the sector to grow at 7% between 2017 and 2027. The state of Uttarakhand is expected to match this trend in terms of tourist arrivals.

The state's new Tourism Policy envisages to chalk out a sustainable development strategy for tourism sector in the state. The role of the State Government and its Departments is envisaged to revolve around policy, regulation and promotion of tourism; while provision of services like accommodation, tourist facilitation, transportation, organisation of tours, activities, events, etc. will be the purview of the private sector, with State playing an enabling role.

LEVERAGING PRIVATE SECTOR INVESTMENTS

The policy underscores the fact that future tourism development in Uttarakhand would also benefit from private sector capital and expertise. In this regard, the government places immense faith in private-public sector relationships to further the cause of tourism development. For this to take effect expeditiously, the State would:

- i) reduce their role in areas where private

INCENTIVES PROVIDED UNDER THE POLICY

The policy provides the following incentives to eligible tourism units:

- Capital subsidy for hospitality (accommodation-related projects)
- Capital Subsidy
- Incentives for marketing and promotion
- Incentives for training and skilling
- Interest subvention
- Incentive for waste treatment
- Incentive for generating bookings through State Online Travel Agency
- Capital subsidy for investments in tourism products and services
- Subsidies for projects and units not eligible for capital subsidy
- Incentive for high-value premium hospitality
- Incentives for foreign tourists
- Organisation of MICE, art, social and cultural events, fairs and festivals
- Incentives for promotion of Heli transport
- Exemption on electricity duty
- Exemption on stamp duty

sector participation is encouraged (such as development and provision of accommodation), and ii) enhance ease of doing business (investor facilitation) by strengthening single window clearance process for faster approvals of tourism entities.

ELIGIBLE TOURISM UNITS

This policy supports and incentivises both existing and planned tourism projects. For the purpose of eligibility for capital subsidy¹ under this policy, those projects / enterprises which are new as well as those going for expansion / diversification as of the date of application for subsidy shall be considered.

For eligibility for turnover-linked incentives under this policy, those projects / enterprises which are operational as of the date of application for subsidy shall be considered.

The state intends to concentrate its efforts on the following 'Focus Tourism':

- Segments over the policy period:
- Nature and Adventure Tourism
- Health and Wellness Tourism
- Religious and Cultural Tourism
- Heritage Tourism
- MICE Tourism



Uttarakhand Pumped Storage Project Policy

This policy aims to set forth key objectives and mechanisms for development of Pumped Storage Projects in Uttarakhand. Pumped Storage Projects will be categorised in two main categories:

- On-stream projects:** At least one storage located on river stream. The state government designated agency will identify on-stream projects from time to time. The projects may be allocated to CPSUs or State PSUs on nomination basis and to private developers through competitive bidding. The period of allocation and terms and conditions shall be as defined under this policy
- Off-stream sites:** No storage located on river stream: The state government will invite developers to identify suitable sites for off-stream Pumped Storage Projects (PSPs) and submit proposals with details of their viability and storage potential. After evaluation, suitable projects will be

approved and formalised through an MoU/agreement with the developer

SUPPORT AND INCENTIVES

To encourage PSP development in state, the following support and incentives shall be offered:

- Exemption of intra-state transmission charges:** PSP Developers shall be billed not more than 50% of intra-state transmission charges for a period of five years from the project CoD, if project CoD is before end of FY2033-34
- Exemption of Local Area Development Fund:** Local Area Development Fund shall not be applicable to off-stream PSPs for the projects where power is purchased by state government
- Exemption of free royalty power:** The state government shall not collect any free royalty power from Pumped Storage Projects



Policy objectives

Facilitate development of Pumped Storage Projects in the state and support state's growing energy demand in a sustainable manner.

- Harness the PSP potential in the state and encourage development of self-identified off-stream sites
- Leverage PSPs to generate public and private investment
- Encourage integration of renewable energy sources into the grid by promoting PSPs
- Leverage PSP storage to fulfil the drinking and irrigation needs of the regions wherever required and feasible

AYUSH Policy



AYUSH has remained a core part of Uttarakhand's culture and tradition over the years. The state has multiple natural and cultural endowments which make it an ideal destination for AYUSH.

Some key endowments include the presence of rare medicinal herbs, a well-established AYUSH manufacturing sector, a strong ancient community of practitioners and presence of destinations conducive for AYUSH healing.

KEY ACTIONS AND INCENTIVES MEDICINAL PLANTS

- Promote Good Agricultural Practices (GAP), quality standards and technology such as drones for better cultivation and monitoring
- Develop cold-storage facilities and aggregation platforms
- Introduce assured buy-back mechanisms and promote medicinal-plant cultivation
- Build a distinctive Uttarakhand/ Himalayan brand for key medicinal

AYUSH MANUFACTURING

- Provide additional capital subsidies for eligible AYUSH manufacturing units and encourage cluster-based manufacturing
- Promote WHO-GMP, AYUSH premium and AYUSH standard certifications
- Establish common testing laboratories and a dedicated Homeopathic Drug Testing Laboratory
- Position Uttarakhand as a leading AYUSH manufacturing hub

HEALTHCARE

- Encourage NABH accreditation of

AYUSH hospitals and clinics through financial support and easier empanelment under state health schemes

- Strengthen government AYUSH hospitals and expand teleconsultation and digital healthcare services
- Promote Yoga as a tool for preventive healthcare and encourage private investment in AYUSH healthcare infrastructure

- Develop AYUSH Grams to involve local communities

WELLNESS

- Provide additional capital incentives for eligible wellness centres, hotels and resorts in hill regions
- Promote AYUSH parks, yoga and meditation centres and wellness destinations through PPPs and private investment
- Undertake domestic and international campaigns to position Uttarakhand as a leading global wellness destination

EDUCATION & RESEARCH

- Incentivise NAAC accreditation and strengthen the quality of AYUSH education
- Introduce apprenticeships, internships and research programmes through collaborations with leading national and international institution
- Promote research in Yoga, Naturopathy and the integration of traditional and modern medicine
- Strengthen faculty training, professional upskilling and documentation of Uttarakhand's traditional AYUSH knowledge





EVENT AT NEW YORK'S MADISON SQUARE GARDEN

Bharat's destiny is to make world realise unity in diversity: Bhagwat

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, August 30

IN AN apparent articulation of the RSS's worldview for an American audience, RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat on Sunday said Bharat's "destiny" was to make the world realise that unity could coexist with diversity, and that the country had to demonstrate this "not by preaching, but by practice".

Addressing around 5,000 people at New York's Madison Square Garden, Bhagwat said nations were not merely geographical entities but had a "duty" to perform. Invoking Swami Vivekananda, he said every nation had a message to deliver, a mission to accomplish and a destiny to fulfil, and argued that Bharat's mission was to demonstrate the idea of unity underlying diversity.

"For Bharat, this unity and diversity are part of the DNA," he said. "Diversity has to be celebrated, has to be respected, has to be accepted... We must keep in mind this feeling of oneness. This is a real feeling."

The event, organised by the AHEAD Forum as part of the RSS's centenary-year global outreach, came amid a controversy in New York. Mayor Zohran Mamdani said earlier this week, "I don't support the rally, but I don't know if the city has any jurisdiction on cancelling a private event."

Bhagwat said the idea of oneness was not merely philosophical but had implications for how human beings treated one another.



RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat in New York on Sunday. PTI

other. Asking the audience to imagine eating a meal while a hungry person watched them, he said a human being would find it difficult to continue eating because of the instinctive recognition of another person's suffering. "You will not be able to do it. Because we are human beings."

He contrasted two approaches — "live and let live" and "live and let on those live who obey us". Those who protected only people who obeyed them were "rakshasas", he said, while those who cared for others irrespective of whether they were useful or obedient represented the "devas".

Bhagwat said India's civilisational understanding was that humanity was connected through the *atman*, like beads woven into a single thread. Differences of body, clothing and modes of worship, he said, did not alter this underlying unity. "It tells us that you appear different but you are not. Because all these differences will fade. Your

body will die, but something lives permanently. We belong to each other," he said.

It was this understanding, he said, that India's ancestors had sought to give to the world. They had organised the people living "south of Himalayas up to the sea" into a nation with the task of communicating this knowledge to the world. "That is the mission Bharat has to accomplish. Not by preaching, but by practice," he said.

Addressing the Indian diaspora, Bhagwat said their first responsibility was towards the US, which he described as their "karmabhoomi". If they wanted to do something for India, he said, they should first fulfil their duties towards the country where they lived. Bhagwat said Indians abroad should live by the values they received from India. "We take from the world and so we have to give back. How much we earn is not important. How much we distribute is," he said.

'Doublespeak': Opp parties slam RSS chief, say he can't tolerate diversity at home

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 30

THE OPPOSITION on Sunday accused RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat of indulging in doublespeak over his remarks on diversity, even as the BJP hailed him, saying he has shown the world what Hinduism actually means.

Reacting to Bhagwat's remarks, Congress spokesperson Shama Mohamed said the RSS chief should "stop lying" and alleged that the RSS's DNA has "hatred and communalism".

Congress leader Udit Raj said Bhagwat made the statement to placate those protesting against the RSS in New York. "They are two-faced people, they change their colours like a chameleon. Since there were protests against them in New York, they had to try to counter it with such a jumla (rhetoric)...," he said.

AIMIM chief Asaduddin Owaisi accused Bhagwat of indulging in "doublespeak" and termed the speech "the oldest trick in the RSS playbook". "Some words are for the world, and some are for its own members... What do they say about Muslims and other minorities?" "My request to Bhagwat is that he should just recite choice extracts from the poisonous works of Savarkar, Hedgewar, Golwalkar, etc. Let people decide

what they make of RSS," he said.

Shiv Sena UBT MP Sanjay Raut said the RSS chief needed to make the same statement in India. "This statement and ideology, Bhagwat ji should speak about it in India. Their people who are sitting in power in Delhi, Uttar Pradesh, those in Maharashtra... imported from other parties — he should tell them this... You will say something in New York and in Bharat, when there is a protester against you, you will say something different. This is not called dharma but dhong (drama)," he said.

Rajya Sabha MP Kapil Sibal took a swipe at Bhagwat, saying he was left wondering whether it was Congress leader Rahul Gandhi or the Sangh chief speaking. "You accept diversity abroad; you do not tolerate diversity at home," said Sibal.

Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis said tolerance is the soul of Hindutva. "Tolerance runs in the blood of Hindus, it is a fundamental aspect of Hindutva... If someone attacks you, there must certainly be a counter-response; however, a Hindu never initiates an attack."

Cockroach Janata Party leader Abhijeet Dipke said the BJP thinks it has become bigger than the RSS, but it should pay heed to what the Sangh chief has been saying.

WITH PTI INPUTS

MANN KI BAAT



Prime Minister Narendra Modi at a yoga session organised by the Yoga Federation of Uzbekistan in Tashkent. PTI

Play role in anti-drug drive, create slogans, songs: Modi to youth

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 30

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi urged the youth on Sunday to take "creative efforts" and bolster the campaign against drug abuse to create a powerful slogan or songs to convey the message for a drug-free life.

During his Mann Ki Baat address, Modi warned drug addiction does not just engulf a single individual but the entire family as he commended those raising awareness against drugs and stepping forward to help people struggling with addiction.

"Can you come up with a powerful slogan for a drug-free India? Can our young musicians create songs that convey the message of a drug-free life? Can students and theatre groups write touching short plays that highlight the dangers of drugs while also showing the path to recovery? Our country has no shortage of excellent content creators. I urge them to create content in various languages that helps society in this endeavour," he said. "You can use your creativity as a medium for social change... creative efforts prove more impactful than formal campaigns. Let us all play our part in this noble mission to keep India's youth away from drugs and free from addiction."

Launched on August 15,

2020, under the National Action Plan for Drug Demand Reduction, the Nasha Mukta Bharat Abhiyaan is a flagship government initiative.

This year, which marks the 150th anniversary of Vande Mataram, 8 crore Tiranga selfies were uploaded, the PM said. Through the Suryapath Tiranga initiative, the tricolour embarked on a unique journey across the globe, he said.

He said, "Nearly 46% of the beneficiaries of PM SVANidhi Scheme are women. Around 35 lakh women across the country are connecting with this scheme to advance their businesses."

Calling for honouring local artisans during Vishwakarma Puja in September, he said, "I once again urge you to be 'Vocal for Local'. Being 'Vocal for Local' doesn't merely mean buying earthen lamps... Whatever item we purchase for our homes, do ensure it is made in India... Our friends from creative world, influencers and celebrities also have a significant role to play in it."

The PM also paid tribute to legendary Bengali actor and "Mahanayak" Uttam Kumar, whose birth centenary falls on September 3. "Mahanayak Uttam Kumar *chirodin manusher hridaye raj korben* (He will forever rule the hearts of people)," PM said.

41 nations, 135 movies: Kashmir set to host its first global film festival

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, August 30

FROM KASHMIR *ki Kali* in the 60s to *Kabhie Kabhie* in the 70s to *Highway* (2014) and *Raazi* (2018) more recently, the Valley has long attracted Hindi film industry to shoot its movies in the pristine landscape.

Now, with the hope of putting the region on the world cinema map, Kashmir is all set to host its first international film festival next month.

"Rang-e-Cinema", to be hosted by J&K government's Information and Public Relations department from September 7 to 10, aims to establish J&K as a "major international destination for cinema, filmmaking, creative collaboration and cultural exchange".

"The core objective is to rebuild J&K's historic relationship with cinema," said an official associated with the international festival. "It is also aimed at creating opportunities for local talent, attracting filmmakers, pro-

moting film tourism and placing Jammu and Kashmir firmly on the global cinematic map."

The organisers have announced a star-studded five-member jury for the festival. This includes eminent cinematographer and director Santosh Sivan, son of *Slumdog Millionaire* fame Resul Pookutty, German film curator and journalist Dorothee Wenner, founder and CEO of Bang Singapore Keiko Bang, and film director Himansu Sekhar Khatua of *Surya Swaroopa* fame.

"We had received over 1,100 submissions for the festival from over 80 countries," said a senior official. "Of these, 135 submissions, from 41 countries, have been shortlisted." While 64 entries have been shortlisted from India, 13 films from France and eight from Iran would be a part of the festival. The other participating countries include Türkiye, Germany, Russia, Spain, Brazil, Qatar, Argentina, the US, South Korea and Taiwan.

IAS officer, who brought piped drinking water to UP village, quits

Maulshree Seth
Lucknow, August 30

DIVYA MITTAL, who gained popularity for bringing piped water to a remote hilly village in Mirzapur district of UP as the District Magistrate three years ago, on Sunday announced her resignation from the IAS after a 13-year stint.

Announcing her resignation in a social media post, the 42-year-old officer of the UP cadres said she was now ready to "move on" from a journey in which she had learnt more from the people she served than she had given them. "Today, I have voluntarily stepped away from an unforgettable 13-year journey by resigning from the IAS," the 2013-batch IAS officer said in a social media post. Mittal served as district magistrate of Mirzapur from September 2022 to September 2023, and later as that of Deoria from July 2024. In May this year, she was appointed Special Secretary, Revenue Department, in Lucknow.

Mittal's tenure in Mirzapur



Now, it was time to live the dreams I saw for my people: Divya Mittal posted on X. @DIVYAMITTAL_IAS/X

brought her considerable public attention in 2023, particularly after her intervention led to provision of piped water to Lahuria Dah village, where residents had long depended on tankers for drinking water. But soon after, she was transferred out of Mirzapur and placed on the waiting list from September 4, 2023, to February 1, 2024. On February 1, she was posted as CEO of UP Rural Road Development Agency and later served as district magistrate in Deoria.

Mittal said she initially be-

lieved she had entered public service to give something to society. "I was a fool to think I had come to give something. The truth is, I received the most, and that debt only grew deeper," she wrote.

Mittal did not specify what she had planned to do after quitting the IAS. In her final message, she said the dreams she had once seen for herself had already come true. "Now, it was time to live the dreams I saw for my people," she wrote.

Source said that she plans to pursue academics and book writing. There are also speculations about her joining politics.

SP chief Akhilesh Yadav alleged that honest officials in UP were being pressured under the BJP government to indulge in "unethical and illegal" activities, forcing them to quit the service.

"There are countless other instances where the BJP government puts pressure on officials to carry out unethical and illegal acts, because of which they are even forced to resign," Yadav said on X.

Police summon Derek over billboard brawl

Kolkata: The Kolkata police have summoned TMC MP Derek O'Brien in connection with the scuffle at 9 Camac Street on Thursday over the removal of an alleged illegal billboard. A team of three officers from the Shakespeare Sarani police station arrived at O'Brien's residence on Prince Anwar Shah Road to hand over the notice on Sunday morning. As the MP was away, his staff accepted the notice. ENS

Day after Jarange began fast, govt says ready to discuss legal validity

Vallabh Ozarkar
Mumbai, August 30

A DAY after Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange Patil resumed his indefinite fast at Antarwali Sarati, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Sunday said the government is open to discussing constitutionally valid and legally viable demands.

Deputy CM Eknath Shinde said the government's position was to provide reservation to the Maratha community without reducing the reservation available to other communities.

Fadnavis said representatives of the government are attending the Parbhani event to discuss the demands of demonstrators. "Earlier also we found a way to address their issues, and we are going forward to resolve their demands. Similarly, Eknath Shinde is also very sensitive to these issues from the very beginning," he said.

Shinde, who attended a farmer-youth meeting at Parbhani, said, "I know Manoj Jarange Patil's concern. CM Fadnavis and I have sent our ministers to examine the legal aspects."

Mahila, Manusmriti, purification row: Rahul's new political pitch takes shape



"SHUDDHIKARAN (PURIFICATION)", *Manusmriti*, "Chhatron ki Goonf", and the caste census. These four show that Rahul Gandhi is moving according to a plan. The Leader of Opposition (LoP) has stepped up efforts to create a new narrative geared to win over Dalits, women, Gen Z, the Other Backward Classes (OBCs), and minorities, having eyed this constituency of "90% of India" for some time now.

Gandhi recently sparked a backlash from the BJP by criticising the *Manusmriti*, the ancient Hindu text, for viewing women only as an extension of their father, husband, or son. Not unexpectedly, the ruling party accused him of being derisive towards the Hindu faith. The stage is now set for a slugfest between the two parties, each reaching out to constituencies

that might enable them to come to power in Uttar Pradesh and other poll-bound states in 2027.

Gandhi's words at his 'Chhatron ki goonf' event in Pune reflected a shift in the Congress's strategy. The LoP did not use the usual, mild words that political parties use to express concern for women, such as "welfare" and "empowerment". Instead, he talked about "smashing patriarchy" and accused the RSS and the BJP of possessing a "Manusmriti mindset".

The format of the meeting was also differently conceived and it even reflected in Gandhi's sartorial choice. He was dressed in a more stylish yellow shirt instead of his customary beige trousers and white T-shirt (with the trademark one hand in his pocket). At the 'Chhatron ki Goonf' address in Prayagraj earlier, he had worn a pink flowing shirt.

The idea of Gandhi's makeover, if Congressmen are to be believed, is to try and win over a large section of Gen Z, especially women, whom the party thinks it has not paid attention to until now. Many urban, educated, middle-class,

and upper-caste Gen Z like the LoP's "inconsistent" ways — such as taking off for a break from time to time, unlike traditional politicians who are expected to work 24x7. For Gandhi to pay as much attention to his fitness and health as to his work is a model that interests them, and they like him for asking questions of the government — as a 19-year-old put it, "To be modern is to ask questions."

In Pune, Gandhi also demonstrated a different way of political engagement. He walked up and down the stage with a mike in his hand, calling on groups of young women to come up on the stage and chat with him. They talked about their experiences — the safety constraints they face that have a bearing on their education or work, their inability to make decisions independently, as well as lack of finances. These were not only English-speaking women. Most of them were more at home in Marathi, managing to speak in Hindi that was disarming — their punchlines drawing applause from the audience, a large number of them women. It appears that

the Gen Z are viewing Rahul Gandhi with new eyes.

Why Gandhi brought up Manusmriti

Gandhi could just as well have made a powerful pitch for women's rights without referring to the controversial *Manusmriti*. But he chose to court a controversy because not only did he want to reach out to Gen Z women — and Gen Alpha girls — but also to Dalits. A century ago, B R Ambedkar had burnt the *Manusmriti* in public in 1927 to protest against its teachings, criticising it for encouraging untouchability and denying the lower castes and women equality and autonomy of functioning.

Then, on August 29, Gandhi upped the ante with his attack against the BJP for not acting against those who had washed the stage from which Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge had addressed a gathering in Haldwani earlier this month. This, the LoP argued, was just because Kharge is Dalit. Gandhi tried to make this "shuddhikaran (purification)" act synonymous with continuing un-



Rahul Gandhi addresses a press conference in New Delhi on Saturday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

touchability against Dalits and project that the BJP, despite rapidly expanding its base and courting the OBCs and Dalits since 2014, remains the party of the upper castes — the Brahmin-Bania party — at its core.

The BJP distanced itself from the incident and hit back, but Gandhi is not letting up, asking if the Dalit president of the largest Opposition party could be treated in this fashion, what might be the fate of ordinary Dalits in villages? Gandhi knows that the return of Dalits to the Congress fold holds the key to the party's future. It is the Dalit fear of losing their constitutionally guaranteed reservations that had led to the BJP failing to get a majority on its own in 2024.

Gandhi is also not abandoning his outreach to the OBCs, though he has not made much of a headway with them in the Hindi heartland. This was the sum total of the letter that he and Kharge shot off to Prime Minister Modi to reframe the questions in the caste census — many believe that it will not do justice to the OBCs.

Gandhi's problem, however, lies elsewhere. It is the emancipation of the Congress organisation in large parts of the country. Winning elections is a complex business today. A buzz is not good enough without the machinery to convert goodwill into votes and that is where the Con-

gress has been found wanting.

Can BJP capitalise?

Paradoxically, the *Manusmriti* debate has also come as a godsend for a BJP on the back foot after the recent protests. It could help the ruling party switch the narrative back on the Hindu versus anti-Hindu lines to polarise the polity. BJP leaders were quick to target the LoP, saying he criticises only the Hindu religious texts for discriminating against women. The newly appointed BJP general secretary Smriti Irani, who defeated Gandhi in Amethi in 2019 and who has been rehabilitated to take him on, asked the LoP to walk the talk and support the implementation of the Women's Reservation Act and induct women ministers in the Congress's Karnataka Cabinet. Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath also took aim at Gandhi, accusing him of insulting the state and the country's religious traditions.

It is early days yet, but given that the *Manusmriti* gives primacy to the Brahmins and upper castes, the new controversy could help the BJP con-

solidate the upper castes behind it once again. Though they have been the most convinced of the BJP's supporters in the Hindi heartland since the Mandir movement, these communities have been feeling restive with what they see as the BJP's tilt towards the OBCs. They had reacted to the UGC equity norms, now stayed, and even the caste census that is underway.

In 2018, the government, which had restored the SC-ST Act diluted by the Supreme Court, had to move with alacrity to bring a 10% quota for the economically weaker sections in the general category. As then, so also today, the BJP, whose base has expanded under Narendra Modi, is compelled to walk the tightrope.

In the end, the two "Ms" — *Mahila* and *Manusmriti* — may well define the 2027 elections in UP and other states, which in turn will have a ripple effect in the big battle in 2029.

(Neerja Chowdhury, Contributing Editor, The Indian Express, has covered the last 11 Lok Sabha elections. She is the author of *How Prime Ministers Decide*.)





THE CURTAIN RAISER TO THE VIBRANT GUJARAT GLOBAL SUMMIT 2027



Curtain Raiser

Chaired by

Shri Bhupendra Patel

Hon'ble Chief Minister, Gujarat

Interaction with Industry Leaders

📍 Auditorium 2, Convention Centre, Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi (Entry from Gate No. 7)

📅 Monday, 31st August 2026 ⌚ 11:30 AM onwards

Interaction with Heads of Mission

📍 Durbar Hall, Hotel Taj Palace, New Delhi

📅 Monday, 31st August 2026 ⌚ 07:00 PM onwards

"Through a perfect synergy of innovation and industrial investment, 'Vibrant Gujarat' stands today as the powerful engine of global economic growth."

- **Harsh Sanghavi**, Deputy Chief Minister, Gujarat

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New Delhi

NEPAL DISASTER: MEA SHARES LIST OF 149 INDIANS RESCUED ON SUNDAY



The trail of devastation left behind in the riverside town of Betrawati in Nepal on Sunday. Betrawati is also on the main route used by pilgrims travelling to Gosaikunda, a pilgrimage site in Rasuwa. TASHI TOBGYAL

‘Hope for some miracle’

403 Indians cross into Nepal from China; forensic team from India begins DNA tests

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, August 30

AS MANY as 403 Indian nationals safely crossed into Nepal from China on Sunday and 500 Indians are still in China and safe, the Ministry of External Affairs said on Sunday.

However, the ministry did not give any update on the missing Indians. On Saturday, as search and rescue operations continued in Nepal for the fourth day, the ministry had said 275 Indians and another 128 people of Indian origin — mostly Kailash Mansarovar Yatra pilgrims — remained missing.

On Sunday, the MEA on its X handleshared a list of 149 people who were rescued. It also said that a “19-member specialized forensics team from India began functioning in Kathmandu today”.

“This team will help augment the analysis of DNA samples in Nepal for identification of the mortal remains of the victims. Ambassador of India to Nepal [Naveen Srivastava] met and briefed the forensics team. Subsequently, the team had discussions with counterparts in Nepal Police’s Central Forensic Science Lab Laboratory in Kathmandu and Forensics Department of the Tribhuvan University Teaching Hospital,” it said.

About the Indian tunnel rescue team, the MEA said, “Tunnel Rescue Operations Team continued its work today and

supplemented the research and rescue efforts of Nepali Army at hydropower sites in Chilime and Langtang.” “The team was able to enter a tunnel near Langtang hydroelectric project and retrieve the mortal remains of one person in spite of inclement weather. This team is continuing its support operations near the Langtang hydroelectric project,” it said.

The death toll from flash floods in Nepal rose to 788 on Sunday, with bodies continuing to be recovered, as authorities warned of increased water levels in the Bhotekoshi river and urged residents and rescue personnel in flood-hit districts to remain alert.

More than 2,500 people still remain missing, while nearly 9,500 people were rescued, according to the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA).

In a statement issued on Sunday, the NDRRMA warned that water levels in the Bhotekoshi river had risen again. “The water level in the flooded Bhotekoshi river has risen to some extent; all concerned are urged to take precautionary measures,” it said.

As many as 2,502 people, including 591 foreigners, remain missing, according to authorities. India has provided 68.5 tonnes of relief materials. “The fourth flight, carrying 11 tons of relief materials, has arrived in Nepal,” the Indian mission said.

WITH AGENCIES FROM NEPAL



A photograph of a family lies amid the debris as search operations intensified. TASHI TOBGYAL

‘Chances of survival look slim’: 67 from Maharashtra still untraceable

Apoorva Agashe
Mumbai, August 30

AS MANY as 67 pilgrims from Maharashtra who were stranded in Nepal after the flash floods remained untraceable, with their families awaiting news of their loved ones.

Maharashtra government on Sunday said that 69 people from the state had crossed from China’s Kodari Immigration Center into Nepal and were expected to reach Mumbai by Monday. Earlier 142 citizens were brought back to the state.

The Ramakrishnan family from Mumbai is among those whose members were headed to Tibet to complete their Kailash Mansarovar pilgrimage before they went missing. “At 8.21 am, I got a message from my brother-in-law Venkata saying, ‘We are at the immigration centre at

(Nepal), heading towards Tibet.’ He has been untraceable since then,” C G Ramakrishnan told *The Indian Express*.

Ramakrishnan’s sister, Meenakshi Subramanian, and her husband were among the 67 people who had travelled to the region on a pilgrimage led by Dr Milind Chitale. The group was at the Timure border immigration centre, preparing to cross into Tibet, when floods struck.

Ramakrishnan said the family has been in touch with Indian, Nepalese and Chinese embassies. But there is no information about the whereabouts and status of 67 members of Richa Tours and Travels in Nepal and Hills and Trails in Mumbai.

Meenakshi Subramanian (60) and her husband Venkata Subramanian (67), from Kandivali were on Kailash Mansarovar. Their last known location is

Timure, Rasuwa, one of the worst-hit districts.

Ramakrishnan said, “From what we could gather from embassies is Rasuwa was the epicenter of the flash floods... We are anxious to about the whereabouts of our loved ones. Their phones are switched off or unreachable. Authorities are trying to find them but we are losing hope as the chances of survival look dim. We hope we are wrong and some miracle happens.”

Thane-based Joshi family is also waiting to hear from their loved ones. Sachin Joshi, a relative of a couple who have been missing, said the families of those missing in Nepal have formed a WhatsApp group to coordinate their efforts. “My relatives, Samir Joshi and Aparna Joshi are missing. All relatives have formed a WhatsApp group for coordination.”

Bengal couple returns, no word on Mukul Roy’s daughter-in-law

Sweety Kumari
Kolkata, August 30

RETIRED SCHOOLTEACHER Anukul Poddar and his wife Reba Poddar, who had been in the vicinity of the flash flood-affected area in Nepal, returned home in Basirhat in North 24 Parganas district on Saturday and recounted how a timely decision by their driver saved their lives when the flash floods struck on August 26.

“We returned by Mithila Express. We had gone there for the Mansarovar and Kailash yatra. However, as we left Kathmandu Hotel for our journey ahead, our driver came to know about the floods and took us to a safer location at a higher altitude and we returned to our hotel 40-45 minutes later. It is because of our driver that we are safe today,” Anukul said. Their arrival has ended the agony for their family. But for many across the state, every moment is mounting for anxiety as they await updates on several with most of the tourists yet to be traced or located.

Among those untraced is Sharmistha Bhowmik Roy, wife of ex-TMC MLA Subhranshu Roy and daughter-in-law of late politician Mukul Roy. She left Kolkata on August 21 as part of a 30-member Kailash Mansarovar pilgrimage group and was reportedly around 10 km from site of deluge when communication with her was lost. “I could only get information they had cleared immigration and crossed into Chinese side. There is no further update,” Subhranshu said.

NEET-PG: Power cut hits two Jaipur centres, retest on Sep 5; panel formed

Hamza Khan & Anonna Dutt
Jaipur, New Delhi August 30

A FRESH exam will be held on September 5 for candidates affected due to power cut issues during the NEET-PG 2026 exam held at two ION Digital Zone IDZ centres in Jaipur’s Sitapura area, the National Board of Examinations in Medical Sciences (NBEMS) said on Sunday.

As per NBEMS, the examination could not be completed at test centres numbers 41,682 and 41,683 in Jaipur “due to internal power failure issues at the centre, attributed to M/s TCS Ltd., the exam conducting agency.”

The Board said the re-test would be held on September 5 at 3pm in Jaipur. Other details regarding the re-exam centre will be released separately, it said, adding that revised admit cards will also be issued. It said, “NBEMS apologises to the affected candidates for the inconvenience caused.”

According to sources, the NBEMS has constituted a three-member committee to look into the power supply issue, the reasons for disruption, and the circumstances leading to it. The committee will include a senior official from Rajasthan government, a joint secretary from the Union health ministry, and a senior engineering official from the Central Electricity Authority. The committee will submit its report within the stipulated time-frame, sources said.

Dr Abhijat Sheth, NBEMS president, said, “There was no paper leak, cybercrime, or hacking. There were no complaints received. There was one problem, however. Around 2,445 candidates in Jaipur’s Sitapura centres could not complete their examination due to internal power failure. And, we had to postpone the examination to preserve its sanctity.”

He said, “We will conduct the test in the same manner and keep in mind that the scores are not affected.”

According to Union Health Ministry officials NBEMS has also expressed regret for inconvenience caused to the affected candidates and said the re-examination is being conducted to ensure that they receive a fair and equitable opportunity.

Dr Gaurav, who wrote the exam, said, “In two hours, the exam began 10 times and ended 10 times.” While several other candidates alleged lack of proper electricity supply at the centre which hampered the exam, some demanded its cancellation across the country.

Vishnu Sharma, another candidate, said, “The system shut down repeatedly right from the beginning, even before the exam could properly start. It would work for barely two minutes before crashing. This happened at least 20 times.”

He said, “We kept cooperating, hoping it would work the next time, but the system continued to shut down. When candidates are charged such a substantial fee, is it too much to expect proper facilities for an exam of this scale?”

In a post on X, Congress said, “The NEET-PG exam scheduled for 9am in Jaipur could not even start until noon. Students and their families continued to suffer due to (PM Narendra) Modi’s pathetic system, while the entire government slept soundly under the covers. Once again, it has been proven that the Modi government cannot conduct even a single exam properly. Shame on them.”

As per NBEMS, NEET-PG 2026 exam was conducted on August 30 at 1,111 centres across 339 cities for 2,73,096 registered candidates. Of them, 2,65,980 candidates appeared for the exam and 2,63,535 completed it.

8-yr-old boy dies after being run over by car in Mumbai; woman held

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 30

A 45-YEAR-old woman was arrested after her Innova Crysta allegedly hit an eight-year-old boy while he was crossing the road in Bandra West on Sunday afternoon, resulting in his death.

The deceased was identified as Ansh Gupta, 8. The accused driver has been identified as Megha Rawal, 45, a Bandra West resident, who is a fitness coach and nutritionist. She is the founder of Mezmo candy, a healthcare brand which makes gummies out of real fruit.

According to police, the incident took place between 2.15pm and 2.30 pm in front of Jijamata Garden on John Baptist Road, Bandra West. Ansh was allegedly crossing the road when the Innova Crysta driven by Rawal hit him. Following the accident, Ansh sustained grievous injuries

and was rushed to Holy Family Hospital for where doctors declared him dead on arrival.

“He had sustained grievous injuries so we had rushed him to Holy Family Hospital. The doctors had declared him dead on arrival. The family of Ansh Gupta is still shocked,” police said.

The police said they were investigating whether the accused was using a phone while driving when the accident occurred. It is alleged that the woman was on a phone call at the time of the incident.

“The woman has been identified as Megha Rawal, and we suspect she was talking over a phone call when the incident took place. We are investigating,” a police officer said. Rawal has been booked under BNS Sections 105, 281 and 125, along with Section 184 of the MV Act, which deals with dangerous driving.

‘Delay in justice’: Kin of Dalits killed in 2012 Gujarat firing link suicide to father’s grief

Brendan Dabhi
& Parimal A Dabhi
Ahmedabad, August 30

ALMOST 14 years ago, three young Dalit men were killed in alleged police firing in Gujarat’s Surendranagar district, in what remains one of the most sensitive and controversial cases of its kind in the state in recent years.

Earlier this week, the father of one of the three men died on the railway tracks in Thangadh, allegedly by suicide, metres from a memorial erected to the memory of the youths — Mehul Rathod, Prakash Parmar, and Pankaj Sumra.

Prakash Parmar’s father Babubhai had died of heart failure in 2015. After Pankaj Sumra’s father Amarshi Sumra died Wednesday night, only one of the three grieving fathers now survives.

Valji Rathod, the father of

Mehul Rathod, told *The Indian Express* he believed it was the failure to get justice for their sons that had in some way led to the deaths of both Babubhai and Amarshi. “We believe it is the delay in justice that finally took the life of Amarshi Sumra, just like it did of Babubhai Parmar a decade ago,” Valji Rathod said.

Mehul Rathod, Prakash Parmar, and Pankaj Sumra were allegedly shot dead by police in two separate but related incidents on September 22 and 23, 2012, which followed a clash between Dalits and non-Dalits at a local fair.

Prakash Parmar was 26 when he was killed. Mehul Rathod and Pankaj Sumra were only 17 and 16 respectively. “Amarshi Lakha Sumra, the 53-year-old father of Pankaj Sumra, died at 10.21 pm on August 26 after he was run over by the 12268 Hapa-Mumbai Central Duroto Express as the

train crossed Thangadh,” ASI Jagdish Dhoraliya of Government Railway Police, Surendranagar, said.

Police have registered an Accidental Death (AD) report. But the three Dalit families see a link between Amarshi’s death and those of his son and the two other youths in 2012.

“No one can really comprehend a father’s grief over the loss of his son. These three men, Amarshibhai, Valjibhai, and Babubhai, went through pain that is hard to describe,” Vinu Bagda, Amarshi Sumra’s younger brother, said.

“Two families have been completely destroyed. I am the only one (of the three fathers) left now. I have no support any more. Amarshibhai would constantly ask me to stay strong, but now he is gone himself,” Valji Rathod said.

Vinu Bagda said Amarshi



Amarshi Sumra, whose son Pankaj was among the three youth killed in 2012, died allegedly by suicide on Aug 26

was dismayed at the way justice seemed to be denied to his son. “He would say that the case goes on and on without any conclusion... This time of the year is particularly hard for us because preparations have begun for the Tarnetar fair during which his son was killed,” Vinu said.

“Amarshi had spoken with his daughter a couple of days ago, and she had told him she

regretted no longer having a brother with whom she could celebrate Raksha Bandhan. This may have exacerbated his grief,” Vinu said.

The two brothers had met four days before Amarshi died. “He told me he no longer had the will to live. I told him he should not think that way, and tried to reassure him that justice will be done,” Vinu said. “Many people told us Amarshibhai had gone to the memorial around 9.30 pm that day. We think he may have gone to the tracks shortly afterward,” Vinu said.

On September 22, 2012, an argument broke out between groups of young men of two communities during that year’s Tarnetar Mela organised by the local civic body. PM Narendra Modi, who was then CM of Gujarat, was visiting the district at the time, and police moved quickly to break up the scuffle.

They used tear gas and fired at the crowd. A bullet allegedly hit Pankaj Sumra in the back. He was taken to Surendranagar hospital and then to Rajkot civil hospital, where he was declared dead. On September 23, members of the Dalit community came out in protest, and the police allegedly fired again. This time Prakash Parmar and Mehul Rathod were killed. A fourth Dalit youth, 25-year-old Chana Vaniya, was injured.

In 2012, the Gujarat government ordered an inquiry under Sanjay Prasad, then principal secretary in the Social Justice and Empowerment Department. Prasad submitted his report in May 2013. But its contents were never made public. This inquiry was not by a commission of inquiry, whose reports must be tabled in the Assembly.

To questions asked by Congress MLAs Shailesh Parmar in

2016 and Gyasuddin Shaikh in 2017 in the Assembly, then CMs Anandiben Patel and Vijay Rupani said in written replies that the report was “under consideration of the state government”. Patel is now governor of UP. Rupani was killed in Air India plane crash on June 12 last year.

Lawyers connected with the case said 6-7 FIRs were registered in the Thangadh killings, three of which were filed by Dalits accusing four policemen of the murder of the three youths. The other FIRs were against Dalits. An investigation by the CID (Crime) found police had used AK-47 rifles on protesting Dalits. The Rupani government in August 2016 set up a three-member SIT headed by IPS officer Anupam Singh Gahlaut.

The SIT filed a chargesheet in the case of Pankaj Sumra’s alleged murder, in which his mother Baluben was the com-

plainant. The other two cases, involving the alleged killings of Prakash and Mehul, were closed.

Three of the four policemen accused in Pankaj’s killing are facing trial in district court in Surendranagar. The case is at the stage of recording prosecution evidence. “It will be 14 years on September 23 this year,” Valji Rathod said. “The report of Sanjay Prasad inquiry is still not public, and no accused has been arrested. How long must we wait for justice?” In protest, Valji fought the 2019 LS election to the Gandhinagar seat as an Independent against Amit Shah, who would go on to become Union Home Minister.

Chandrika Rathod, Mehul’s mother, said: “In 2017 we moved Gujarat HC seeking the release of Sanjay Prasad report. We have protested in Delhi, Gandhinagar, and Thangadh, but the findings were not released.”

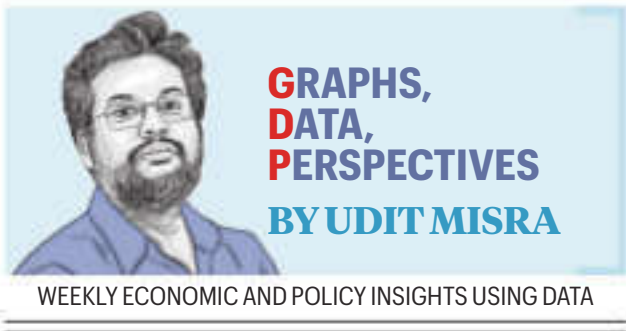
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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

• **ECONOMY**

Worries behind India's robust GDP, inflation data



GRAPHS, DATA, PERSPECTIVES
BY UDIT MISRA

WEEKLY ECONOMIC AND POLICY INSIGHTS USING DATA

OVER THE past three financial years, the Indian economy recorded a GDP (gross domestic product) growth rate of more than 7%, alongside a sharp drop in the inflation rate. Many analysts expected the US-Israeli War on Iran to dent this trajectory, owing to factors like an increase in the prices of crude oil and a reduction in foreign investments. Making matters worse was the prospect of high temperatures thanks to El Niño, which threatened to hit food production.

The growth rate was expected to fall, while the inflation rate was expected to skyrocket from 2% in 2025-26 to near 6% — from the lower end of RBI's "comfort zone" to its upper limit. On May 11, Prime Minister Narendra Modi even appealed to Indians to tighten their belts by stopping gold purchases and reducing fuel consumption, among other measures.

But macroeconomic data shows India hasn't fared as poorly as feared. On Monday, GDP data for Q1 will be released and is expected to yet again cross the 7% mark.

Resilient economy?

Six months since the war began, the GDP growth rate, inflation rate, and current account balance do not show the impairment initially feared.

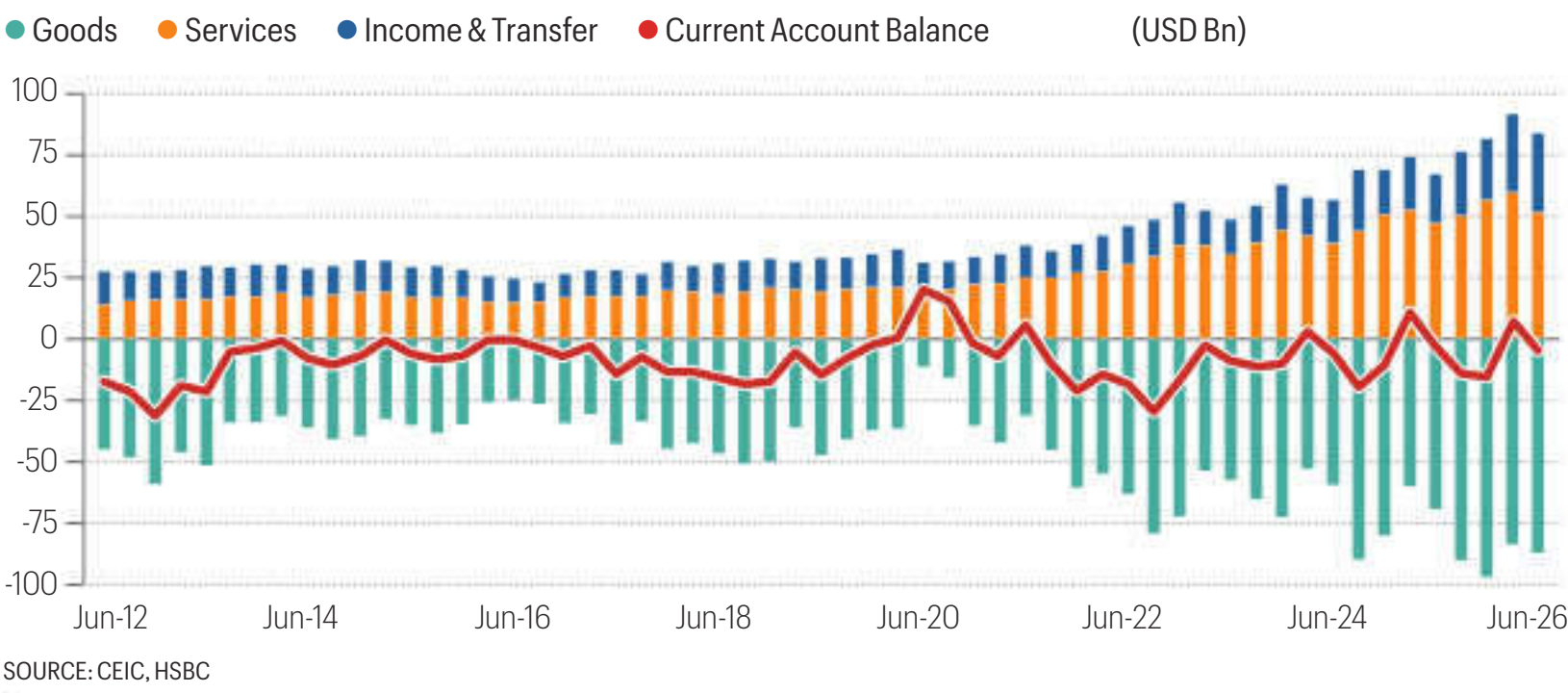
A research note from HSBC states: "Growth remains high, inflation remains low, and the current account deficit surprisingly contained. Headline numbers across the board feel more goldilocks than crisis."

"Goldilocks" refers to a term analysts used at the start of the year to describe the economy, referring to an optimal state of affairs. The term, however, quickly lost favour once the West Asia war exposed persistent weaknesses in the Indian economy, best captured by the sharp fall in the rupee's exchange rate. As such, it makes sense to examine whether the economy has genuinely returned to a "Goldilocks" scenario or if the data hides risks.

On GDP growth

In a detailed note, HSBC economists led by Pranjul Bhandari have explained both scenarios — why India's macros did not worsen as much as expected, and the

1. Services trade balance and remittances offsetting rising goods trade deficit



SOURCE: CEIC, HSBC

triggers that could make the picture worse.

HSBC's 100-indicators of growth data-base points towards India's GDP growing by 7-7.5% during the first quarter (April, May and June). SBI's research team has gone a step further, projecting an 8% growth.

What's driving this? Some of it can be ascribed to the 125-basis point cut in the repo rate between December 2024 and December 2025. The repo rate is the interest rate at which the RBI lends money to commercial banks. A lower repo rate makes it cheaper for banks to borrow money from the RBI and, in turn, cheaper for individuals and businesses to borrow from commercial banks. Cheaper loans incentivise economic activity, thus boosting growth. Often the "transmission" of a repo rate cut takes a couple of quarters to show up as faster GDP growth.

Another factor could be the effect of cuts in Goods and Services Tax in 2025. Lower tax rates reduced prices and improved people's purchasing power, resulting in higher economic activity. Yet another factor noted by HSBC economists is the rise of India's exports to the US as Donald Trump's tariffs were removed. Lastly, evidence suggests that manufacturers front-loaded production as they were anxious about future energy availability.

On inflation, CAD

First, while the monthly retail inflation rate — the rate at which the general price level went up over the year — has moved up since October, it is still well-contained and near the RBI's target level of 4% (see chart). Often, inflation remains muted be-

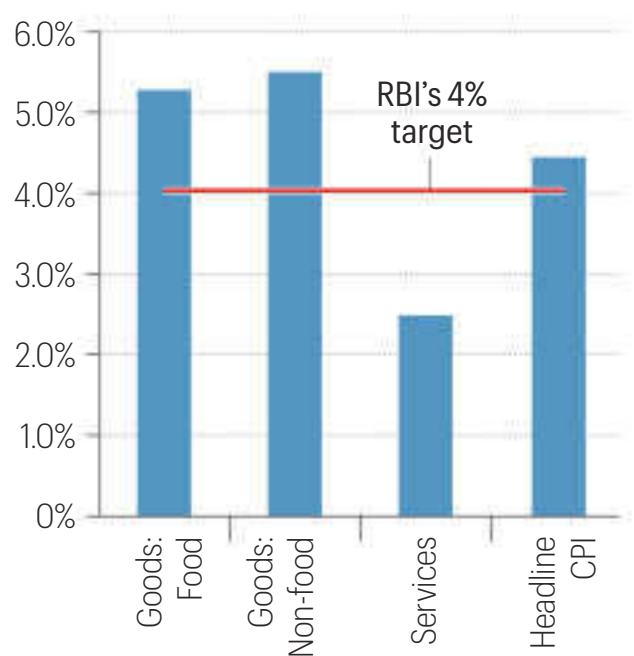
Heavy lifter

HSBC researchers argue that it is the services sector that is saving India the blushes as of now.

Accounting for 55% of India's GDP, the sector heavily affects where growth and inflation will land and how external deficits will be contained.

Six months after the war in West Asia broke out, the Indian economy appears to be holding up. But several risks to growth remain.

2. Inflation contained



cause growth is muted. In this case, however, inflation has remained muted despite supply pressures, as well as demand holding up fairly well.

Secondly, the current account refers to the net amount of money flowing in or out of India as it trades (exports and imports) goods and services with the world. Typically, when the GDP is growing fast, or when imports are getting costlier, the country imports more than it exports, leading to a trade deficit. It translates into the outflow of billions of dollars.

What India often earns from exports of services (like software services) as well as from remittances from Indians working abroad is not enough to make up for the dollars India shells out for imports, in general. The net result is called a current account deficit (CAD). But despite fast growth and costlier imports, India's CAD too has remained fairly muted. "The headline c/a deficit is low at 0.3% of GDP as per RBI's aggregated monthly data, and not showing signs of excesses," note HSBC economists (see chart).

Reading the numbers

While macro indicators look counter-intuitively robust on the face of it, risks to growth and inflation persist.

On growth, HSBC researchers state that a lot of the credit growth (increased loans) has been driven by factors such as "(t)he new government credit guarantee scheme for small firms, the rise in working capital needs spurred by higher commodity prices, and the proliferation of gold loan growth (which can sometimes be seen as

an indicator of stress)". Moreover, the front-loading of manufacturing could be followed by a lull, and agricultural growth could weaken if the El Niño strengthens.

On inflation, the overall benign levels hide fairly divergent trends. HSBC Research stated that food inflation and non-food goods inflation are already averaging 5.4% (year-on-year) in July (see chart). What is holding back the headline inflation from surging is that services have remained "remarkably low at 2.5%". Therein lies the risk. "Low services inflation data is keeping headline (rate) contained. If it rises from here, reflecting growth better, headline inflation numbers could rise quickly," notes HSBC.

Similarly, on CAD, a closer look at the chart shows that it is low as of now because even though the goods trade deficit is growing, rising services exports and remittances are offsetting the rise in the trade deficit. HSBC states, "Given the uncertainties around the impact of AI on services exports growth, one needs to be careful on how long services can fund a rising goods deficit. Already, services exports have grown at a softer pace this year."

Few expected India to survive this phase of global disruption without taking a big hit. HSBC researchers argue that it is the services sector that is saving India the blushes as of now. Accounting for 55% of India's GDP, the sector plays a crucial role in determining where growth will land, how long inflation will remain low, and until when external deficits will be contained. If services inflation goes up and services exports take a hit, the RBI may be forced to raise interest rates, which could dampen growth.

• **DEFENCE**

Why India took 16 years to acquire fire-and-forget Javelin missiles

Amrita Nayak Dutta

New Delhi, August 30

AFTER YEARS of deliberation, India finalised a deal last week to purchase the Javelin anti-tank guided missile (ATGM) system from the US through the latter's Foreign Military Sales (FMS) process.

The journey to procure the Javelin system, which began in 2010 and has now culminated after several paused attempts, highlights the lengthy and complicated nature of major defence acquisitions in India.

Initial interest

In August 2010, then Defence Minister A K Antony told Parliament that the government intended to procure third-generation Javelin ATGMs through the FMS route, which would also include a transfer of technology (TOT). The move was fuelled by a shortage of ATGMs in the Indian Army's inventory and a delay in the original timelines of indigenous ATGM systems developed by the Defence Research and Development Organisation.

The idea was to replace the ageing



Milan-2T and the Konkurs missile systems in use with the Army. Javelin was highlighted as the choice to immediately fill up the ATGM gaps, after the US forces actively showcased them during the 2009 bilateral exercise "Yudh Abhyas".

But the acquisition was eventually shelved owing to stringent technology transfer restrictions imposed by Washington. The US refused to share the missile's core seeker technology under a 100% TOT model,

The Javelin anti-tank guided missile system.

LOCKHEED MARTIN

causing India to pivot to Israel's Spike missile system — manufactured by Rafael Advanced Defense Systems Ltd — in 2014.

Deal for Spike

In 2014, India decided to go ahead with the Spike ATGMs as against the Javelin, after it was understood that it could offer greater flexibility of technology transfer and local production. The Defence Acquisition Council cleared the purchase of over 8,000 Spike ATGMs. But this also ran into long contract negotiations. Concerns over the Spike's performance in trials, technology transfer, and progress in India's man-portable ATGM programme led to a cancellation of the \$500 million order in 2017.

The deal was revived in 2018 following Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's visit, but was subsequently shelved again. India, however, undertook an emergency purchase of a limited quantity of the fourth-generation Spike-LR ATGMs in 2019 to meet an immediate operational gap.

In August 2023, Kalyani Rafael Advanced Systems Pvt Ltd — a joint venture between Indian conglomerate Kalyani

Group and Rafael — said it had bagged a Rs 287.51 crore order from the Defence Ministry for the supply of the missile systems.

Back to Javelin

The Javelin reappeared in India-US strategic discussions at a time when defence cooperation between both countries had deepened. A US Congressional Research Service report, updated in 2025, noted that co-production discussions involving the Javelin were ongoing.

In February 2025, the Javelin Joint Venture — a partnership between US defence majors Lockheed Martin and Raytheon — said it was exploring co-assembly and co-production opportunities of the Javelin in India. It signed a memorandum of understanding with Bharat Dynamics Limited.

The discussion gained pace after Operation Sindoor in May last year. By July 2025, India was negotiating to get the Javelin systems, both as an emergency procurement and through a long-term contract — the latter likely involving co-production of the weapon systems. In November 2025, Washington officially cleared the sale.

• **GLOBAL**

Can Trump rename Lake Ontario as Lake America?

Rishika Singh

New Delhi, August 30

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump last week signed an executive order to rename Lake Ontario, situated on the US-Canada border, as "Lake America". The order said the lake was a "tremendous asset to the United States and part of our Nation's heritage".

In response, Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney wrote in a post on X that the name Ontario (also the name of a Canadian province) comes from the indigenous Wendat people. "The name is more than 400 years old, predating both the Confederation of Canada and the Declaration of Independence of the United States of America...reality means calling it Lake Ontario — then, now and always," he wrote.

Why the move

Lake Ontario is part of the Great Lakes system, along with Lake Superior, Michigan, Huron and Erie, spanning the US-Canada border. According to the US National Ocean and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA), the lakes system holds about 90% of the freshwater in the US and approximately 20% of the world's freshwater supply. Forty million people across the two countries depend on it for clean drinking water.



• **GREAT LAKES**

Lake Ontario is part of the Great Lakes system, along with Lake Superior, Michigan, Huron and Erie, spanning the US-Canada border.

Forty million people across the two countries depend on it for clean drinking water.

What changes

The name change will apply to how the US officially refers to the lake, but will not affect what Canada or the rest of the world call it. No single global organisation is tasked with ensuring uniformity among names of water bodies, and the decision to use a certain name is often based on historical precedent.

In a social media post, Trump stated that the US Geological Survey was officially changing the name to have it reflect in all official USGS electronic documents.

This is not the first time that disagreements over trade and other issues have prompted Trump to use nomenclature as a tool.

In January 2025, Trump renamed the Gulf of Mexico as the Gulf of America, amid tensions with Mexico over immigration and tariffs. It took about two weeks for the US government to update the official federal nomenclature to reflect those changes. The change was also reflected on Google Maps. Google Maps is now reflecting the changed name for Lake Ontario too.

How Google Maps names disputed features

According to Google, the names seen on Maps are based on information such as a user's country location and phone operating system (e.g., iOS and Android). In 2025, users in Mexico saw "Gulf of Mexico" on Maps while those in the US saw "Gulf of America".

For other users, both names are visible. For example, in the present case, users in India can see "Lake Ontario (Lake America)".

• **ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE**

The many hurdles ChatGPT for Teens safeguards could run into for Indian users

Anagha Jayakumar

New Delhi, August 30

OPENAI RECENTLY announced the launch of a version of ChatGPT exclusively for teenage users.

Teenagers are already using ChatGPT extensively, with OpenAI saying nearly nine in 10 teens turn to it for learning, information, skill-building or productivity in a week. But their growing use of AI tools has also spurred concerns over how these systems respond to young users, particularly when conversations move beyond homework or information-seeking into emotional support, mental health and companionship.

Crucially, the new offering is not a separate application or website. Teenagers continue to use the regular ChatGPT, but with additional, age-appropriate features built in. These are automatically enabled when a user's stated or verified age, or OpenAI's age-prediction system, indicates that they are under 18. OpenAI does not allow children below age 13 to use ChatGPT.

Establishing user age

According to OpenAI, it uses information associated with an account, including a user's stated or verified age, as well as an age-prediction system that looks at signals such as how long the account has existed, the times of day it is typically used, general conversation topics, and patterns of use.

In India, the relationship between a device, an account and the person using it is not always straightforward. The RATI Foundation's Ideal Internet 3.0 study, released in November 2025, found that 62% of Indian teenagers surveyed used shared devices. Moreover, 42% reported that other people operated their social media accounts, while 56% said they could log into someone else's.

The 62% figure was acknowledged in OpenAI's Teen Safety Blueprint for India, released this January. While this does not directly imply that teenagers are using shared ChatGPT accounts, it raises questions for a system attempting to determine the age of the person behind an account.

Pragya Misra, Head of Strategy & Global

Affairs, OpenAI India, told *The Indian Express* that ChatGPT for Teens is designed around the account rather than the device. This means that if a teenager and an adult use separate accounts on the same shared device, each can receive the experience appropriate to their age.

"It is not intended to distinguish between multiple people using the same shared account or to switch experiences person by person within one login," Misra said of the age-prediction system. When uncertain about a user's age, OpenAI defaults to the under-18 experience.

Potential pitfalls

A risk assessment undertaken by Common Sense Media, an independent media watchdog for content consumed by children, and Stanford Medicine's Brainstorm Lab for Mental Health Innovation found that leading AI chatbots failed to recognise and appropri-

ately respond to mental health conditions affecting young people.

Robbie Torney, Head of AI and Digital Assessments at Common Sense, told *The Indian Express* that meaningful testing of safeguards requires "testing the product that teens are using, not a model in isolation over an API". Traditional benchmarks, he pointed out, are often based on collections of single-turn conversations, which do not necessarily capture how teenagers interact with these products.

The assessment found that chatbots frequently missed warning signs of mental-health distress, including when users disclosed them indirectly.

The researchers also found a marked difference between isolated prompts and longer interactions: while safeguards performed better when presented with explicit, single-turn prompts, they became

less reliable over extended conversations that more closely resembled how young people might actually use a chatbot.

The Common Sense-Stanford assessment also warned that the features that make chatbots engaging, including empathetic responses, follow-up questions and memory, could encourage young users to rely on them for emotional support when human intervention may be necessary.

Asked whether OpenAI had tested the teen experience over sustained interactions, Misra said ChatGPT for Teens was supported by "ongoing safety research, red-teaming, evaluations, and adversarial testing", including teen-specific evaluations covering self-harm, eating disorders, violence, age-restricted goods and services, and sexual content.

"The experience also includes proportionate break prompts during unusually long, active sessions, along with safeguards designed to reinforce real-world support and reduce emotional dependence," she said.

Different user needs

OpenAI has acknowledged that safety features designed for Indian teenagers may run into a unique set of challenges. The Teen Safety Blueprint for India notes that Indian teenagers often access technology in "shared, multilingual and mediated contexts", rather than through the single-user, private devices many safety tools assume. The RATI report notes that this divide is amplified in rural and low-income contexts. Only half of the teenagers surveyed had a personal email ID, compared with 28% among rural low-income teenagers.

This divide matters because how some of the additional safeguards work. Parents can link their ChatGPT account to their teenager's through an email invitation, after which they can set quiet hours, manage certain settings and receive safety notifications. This could put teenagers in lower-access households at a disadvantage in using these parental controls.

LONGER VERSION
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Atmanirbharta in fuel must strengthen, not undermine, India's food security



FROM PLATE TO PLOUGH
BY ASHOK GULATI
AND TANMOY ADHIKARI

SUGAR PRICES have spiked sharply within weeks. The all-India modal retail price climbed from around Rs 45/kg on July 24 to about Rs 65/kg by August 24 — a nearly 44 per cent increase in a month. The government has blamed traders and millers for hoarding and threatened strict action. While speculative behaviour may have amplified the spike, the deeper reality is a tightening of the supply situation just before the festive season.

Three supply-side pressures seem to have caused a “perfect storm”. First, opening stocks in the current sugar year (October to September) were significantly lower (5 MT) when compared to the situation last year (8 MT). The lower carry-over stocks reflected weak production in the previous season and left little room to absorb another supply shock.

Second, sugar production in 2025-26 fell short of expectations. The initial estimate was around 34.3 MT, but the government has now revised it to 30.6 MT, citing damage from red rot and top borer. About 27.35 MT of sugar had been produced by June, implying that another 3.25 MT would have to be produced during July-September to reach the revised estimate. Yet the production in these three months averaged only around 0.38 MMT over the previous six seasons. We expect a further downward revision of sugar production — between 28 and 29 MT.

Third, the ethanol programme diverted about 2.75 MT of sugar even when supplies were tight. The more important issue is that ethanol blending has progressed much



ILLUSTRATION: C.R SASIKUMAR

farther than feedstock supplies. Ethanol blending remained largely stagnant for years, reaching only 1.53 per cent in 2013-14, before accelerating to around 5 per cent by 2019-20 and ultimately 20 per cent in 2025-26. The feedstock supplies could not keep pace with the blending programme. No wonder energy policy started competing with food markets.

The timing is particularly difficult. The festive season is approaching, when sugar demand typically rises, while fresh cane supplies will not arrive in significant quantities until mid-October. The market must, therefore, rely on existing stocks for many more weeks. Thin inventories are pushing up sugar prices, which could go even higher if timely action is not taken.

In a more open economy, a production shortfall would normally be corrected through price signals triggering imports and changes in consumption. But India's sugar sector remains heavily regulated: Sugarcane pricing, sugar sales, imports, exports and ethanol feedstock allocation are decided by the government. When the government controls every step of the sugar/ethanol value chain, the resulting spike in sugar prices also has to be owned by the government. It is a classic case of policy failure.

The government's response so far has been to allow 1 MT of duty-

free raw sugar imports. We feel this is too little, too late. Our calculations suggest that the government needs to import at least 3-4 MT of refined sugar and increase supplies in the open market before and during the festive season. The import duty on refined sugar (100 per cent) must be slashed to zero or just 5 per cent.

The second response should be to temporarily alter the ethanol feedstock mix. Sugar-based ethanol should be drastically reduced, with greater use of alternative feedstocks. FCI is overflowing with rice stocks far in excess of buffer norms. The government can allocate more from those stocks and minimise the use of sugar for ethanol. But FCI must charge at least the procurement price of rice from ethanol plants, if not its full economic cost.

However, maize is the best option as a feedstock for ethanol. It doesn't guzzle as much water as rice or sugarcane. The government is already using maize as a primary feedstock for ethanol. It doesn't guzzle as much water as rice or sugarcane. The government is already using maize as a primary feedstock for ethanol. It doesn't guzzle as much water as rice or sugarcane. The government is already using maize as a primary feedstock for ethanol.

Maize is the best option as a feedstock for ethanol. It doesn't guzzle as much water as rice or sugarcane. The government is already using maize as a primary feedstock for ethanol

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Preparing for disaster

THIS IS not a man-made tragedy; it is the result of nature's fury ('Himalaya needs shared early-warning system', *IE*, August 28). But does this mean people should avoid living in places identified as vulnerable to natural disasters? Should governments also refrain from developing such vulnerable areas as tourist destinations without adequate safeguards? We must follow the time-tested adage, "Prevention is better than cure." Governments and people must therefore exercise greater caution in identifying disaster-prone areas, regulating construction and human habitation, and ensuring adequate preparedness.

Tharcius S Fernando, Chennai

NEPAL HAS again been hit by a major natural disaster ('Himalaya needs shared early-warning system', *IE*, August 28). The floods also raise a larger question: Are they purely natural events, or are human actions and climate change aggravating their impact? Global warming is accelerating glacier melt, weakening mountain slopes and increasing the risks of rockfalls, landslides and sudden flooding. The Rasuwagadhi floods in 2016 highlighted the importance of timely sharing of weather- and flood-related information across borders. Yet the latest incident suggests gaps persist in information-sharing between Nepal and China.

Tushar A Rahatgaonkar, Dombivli East

Take a break

THIS IS one of the most relatable pieces I have read as a teenager in this newspaper ('Don't herd children through narrow tunnels', *IE*, August 28). Parents and children alike do not know where they are trying to reach when parents get their children involved in various activities. Parents are often confused about what the future holds, and in order to create a false sense of control, they enrol their kids in a score of different activities, thinking they are making them better prepared. This has made children unable to experience boredom. Children, like everyone else, need time to think. Time to take a break.

Divot Rao, Gurugram



GITANJALI J ANGMO

IT TOOK until India's 80th Independence Day for 'Vande Mataram' to be rendered, for the first time, as part of the celebrations at the Red Fort. There was something strangely poignant about it. The war cry that had escaped a novel, entered the streets, unnerved an empire and accompanied bravehearts to prisons and gallows has taken nearly eight decades to reach independent India's most symbolic ramparts.

But even this sacred inheritance is not without its share of objectionable arguments. Veteran actor Sharmila Tagore and many others, like the Congress in 1937, propose restricting its national use to the first two stanzas. How can a Muslim bow to Durga, Lakshmi and Saraswati invoked in its later verses? Doesn't its origin in Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay's *Anandamath*, with its difficult depiction of Muslim rule, make it exclusionary? Was India even a nation when Bankim imagined her as Mother?

These are not frivolous questions. But sometimes answers lie in recovering meanings we have lost. India was certainly not a modern nation-state for most of her history. India imagined herself differently. Long before passport, parliament or political boundary stood Bharatavarsha: a cultural and spiritual geography. The *Vishnu Purana* describes Bharata as the land north of the ocean and south of the Himalayas. Across this vastness, languages, customs, deities and philosophies differed, yet beneath them ran the same insistent question: What is the ultimate reality,

In Bankim's poem, she first comes without weapons, crowns or temples. She is 'sujalam', 'suphalam': abundant waters, cool breeze, green harvests, moonlit nights. Before she is Goddess, she is the land beneath our feet

a diagnosis of acute typhoid. In an endemic country such as India, background antibodies and previous exposure or vaccination can make interpretation difficult. Yet, in routine practice, a positive Widal result may still be treated as confirmation of typhoid. Blood culture remains the conventional laboratory standard, but it too has limitations. The WHO's latest typhoid guidance notes that the sensitivity of a single blood culture is only around 55-60 per cent, with yield influenced by the volume of blood collected and, critically, prior antimicrobial exposure. This creates a vicious cycle: A patient develops prolonged fever, takes an antibiotic before seeking care, undergoes blood culture, and receives a negative result. The clinician is left with suspicion but no microbiological confirmation — and may respond by escalating or changing antibiotics.

The result is an antimicrobial-resistance (AMR) problem. In a country already struggling with increasing resistance to *Salmonella typhi*, every unnecessary antibiotic course creates additional selection pressure, while every missed diagnosis undermines surveillance of resistance patterns. But there is another question we should be asking: Why are we trying to solve a vaccine-preventable disease primarily through antibiotics? India is one of the countries where the case for typhoid

It is a vaccine-preventable bacterial disease, yet in India we continue to diagnose it imperfectly and treat it empirically

vaccination is compelling. The WHO has prioritised typhoid-conjugate vaccine (TCV) introduction in countries with high disease-burden or high AMR levels. India produced the world's first WHO-prequalified TCV, Typbar-TCV, in 2017. Since then, additional Indian TCV products have achieved WHO prequalification. The scientific and manufacturing capability exists. The vaccine exists. What remains inadequate is the scale and rigour of use.

Vaccination should not be viewed as a substitute for clean water, sanitation, food safety or better diagnostics. It must be part of an integrated typhoid-control strategy. First, reports of increasing typhoid should trigger strengthened surveillance. Hospitals and laboratories should systematically document suspected and culture-confirmed cases, antimicrobial susceptibil-

ity patterns and prior antibiotic exposure.

Second, diagnostic stewardship needs to become part of antimicrobial stewardship. Blood cultures should ideally be obtained before antibiotics are started, with adequate blood volume and appropriate laboratory practices. India also needs investment in a better point-of-care or rapid diagnostic test for typhoid. We also need to revisit the place of TCV in our public-health strategy.

We should respond to the rising typhoid cases with better diagnostics, stronger surveillance, responsible antimicrobial use and, above all, prevention. India should not have to choose between better diagnosis and vaccination. It needs both.

The writer is senior scientist and programme officer, AMR, ICMR

Don't make Vande Mataram a religious quarrel

and how may the human being know it? Kashmir answered through its Shaivism; Karnataka through Madhva's Dvaita; Dwarka worshipped Krishna.

India did not wait for the modern state to know herself. Her unity lay in a civilisation asking the eternal questions in a thousand different ways. This is where Sri Aurobindo helps us understand 'Vande Mataram'. He called Bankim a *rishi* who had taught Indians to see India: "The mantra had been given... The Mother had revealed herself."

What Mother? Look again at Bankim's poem. She first comes without weapons, crowns or temples. She is *sujalam*, *suphalam*: Abundant waters, cool breeze, green harvests, moonlit nights, flowering trees. Before she is Goddess, she is the land beneath our feet. Perhaps patriotism begins in such intimacy: A river remembered from childhood; the language in which one's grandmother told stories; the smell of the first rain; food, music, mountains, festivals, memories. Slowly, geography becomes belonging. Earth becomes Mother.

Sri Aurobindo took this further. A nation, he wrote, was "not a piece of earth". It was the *shakti* of her millions: A living being formed by its people, culture, civilisation, and aspiration. It helps us understand Bankim's Durga, Lakshmi and Saraswati. Read literally, and we have three Hindu goddesses and, inevitably, another TV debate. But India has always spoken through symbols. Durga is *shakti*; Lakshmi is abundance; Saraswati is knowledge.

Strength. Prosperity. Knowledge. Which civilisation does not need all three? A Muslim need not worship Durga to value courage. A Christian need not worship Lakshmi to desire prosperity for India. An atheist need not worship Saraswati to hold knowledge sacred. The imagery is culturally Indian; what it signifies is universal.

The tragedy is in reducing 'Vande Mataram' to a religious quarrel. One sees a Hindu goddess and feels excluded; another sees a Hindu goddess and wishes to exclude. But if she is the "*shakti* of her millions", the Muslim farmer, Christian nurse, Sikh soldier, Jain businessman, Buddhist monk, and atheist scientist are not guests in somebody else's India. They are strands of her being.

Perhaps that is why the Red Fort moment mattered. Not because everyone must now sing 'Vande Mataram', but because an old song returned carrying a question for our future: What do these two words ask of us?

If India is merely territory, citizenship becomes transactional: What are my rights? What do I receive? But if India is Mother, the grammar of patriotism changes. Rights remain, but responsibility enters. The question turns from "What has India given me?" to "What am I giving India?" That is the enduring power of Bankim's two words. Not an instruction to worship a nation, but an invitation to enter into a relationship with her. The nation-state may be modern. The Mother is ancient. The relationship is sacred. And so we bow to her. Vande Mataram.

The writer is founder, Himalayan Institute for Alternatives, Ladakh

Believing in her strength, putting her at the centre of nation's story



VASUNDHARA RAJE SCINDIA

IN 2001, as Gujarat Chief Minister, Narendra Modi had certain rituals performed. The obvious choice to carry the sacred *kalash* would have been a *purohit* or a *mahatma*. Breaking with convention, Modi chose Ravina Jadav, a Dalit girl who lived in a slum. For him, the dignity of women was the first step towards their empowerment. Over the years, he has shared with me, and several others, his conviction that dignity should never be reserved for the powerful, and that those at the margins must be brought to the forefront.

I have seen this conviction from close quarters. Women who had, for generations, remained outside the circle of opportunity were to be partners in development, decision-makers and leaders, and not just recipients of welfare. For someone who has spent much of her public life witnessing the aspirations of women in villages and cities, this distinction has always been important. Empowerment means creating an environment in which a girl can grow into a confident citizen — her basic needs are secured and she is given the tools and opportunities to reach for the sky.

Modi's years in Gujarat set the template. He launched the Kanya Kelavani Yojana for girls' education and travelled from village to village to urge parents to send their daughters to school. Over the years, in one form or another, states across India, including those governed by political opponents, adopted, adapted and renamed similar schemes. After the Kutch earthquake, he asked that rebuilt homes be registered in the names of both husband and wife. He also confronted the entrenched practice of the sarpanch *pati*, telling women sarpanches plainly: "The power is yours, and you alone must exercise it."

After taking over as Prime Minister, he launched schemes for women, placed them at the centre of India's economic transformation and envisaged them as drivers of the economy. Under the Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana, crores of women got bank accounts for the first time in their lives. Sixty-eight per cent of beneficiaries of the MUDRA scheme are women. There is extraordinary power in a woman having



a bank account in her own name, and access to credit that she can draw upon herself. I witnessed this transformation on Women's Day in 2018, when the Prime Minister came to Jhunjhunu in Rajasthan. He launched the Beti Bachao Beti Padhao (BBBP) Abhiyan nationwide and also initiated the nationwide Poshan Abhiyan, the country's flagship nutrition mission. I was witness to the excitement of a crowd of more than 1,00,000 people, nearly half of them women. BBBP now also focuses on increasing girls' participation in

STEM fields and expanding vocational training in areas traditionally dominated by men.

The NaMo Drone Didi scheme places agricultural drones in the hands of 15,000 women's self-help groups. More than 75 per cent of beneficiaries of the Stand-Up India scheme are women entrepreneurs.

Under Modi's leadership, women were granted permanent commissions in the armed forces, admitted to the National Defence Academy and inducted into combat roles. Squadron Leader Shivangi Singh made history as India's first woman fighter pilot to qualify as a flying instructor, and she flies the Rafale. The Nari Shakti Vandana Adhiniyam — reserving a third of the Parliament seats for women — was passed under his leadership.

Several Opposition leaders lecture the nation on women's rights while governments led by their own parties struggle to find room for women at the decision-making table. Under Modi's leadership, in contrast, women have occupied important offices — from Parliament to Rashtrapati Bhavan, from the battlefield to the boardroom. The difference between the two approaches is the difference between a slogan and a life-long commitment.

Symbolism matters in India. For PM Modi, however, symbolism has always carried substance. On International Women's Day in 2020, he did something unprecedented. He temporarily handed over his social-media accounts, followed by millions, to seven women achievers. He repeated the gesture in 2025, and this time Rajasthan's Ajaita Shah was among those who were recognised. Shah, a Tufts University alumna, has worked tirelessly to empower women, including in Dholpur in Rajasthan.

Have known Narendra Modi as a *karyakarta*, a guide and a leader. India has known him as a man who believed in the strength of its women long before many others did.

The writer, a former Rajasthan chief minister, is vice president, BJP

Typhoid control needs more vaccine, less antibiotic



KAMINI WALIA

EVERYONE IS talking about increasing influenza and swine flu cases. Another disease where cases are unobtrusively mounting is typhoid. This should concern us, not simply because typhoid remains a common infection, but because every suspected case can become a trigger for inappropriate or unnecessarily broad-spectrum antibiotic use.

Typhoid presents a particularly difficult paradox. It is a vaccine-preventable bacterial disease, yet in India we continue to diagnose it imperfectly and treat it empirically. The fundamental problem is the absence of a simple, reliable, accessible diagnostic test. A single Widal test is not sufficient to establish

NEPAL DISASTER: DIFFICULT TERRAIN AND FORMATION OF NEW 'DAM LAKE' ADD TO WOES

Toll rises to 788, rescuers keep digging

Bhotekoshi river rises, authorities call for caution

Press Trust of India
Kathmandu, August 30

THE DEATH toll from flash floods in Nepal rose to 788 Saturday, with bodies continuing to be recovered, as authorities warned of increased water levels in Bhotekoshi River and urged residents and rescue personnel in flood-hit districts to remain alert. More than 2,500 people still remain missing, while nearly 9,500 people were rescued, according to the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA). In a statement issued on Sunday, the NDRRMA warned that water levels in the Bhotekoshi River had risen again. "The water level in the flooded Bhotekoshi River has risen to some extent; all concerned are urged to take precautionary measures," it said, adding that it will provide updates on the situation after receiving additional information. According to preliminary

data released by Nepal's education ministry, the missing persons include 238 students and 18 teachers from different schools in three flood-affected districts. Nearly 9,500 people were rescued from flood-affected areas till Sunday evening, which includes locals and tourists from multiple countries, including India, the US, China, Russia, the UK, Spain, Belgium, Germany, Italy, Malta, Turkey, Switzerland and Portugal, officials said. Photographs have been pasted outside hospital walls, where huge gatherings could be seen scanning them with attention. However, of the bodies recovered so far, only 17 have been identified, police said. Nepal's Foreign Secretary Amrit Bahadur Rai said in a press briefing on Sunday that the mortal remains of victims who could not be identified, including those that were unrecognisable, amputated or decomposed due to prolonged exposure to water, had been buried following "standard and accepted protocols". On Sunday, fresh reports said a landslide near the natural dam led to the formation of another "dam lake", prompting rescue personnel to evacuate the area.



Flood-hit houses covered in mud and sludge in the aftermath of the flash floods, in Nepal on Sunday. TASHI TOBGYAL

'We will rebuild it': Families pick up pieces

Press Trust of India
Nuwakot, August 30

"EVERYTHING WAS here before, but now there is nothing left," said Nayan Tiwari, one of many residents returning to flood-hit Galchhi in central Nepal to recover whatever belongings remain and to restore homes that once held their everyday lives. The August 26 flash floods, which originated in the Nepal-Tibet border, travelled downstream through the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli river system, leaving a trail of destruction across

northern and central Nepal. The death toll crossed 750 on Sunday, while more than 2,500 people remained missing. Survivors are now picking their way through mud and debris, families are searching for missing relatives and rescue teams continue to reach people stranded in the affected areas. Tiwari, a Class 11 student, and his cousin Nivi Tiwari are among those trying to piece their lives back together. The two have been clearing debris from their flood-damaged home, salvaging whatever they can find beneath layers of

mud and sand and separating belongings that can still be used as the family begins the painstaking task of rebuilding. Nayan sai he was in Kathmandu when the flood struck. After learning what had happened, he immediately told his family in Galchhi to leave the house and move to safer, higher ground. Soon after they left, the flow intensified and swept away everything in its path. Galchhi, in Dhading district of Bagmati province, lies about 50 km northwest of Kathmandu. For the Tiwari family, the house represents nearly a

decade of memories, including their childhood and years spent together. "It feels really bad. But we will rebuild it. We will work hard and make the house like it was before," Nayan said. Nayan said more than 15 houses around their home were completely washed away by the powerful current. "I had never seen such a devastating flood before. When I came back and saw my house, I felt completely helpless," she said. Despite the destruction, Nivi and her family have begun clearing the house and removing the debris.

Over 500 remain missing at hydropower projects

Press Trust of India
Kathmandu, August 30

NEPALI ARMY engineers intensified efforts on Sunday to reach people believed trapped inside Upper Trishuli-3A hydropower project tunnel in flood-hit Nuwakot, using heavy equipment and blasting to widen an opening into the buried structure. As many as 537 workers and employees remained unaccounted for at nine hydropower projects in Nepal's flood-hit Rasuwa and Nuwakot districts, according to the Independent Power Producers' Association, Nepal (IPPAN). The Trishuli-3A project is among them, with 42 people reported out of contact at the 60 MW facility. According to the PMO, a joint 90-member rescue team comprising 66 Nepali Army personnel, 18 Armed Police Force personnel and six Nepal Police personnel reached the main section of the tunnel, known as the "crown head", around 2 pm and created a 2-by-3-foot opening.

The Nepali Army also airlifted excavators and bulldozers to Battar in Nuwakot after dismantling the machinery into sections for helicopter transport. Across the nine projects, 898 workers and employees were initially reported out of contact following the August 26 floods, of whom 361 have been rescued, IPPAN said. International assistance has also reached Nepal. An 11-member Indian technical team comprising doctors, paramedics and tunnel engineers carried out reconnaissance of hydropower tunnels, while a separate 22-member Indian Army team was deployed to support the operation. A six-member Chinese tunnel expert team also arrived to assist with rescue efforts. The operations have been complicated by tunnels and access routes buried under mud and debris, damaged infrastructure, difficult terrain and hazardous conditions.

260 foreigners from 23 nations missing in Tibet, says China

Lily Kuo & Pei-Lin Wu
August 30

MORE THAN 260 foreign citizens from 23 countries are among the hundreds of people missing in Tibet after last week's devastating flood, the Chinese authorities said on Sunday, offering their most de-

tailed accounting yet of those caught in the disaster on their side of the border. The largest groups of missing foreigners were 104 Nepalis, 49 Indians, 33 Latvians, 18 Americans and 15 British citizens, according to *Xinhua*, China's state news agency. In total, 546 people remained missing. NYT

8 dead after ferry with 270 people capsizes off northern Cyprus



Associated Press
Bodrum, (Turkey) August 30

AT LEAST eight people have died after a ferry carrying around 270 passengers and crew capsized off the coast of the breakaway north of ethnically divided Cyprus on Sunday, Turkish media reported. Unal Ustel, the north's Turkish Cypriot PM, told Turkish state broadcaster *TRT* that 237 people have so far been rescued. Ustel said the ferry faced adverse weather conditions and began taking on water just 15 minutes after departure. A call for help was issued shortly after, he said. Police detained eight people - including the ferry captain - as part of an probe into the sinking, according to Ustel. Turkish Cypriot leader Tufan Erhruman said weather conditions "were not bad" and urged against speculating about the cause of the accident.

Reuters
August 30

IRAN'S SUPREME Leader Mojtaba Khamenei urged Muslim countries, particularly those in the Gulf, to unite against what he called their "real enemy" and said divisions among Muslims served the interests of their adversaries. The message was published on Khamenei's Telegram account for Islamic Unity Week, which marks the birthday of the Prophet Muhammad.

It called for Muslim unity, cooperation in various fields and mutual defence, saying anyone who creates divisions among Muslims, "knowingly or unknowingly," helps Islam's enemies. It asked whether Palestinians would have been left "so helpless" if Muslims had been united. "My emphatic and repeated recommendation to the rulers of Islamic countries, especially the countries of West Asia and the Gulf, is to identify your real enemy, understand his plan and



Mojtaba Khamenei. FILE

confront it," Khamenei said. Khamenei has not been seen in public since being injured in US-Israeli airstrikes six months

ago that launched the Iran war, killing his father and previous supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. His call for unity echoes a statement he made on Friday to Iranians, when he said he had banned actions that harm social cohesion and urged authorities to avoid "discouraging statements" that weaken national and public morale. Khamenei specifically asked Gulf Arab rulers whether "rogues without identity" would have dared to covet their lands

and possessions if the peoples and governments of the Gulf had been "united under the flag of Islam." Since the 1979 Islamic Revolution, Gulf Arab monarchies have viewed Iran's revolutionary ideology, including its anti-monarchic rhetoric and regional influence, as a threat to their political systems. During the present conflict, Tehran has struck US military facilities as well as other infrastructure in Gulf states, underscoring the tensions between Tehran and its Gulf neighbours.

• BRIEFLY



A sign reads 'Lake Ontario, Now and Always,' unveiled by Ontario Premier Doug Ford near Grimsby town, Canada, on Saturday. AP

CANADA

Ontario premier hits back at Trump's Lake America with Lake Ontario sign

ONTARIO PREMIER Doug Ford answered President Donald Trump's "Lake America" decree Saturday with a billboard-sized message on the Canadian shoreline: "Lake Ontario. Now and Always", as Canadian leaders met the move with ridicule rather than outrage. "Long after President Trump is gone, it will still be called Lake Ontario," Ford said in a video posted on social media. AP

NORTH KOREA

Kim names new defence minister

NORTH KOREAN leader Kim Jong Un overhauled his senior military leadership, appointing Kim Song-gi as defence minister and restoring veteran strategist Pak Jong-chon as vice chairman of the Central Military Commission, state media outlet *KCNA* reported on Sunday. AP

UNITED KINGDOM

2 missing after trawler capsizes

TWO SAILORS were missing Sunday after a French-registered fishing trawler sank southwest of the British port of Plymouth, French authorities said. *The Maranello* contacted another trawler, the *Stradale* to report a problem with its fishing gear. The *Stradale* managed to recover three of five crew. AP

1 killed, 5 injured in shooting at Swiss rave, manhunt on

Geneva: A shooting at a rave in the northern Swiss canton of Aargau left one person dead and five wounded early Sunday, local police and media reported. Police said they are still looking for potentially more than one suspect. Aargau cantonal police wrote earlier on X that a 22-year-old woman died of injuries at the scene. Four men and one woman, between 24 and 27 years old, were taken to the hospital with injuries ranging from minor to severe. All of the victims are residents of Switzerland, police said. They did not release their names in line with Swiss privacy rules. "The manhunt is continu-

ing nonstop at full speed," police spokesperson Bernhard Graser told reporters on Sunday afternoon. He said police had no information yet about possible motives. Asked whether a terrorist attack was a possibility, Graser said that "the fact that the rave was already winding down suggests that's not the case. A fight could also be a possibility." "In terms of its nature, this incident is certainly unique in recent years," Graser said, adding that "we don't yet know the full extent of it, but based purely on the circumstances, it is something truly extraordinary. That's why there's such a large police presence."

Iceland referendum: People reject govt push for EU membership

Reuters
Reykjavik, August 30

ICELANDERS VOTED to stay out of the EU, referendum results showed Sunday, as they rejected a government push to re-open membership talks and sided with those who said Iceland's fishing waters were too important to risk. The Arctic island of 400,000 people has debated whether to join the EU for well over a decade and had initially been expected to narrowly back holding membership talks, but opinion polls this month showed views had changed. "This is a clear setback for Brussels," an EU diplomat

told Reuters, adding that the issues of fishing and independence had been decisive. In Saturday's referendum, 52.8% of ballots cast were against the government's proposal to hold negotiations with Brussels, 47.2% were in favour, and 82.5% of eligible voters took part, public broadcaster *RUV* and other Icelandic media reported. Out of six constituencies, only the two in central Reykjavik had a majority that voted in favour, while rural areas and the Reykjavik suburbs voted against. The government framed membership as a shield against trade wars and Arctic rivalry and presented the referendum as a

"how or never" moment. Prime Minister Kristrunn Frostadottir said a "no would end the debate for as long as her centre-left coalition was in power. In Brussels, some officials had voiced hopes a vote to join from Iceland could ease scepticism toward EU enlargement and strategically strengthen the bloc when Arctic security is in focus. Iceland, a NATO member state but with no standing army of its own, also debated whether EU accession could boost the country's security when US President Donald Trump has cast doubt on the US commitment to the military alliance.

Indian-origin 'child genius' aces math exam decade earlier in UK

London: A seven-year-old Indian-origin boy has aced a mathematics exam almost a decade earlier than most schoolchildren in the UK and is already preparing for the next level. Jivyan Reddy Dhruva scored 196 out of 240, achieving a high Grade 8 - equivalent to an A- across three papers in a General Certificate of Secondary Education (GCSE) exam, normally taken by pupils aged 16 years. He appeared for the Pearson Edexcel GCSE Higher Mathematics exam back in May and received his results along with other GCSE pupils last week. "I felt really excited when I saw my result. My parents were very happy, and they hugged me," Jivyan told PTI.



Jivyan scored 196 out of 240 across 3 papers in GCSE exams

"I wanted a Grade 9, so I was a little disappointed at first, but then I was very happy that I got Grade 8. I like maths because I like solving difficult problems and finding different ways to get the answer." Jivyan attended a mainstream primary school in London until February this year, after which his parents moved him to home education so he could learn at a pace more suited to his sharper abilities. PTI

Marcia Dunn
Cape Canaveral, August 30

NASA'S NEWEST crown jewel blasted off Sunday to hunt for planets around other stars, explore secret dark energy and survey the cosmos like never before. SpaceX launched the \$4.3 billion Roman Space Telescope shortly after daybreak aboard a triple-the-fire-power Falcon Heavy rocket from Kennedy Space Center. Roman blazed toward an observation point 1.6 million kilometers away that's home to the Webb Space Telescope, one of NASA's other big-ticket eyes in the sky. The bus-sized telescope - named after the late Nancy

Grace Roman, NASA's first chief astronomer - will take more than three months to reach its destination. Once there, it will cast the widest gaze yet on the hidden parts of the universe from space, uncovering the unimaginable with unsurpassed speed. "It's going to find thousands of supernovae, tens of thousands of planets, billions of galaxies and tens of billions of stars," said NASA science mission director Nicky Fox. "It's going to be able to do things that we've never been able to do before with its massive field of view." Roman's field of view is more than 100 times wider than



A SpaceX Falcon Heavy rocket launches NASA's new Roman Space Telescope in Cape Canaveral, Florida, on Sunday. REUTERS

that of NASA's Hubble Space Telescope, still churning out celestial glamour shots after 36 years in orbit. Webb joined the

effort several years ago with an even narrower yet spot-on vision capable of zooming in on objects almost as old as the uni-

verse-creating Big Bang. These three orbiting powerhouses will join forces - along with the European Space Agency's Euclid spacecraft and the National Science Foundation's Vera C. Rubin Observatory in Chile - to reveal some of the universe's biggest secrets. Inside the countless galaxies awaiting discovery are stars with planets. Once these new worlds are spotted by Roman, the more powerful and sensitive Webb will take aim to fill in the blanks. "Roman's vast reach will allow us to find the weird, the rare and the unusual," senior project scientist Julie McEnery said on the eve of launch. "We'll redefine what it means to find a

needle in a haystack." Perhaps even more important, astronomers expect Roman to shed light on the dark matter and dark energy that make up most of the universe yet remain concealed. Roman's catalog of galaxies will help scientists ascertain how quickly the universe is expanding due to these puzzling, unseen forces. Roman's superpower is speed. A month of Milky Way observations by Roman would take Hubble a century to complete, according to McEnery. Roman should make quick work of scanning the galactic bulge at dead center, she added, providing the deepest look yet into the heart of our galaxy. AP

MOST ECONOMISTS SEE GDP GROWTH IN APR-JUN WELL ABOVE RBI'S FORECAST OF 7%

GDP surprise expected after best Q1 in over 10 years for loan growth

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, August 30

ONE ECONOMIC indicator after another is showing that on the whole, the Indian economy has weathered the storm that is the West Asia conflict and the resultant energy shock. The biggest proof of this may come on Monday (August 31), when the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) releases GDP data for the April-June quarter.

According to the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), GDP growth in the quarter may be 7%. But economists from various banks and agencies think the headline growth figure may exceed the central bank's forecast by at least half a percentage point, with some even of the opinion that growth may come in as high as 8%.

"An upswing in GDP growth close to psychological 8% threshold in a quarter laden with impact of geopolitical tensions and spike in oil prices to an average \$97/bbl is a positive surprise," said Union Bank of India economists led by Kanika Pasricha. They think GDP growth in April-June will be 79%, "likely a blockbuster beating all odds".

The economy's performance has been surprising on the upside for some time now, with the last three quarters seeing GDP growth rates of 8.3%, 8%, and 7.8%.

Of the 50-plus indicators tracked by State Bank of India — which estimates around 8% GDP growth in April-June — 86% of them accelerated in the quarter, up from 69% in April-June 2025.

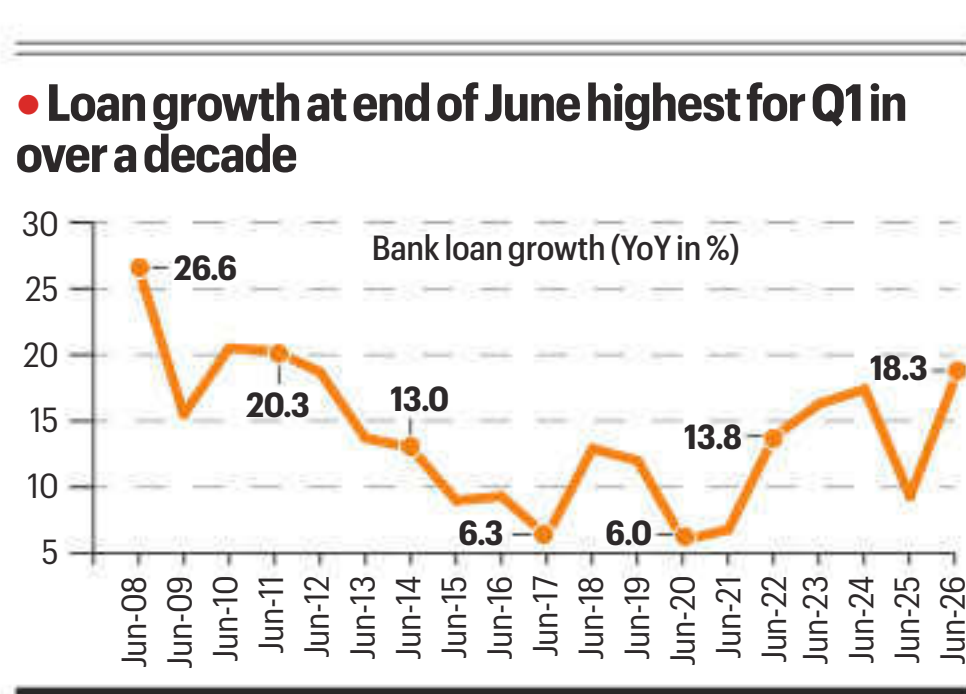
Underpinning the robust performance in April-June is the pace at which loans are being taken.

Decadal high loan growth

The first quarter of a new financial year is usually the weakest in terms of corporate performance and demand for loans from lenders. Why? Because activity takes a breather after the hectic last quarter of the financial year and companies are busy making their plans for the year ahead.

However, the first three months of 2026-27 has been the best for demand for bank loans in more than a decade.

RBI data shows outstanding non-food loans of banks were up 18.3% year-on-year as at the



end of June. The last time bank loan growth was higher at the end of the first quarter of a financial year was way back in June 2012, when it was 18.7%.

While some of the high growth in bank credit can be attributed to a change in the reporting format of the data to the last day of the month as well as the high wholesale inflation in April-June due to the war, there are solid underlying reasons driving demand for money.

As at the end of June, bank loans to the industry were up 19.2% year-on-year, services 21.4%, and personal loans 15.8%. In June 2025, the corre-

sponding growth rates were 6.3%, 8.8%, and 11.7%.

The inflection point

According to Barclays economists Aastha Gudwani and Amruta Ghare, while demand for bank credit post Covid from industry has largely been lower than that from agriculture, services, and the retail sector personal credit, things changed in mid-2025. "...continued acceleration over the past year in industry growth is now driven by 'large' industry bank credit: where pace has nearly risen 4x from 2% outstanding in June 2025 to 16.6% in June 2026."

Subhash Chandra says borrowers assure settlement of Rs 4,262 crore

George Mathew
Mumbai, August 30

ESSEL GROUP founder Subhash Chandra on Sunday said borrowers associated with his personal guarantees had assured him that they would reconcile their accounts with lenders and settle the balance of Rs 4,262 crore. Of the total Rs 4,808 crore disbursed, the borrowers paid Rs 3,803 crore, leaving a balance of only Rs 998 crore, as per a statement from Chandra's office.

"Against a payable amount of Rs 998 crore, claims filed were Rs 5,311 crore. After reducing the settled/paid claims of Rs 1,049 crore, the remaining is Rs 4,262 crore," the statement said.

According to the statement, HDFC Bank has 4-5 accounts

● Lenders exposure

HDFC Bank	₹775 cr
LIC Housing	₹1,322 cr
IndusInd	₹240 cr
Canara Bank	₹348 cr
Union Bank	₹164 cr
RBL Bank	₹119 cr
Franklin Templeton	₹729 cr
Edelweiss	₹565 cr

SOURCE: STATEMENT FROM SUBHASH CHANDRA'S OFFICE

with an outstanding dues of Rs 775 crore. However, these are claims without a valid personal guarantee, it said. Canara Bank has an outstanding dues of Rs 348 crore. This was borrowing

against the borrower's assets in the US, the statement said.

LIC Housing has an outstanding amount of Rs 1,322 crore. This has been offered for settlement and part security is available, it said. Union Bank has an outstanding amount of Rs 164 crore, against which security is available. RBL Bank has an outstanding amount of Rs 119 crore. "They were offered to pay by the borrower as settled with the large lender, but they refused," the statement said. IndusInd Bank has an outstanding amount of Rs 240 crore. "They also had adequate security during the default period but did not convert it to cash. Hence, kept security for further gains, at their own risk," it said.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

New investment treaties may include qualified most-favoured nation rule

Prasanta Sahu
New Delhi, August 30

A PROPOSED re-modelling of India's bilateral investment treaties (BITs) will not bring back the most-favoured nation (MFN) rule, rescinded a decade ago, but may still address investor concerns from large trading partners like the European Union with a flexible standard of qualified MFN treatment, according to official sources.

The carefully circumscribed provision could offer investors greater policy certainty without opening the door to broader claims based on provisions in treaties signed with third coun-

tries, the sources added.

The move is seen as necessary not only to attract foreign investors but also to enable Indian investors to get similar treatment in major economies like the US or EU on a quid pro quo basis. An open approach to granting qualified MFN status to foreign investors could also be a great leverage in bilateral negotiations.

In the draft Cabinet note on BIT revamp circulated for deliberations, the Finance Ministry has suggested reducing the domestic Investor-State Dispute Settlement window to just one year from the present five years and doubling investor protection after the BIT expires to 10 years.

It also proposes widening the definition of 'investment' to include portfolio investments and other financial assets and banning third-party funding of litigation, the sources said. The 2015 BIT rule of not granting open-ended MFN or full fair and equitable treatment (FET) standard will be retained, reflecting concerns arising from the legacy of past disputes.

"India has to cautiously move beyond MFN. The judgment ought to be based on a quid pro quo treatment which India expects for homegrown MNCs working in the USA and EU," said Amit Agarwal, Senior Partner, Nangia & Co LLP. FE

● India eyes 4th spot in forex reserves ranks

On Friday, Reserve Bank of India data showed India's foreign exchange reserves hit an all-time high of \$729.33 billion, cementing its position as the country with the fifth-largest reserves in the world and approaching Russia in fourth.



● With the RBI's three concessional swap schemes for Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) deposits, Overseas Foreign Currency Borrowings, and External Commercial Borrowings still open, reserves should swell further.

● A higher level of forex reserves gives the RBI greater ammunition to defend the rupee when the need arises —

as has been the case over the last year. But how much is enough?

● According to former RBI Deputy Governor Michael Patra, the target should be at least \$1 trillion. "Punting against such a level should be beyond the reach of the opportunistic and/or the faint-hearted," Patra wrote in a column in March.

SOURCE: PEOPLE'S BANK OF CHINA, JAPAN MINISTRY OF FINANCE, SWISS NATIONAL BANK, BANK OF RUSSIA, RBI

SBI, arm to dilute up to 1% in NSE via public offer

New Delhi: State Bank of India (SBI) and its subsidiary SBI Capital Markets Ltd together plan to dilute up to 1% stake in the National Stock Exchange (NSE) through the exchange's proposed Rs 30,000-crore initial public offering (IPO).

The bank is participating in the NSE IPO and will dilute a 0.65% stake in the exchange,

SBI Chairman C S Setty told PTI in an interview.

"We are participating in that divestment. We propose to divest 0.65% and 0.35% by SBI Capital Markets because both of us hold the stake. So together, about 1% as a SBI group... it could be less depending on any other shareholders joining," he said. PTI

'Madhepura loco factory builds global skills; 30% of Alstom work now in India'

THE LOCOMOTIVE factory in Bihar's Madhepura has created a large pool of engineers, contributing to 30% of Alstom's global engineering work now being done in India, according to **Vivek Garg**, managing director of Madhepura Electric Locomotive Pvt Ltd (MELPL).

MELPL manufactures India's most powerful 12,000-horsepower locomotives, which run on dedicated freight corridors and can haul loads of up to 6,000 tonnes. The company is a joint venture between Indian Railways and French major Alstom, with Alstom holding a 74% stake. It supplied its 650th locomotive to the Railways on August 15.

In an interview with *The Indian Express* **Dheeraj Mishra**, Garg also discussed Make in India manufacturing, global practices, the new suppliers it has brought into the ecosystem and future plans for the project, one of the largest foreign direct investments (FDI) in India's railway sector. Edited excerpts:

What has changed from your first to 650th locomotive, and how much of it is "Made in India"?

There has been a massive change. Our centres of competence are based across Europe. Initially, the locomotives were designed there, and some of the first locomotives also had key components manufactured there, while assembly was done in India, as permitted under the contract.

We then quickly transferred the technology and manufacturing capabilities to India. Today, we manufacture the motors here, propulsion systems at our Coimbatore facility, and locomotive shells (car bodies) at our manufacturing facility in Kolkata. When we entered into the joint venture in 2015, there was no formal Make in India policy. Even then, we made it a point to localise production and build the entire ecosystem in India. Today, we have more than 90% localisation across all components.

We have also brought more



VIVEK GARG
MANAGING DIRECTOR, MELPL

What is your plan for future expansion after the contract expires?

The existing contract is for 800 locomotives, with the contract period running until March 2028. We have supplied 650 locomotives so far, and the remaining 150 will be delivered by March 2028. The contract also gives Indian Railways an option to order an additional 200 locomotives.

We are in discussions with Indian Railways on how we can maintain continuity of production at Madhepura. We are hopeful that something will come out of these discussions.

And is there any plan for exports?

We are exploring every possible way of maintaining continuity. We have this land lease for 35 years. The entire investment and the facility you saw will remain in place. It therefore makes sense to continue utilising the facility for manufacturing. We are discussing this with Indian Railways.

What has been the impact of this project so far?

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Today, more than 30% of Alstom's engineering work globally is done in India, and the confidence and capabilities developed through the Madhepura project have been an important part of that journey. We have created a large pool of engineers in India who are now contributing to the design of locomotives as well as urban trains for global projects.

We are also changing the locomotive maintenance system. Traditionally, it was largely schedule-based — the locomotive had to return to the depot at fixed intervals. However, our teams at Saharanpur, Nagpur and Sabarmati use condition-based monitoring to assess the actual health of the equipment and determine what maintenance is required. On top of this, digital tools help with predictive maintenance. With the help of these tools and by skilling workers, we have been able to cut down our maintenance time by almost 20% and material requirements by close to 15%, which is a huge efficiency gain.

The average speed of freight trains is still around 25 kmph. How can it be increased?

We are not really specialists when it comes to operations. But we can contribute from the product design and manufacturing point of view. For example, the Railways has a vision of reaching a 45% market share in five years and increasing freight haulage from around 1,600 million tonnes to 3,000 million tonnes. To achieve that, the Railways need heavy-haul locomotives that can haul long trains and heavy loads at higher speeds. Our locomotive can haul a 6,000-tonne load even on a gradient of 1-in-150 at a top speed of 120 kmph. This capability can contribute to Indian Railways' vision of increasing freight haulage to 3,000 million tonnes.

The reporter was in Patna at the invitation of Alstom.

India aims to seal Chile trade pact this year

New Delhi: India is committed to conclude negotiations for a comprehensive trade agreement with Chile this year as it would help further strengthen economic ties between the two countries, the commerce ministry said on Sunday. Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agarwal was there in Santiago, Chile to review the progress of the talks.

The proposed comprehensive economic partnership agreement (CEPA) is expected to open new avenues for greater trade and investment, while fostering cooperation in technology, talent and resilient supply chains. "India remains committed to concluding the CEPA negotiations within this year, with the aim of delivering a balanced and mutually beneficial framework that provides equitable and commercially meaningful outcomes for businesses on both sides," it said. PTI

Dy MD Kaizad Bharucha in HDFC Bank CEO race

Reuters
Mumbai, August 30

HDFC BANK is likely to name Deputy Managing Director Kaizad Bharucha as one of two options for its next CEO after incumbent Sashidhar Jagdishan retires at the end of his second term in October, two people familiar with the matter said.

India's largest private lender is also searching for an external candidate in keeping with a central bank rule requiring banks submit multiple names for the CEO position, the people said, declining to be identified as the information was private.

The Reserve Bank of India approves top banking appointments. Neither HDFC Bank nor Bharucha responded to emails seeking comment outside of regular business hours.

The CEO search comes after about six months of upheaval at HDFC Bank where

leadership issues have weighed on its shares.

The bank announced Jagdishan's retirement on Saturday. He had been widely tipped to continue as CEO before Atanu Chakraborty resigned as chairman in March saying practices at the bank were at odds with his "personal values and ethics".

An external legal review found no evidence to substantiate Chakraborty's governance concerns. Last month, the board penalised Jagdishan and three others in a separate matter related to the pricing of large deposits. The bank said on Saturday without elaborating that its CEO since October 2020 had decided not to seek reappointment and that it would fast-track the appointment of a successor.

Among the leading internal candidates is Bharucha, a long-serving executive overseeing the retail and wholesale businesses, the people said.

● **RBI AND SEBI ARE STRENGTHENING CYBER RESILIENCE, INCIDENT REPORTING AND AI SAFEGUARDS AS THREATS TO THE FINANCIAL SECTOR GROW MORE SOPHISTICATED**

Why regulators are tightening the cybersecurity net around India's financial sector

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, August 30

AS ARTIFICIAL intelligence (AI) fuels rising cybersecurity threats, regulators are tightening oversight of the financial sector, with the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) reiterating their focus on protecting critical parts of the financial ecosystem.

SEBI, for example, on Monday introduced an IT Resilience Index (ITRI) for Market Infrastructure Institutions — entities like clearing corporations and exchanges that enable trading in financial markets. "Any disruption, degrading in performance or compromise of these (IT) systems may adversely impact critical market operations and

pose risks to the trust in the securities market," the market regulator noted in its circular. The RBI released a new comprehensive cybersecurity framework late last month for banks and financial institutions, and has also flagged the possibility of a "kill switch" mechanism.

The mechanism allows users to freeze all financial transactions in their accounts during fraud in the RBI's case, while the markets regulator is evaluating a similar mechanism as part of its AI guidelines. Both regulators are stepping up focus on cyber risks as AI makes fraud easier to scale. This includes deepfake voices used to bypass KYC checks, as well as complex scams that infiltrate critical financial services institutions. In fact, we've already seen cyberse-

curity threats infiltrating a few banks so far in 2026.

Measuring cyber resilience

SEBI's ITRI for market infrastructure institutions quantifies cyber readiness and turns it into something tangible. The index has 9 parameters — availability and security have a weightage of 20%, integrity, governance, reliability and monitoring, modularity and flexibility, and business continuity have a weightage of 10% each, while scalability and an "others" parameter with miscellaneous requirements have a weightage of 5% each.

"SEBI's IT Resilience Index is significant in that respect because resilience becomes something that can be measured,



AI-driven fraud, deepfakes and cyber threats are pushing regulators to strengthen monitoring and response. REUTERS

benchmarked and ultimately brought into boardroom accountability," said Himanshu Bagai, partner at Saikrishna & Associates.

The framework, which will come into effect from early 2027,

will also include an "early warning system" and continuous monitoring to flag risks early. "MIIs (Market Infrastructure Institutions) shall compute ITRI on a half-yearly basis within a period of 60 days from the end

of each half-year and submit the comparative analysis of two consecutive half-years (on a rolling basis) and corrective action," SEBI's circular noted.

The regulator on Monday also said that it has aligned its cyber incident reporting portal for regulated entities with a standardized "Format for Incident Reporting Exchange" or FIRE format. This "will facilitate reporting of incidents in stages to reflect incident life cycle from initial reporting to intermediate updates and final closure, while acknowledging that certain information may not be available at the time of initial reporting," it said.

AI raises the stakes

SEBI last week said it will

"shortly" issue guidelines for responsible use of AI and machine learning. While the regulator already has AI models monitoring to flag suspicious trading patterns, Whole-Time Member Kamlesh Chandra Varshney had indicated last week that it has also developed a team to

work on AI models covering corporate investigations.

"Now, a team has already been constituted. Like we have a system for trading data, can we have a system for quarterly results that are filed?" said Varshney at an event in Mumbai.

The regulator now flags risks related to AI and the need to improve surveillance at almost all public forums, signifying the scale of the challenge

lying ahead as technology keeps on changing.

The RBI last month tightened cybersecurity rules for banks and financial institutions, mandating board-level oversight, dedicated IT risk committees and a six-hour window to report cyber incidents. In June, it had revised its fraud compensation mechanism for victims, increasing the scope of those who can claim compensation, and included newer-age digital scams in its definition.

While the regulators have shown interest in modernising cyber regulations, many challenges remain. They must remain nimble as threats evolve with rapidly changing technology. FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Idea Exchange

MONDAY, AUGUST 31, 2026

NEWSMAKERS IN THE NEWSROOM

WHY RAJIV RANJAN SINGH

Rajiv Ranjan Singh, also known as Lalan Singh, is the Union Minister for Panchayati Raj and Minister of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying. He is heading the fisheries department at a time when the sector is facing challenges amid tariffs by the US, a major importer of shrimps from India. Singh began his political journey as a student leader, participating in Jayaprakash Narayan's movement. He was also a prominent voice against the fodder scam in the 1990s. He entered Parliament in 2000 after being elected to the Rajya Sabha and was elected to the Lok Sabha from Bihar's Begusarai in 2004 and 2009, and from Munger in 2019 and 2024.



ON BJP LOSING BANKIPUR IN BYPOLLS

In a bye-election, many factors are involved. In 2009, eight by-elections happened at once. We lost six of those eight seats. But in the 2010 general election, out of 243 seats, we won 206



ON NAVIGATING CLIMATE CHANGE FOR FISHERIES

Transponders have been put on vessels, connecting them to satellites for fishermen to remain in touch while at sea. The system also indicates where fish are likely to be found, saving fuel

‘Despite US tariffs, our fish export has increased... now exporting to the UK, Japan, China, Thailand and EU’

Rajiv Ranjan Singh, Union Minister of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying, on transforming fisheries and dairy, building new export markets and navigating the political questions around student protests and Bihar. The session was moderated by Harikishan Sharma, Senior Assistant Editor, *The Indian Express*



(Right) Rajiv Ranjan Singh, Union Minister of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying, with Harikishan Sharma, Senior Assistant Editor, *The Indian Express* RENUKA PURI

Harikishan Sharma: When you took over as Minister of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying, you said the government had set a target to double fisheries exports. What is its current state, and what is your vision for this sector over the next two decades?

Before Prime Minister Narendra Modi came to power in 2014, this entire ministry was with the agriculture ministry. Three crore people are directly connected with fisheries as fishermen or fish farmers. If you look at the entire value chain, the livelihood of almost six crore people depends on it. The PM recognised this as a neglected sector and began efforts to strengthen it. In 2015, he started the Blue Revolution, followed by the Pradhan Mantri Matsya Sampada Yojana (PMMSY). In 2019, the fisheries department was separated from agriculture and a new ministry was created.

In 2013-14, the country's total fish production was 95.79 lakh tonnes. Through schemes such as Blue Revolution, PMMSY and the Fisheries and Aquaculture Infrastructure Development Fund, with an investment of more than Rs 39,000 crore, production increased to 197.75 lakh tonnes in 2024-25 — a growth of 115 per cent. Inland fisheries grew by 147 per cent. Many states have become self-reliant. In Bihar, 90-95 per cent of the fish sold earlier came from Andhra Pradesh. Today, only about five per cent comes from Andhra. Bihar's production has grown 11 times since 2005 and has reached approximately 10.89 lakh tonnes. Bihar now even exports freshwater fish to Nepal, Bengal and Jharkhand.

Harikishan Sharma: What about exports?

In 2013-14, fish exports were Rs 30,213 crore. In 2024-25, they reached Rs 62,408 crore. Then, in 2025, the US imposed a tariff of more than 58 per cent on Indian goods, which was a major challenge for our fishing community. We encouraged exporters to find new markets. We coordinated with MPEDA (Marine Products Export Development Authority) and held round-table conferences with ambassadors and high commissioners of 49 countries. European countries and the UK, for instance, did not want fish imported if harmful antibiotics were used. We banned such antibiotics and prepared a traceability framework under which the origin of fish has to be provided through a QR code.

Harikishan Sharma: Inland fisheries have grown, but marine fish catch has not increased as expected.

No, that is also growing. There is 115 per cent growth and our exports have increased from Rs 30,213 crore.

Unni Rajen Shankar: Does this export also include fresh water fish?

The export of freshwater fish, inland fish, contributes only two per cent to our total exports. So the export that is growing is of marine products. In 2013-14, it was Rs 30,213 crore and became Rs 62,408 crore in 2024-25. After the US tariff, there was a challenge, but the result of all the efforts we made is that instead of decreasing, our export increased by almost Rs 11,400 crore. Our export for this year (2025-26) was Rs 73,890 crore, an increase by Rs 11,000 crore. If our production of marine fisheries is not growing, how is our export growing?

Liz Mathew: Which are the new markets?

The UK, Japan, China, Thailand and several European Union countries.

Sandeep Singh: How much benefit have we seen from countries with which FTAs were signed?

Our exports to the US declined by around 19-20 per cent, but we saw more than 20 per cent growth in the European Union and countries where FTAs were signed. That is how exports reached Rs 73,890 crore.

Harikishan Sharma: What about the new fishing infrastructure in Lakshadweep and the Andaman and Nicobar Islands?

In Lakshadweep and Andaman, almost one lakh tonnes of tuna were believed to have died naturally because there was no fishing infrastructure. We did not fish in the Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ) or the high seas.

In the 2024 Budget, the Finance Minister announced that fishing infrastructure would be developed there. We formulated guidelines for the EEZ and high seas and held investor meetings in both islands. Only vessels with our national flag will be allowed to fish in the high seas because the sea is a national security concern. Tuna will be the biggest catch. It is among the most expensive fish in the world and has high global demand.

Harikishan Sharma: Four states recently banned analogue paneer. What is your take on this as the Dairy and Animal Husbandry Minister.

India is number one in milk production and second in egg production. But we have a problem: animals here have foot-and-mouth disease and brucellosis, which prevents us from exporting as much as we could. We are running vaccination campaigns to eradicate FMD. Outbreaks have fallen from

132 in 2019 to 40 now. As for paneer analogue, paneer is made only from milk. What is being called analogue paneer is not paneer at all; it is an artificial product. Naturally, it can compromise human health.

Harikishan Sharma: Jayaprakash Narayan wrote that students and youth would lead a peaceful, party-less revolution. Student protests are now taking place in different parts of the country. How do you view them?

The student protests in Jharkhand and the one that happened in Delhi are different. The Delhi protest was connected to NEET. The paper was leaked, so the government cancelled the exam and conducted it again. Those involved were arrested. The law had loopholes, so Parliament brought in a stricter law requiring investigations and trials to be completed within specified time limits. What happened in Jharkhand will be known only after an investigation. But according to newspaper reports, the alleged fraud involved the public service commission, with money being demanded for examinations. So, you can't compare the student protest in Jharkhand and the one here.

Now, the Congress is supporting the student movement. It makes me laugh. The biggest student movement — or people's movement — in this country was in 1974 under Loknayak Jayaprakash Narayan. I participated in it. At that time, the Congress government tried to suppress the movement. Thousands of students and youth were killed in firing. Jayaprakash Narayan would ring a bell at 6 pm to signal a black-out, and the entire city would go dark. Today, they are shedding crocodile tears. During the Emergency, the Constitution was amended to increase Parliament's term from five-six years. There was no freedom of the Press.

Liz Mathew: The Delhi student protest was described by many ruling party MPs as being influenced by external forces. And Mohan Bhagwat has said the students' demands are legitimate.

If any student demands transparency in an examination, that is genuine. Such incidents should not happen again, which is why the government also brought in laws. But the people hiding behind the students cannot be considered genuine. I am not talking about any party but everyone knows who came into the movement from behind.

Harikishan Sharma: What about the force used by police against peaceful demonstrations in Delhi?



You must have seen how many police personnel were injured. If you use sticks or throw bricks at police personnel who are there for security, they will react. So how was it peaceful? There were people behind the students who wanted to give the movement a violent form. Despite that, there was no firing.

Manoj CG: Why didn't the government initiate a dialogue with the protesters before the situation reached that point?

Conversation was happening. People were appointed from the government's side to talk to them. We were having discussions even when Sonam Wangchuk sat on hunger strike. Until there is an outcome, however, those conversations do not come to light.

ON POLICE USING FORCE AT CJP PROTEST IN DELHI

If you use sticks or throw bricks at police personnel, they will react. So how was it peaceful? There were people behind the students who wanted to give the movement a violent form. Despite that, there was no firing

Manoj CG: You are a voter of Bankipur, where the BJP has had a winning streak since 1995. What went wrong that a person who started a party three years ago won such a big BJP seat?

In a bye-election, many factors are involved, including the candidate's popularity. Look at Bihar's history. In 2009, eight bye-elections happened at once. We lost six of those eight seats. But in the 2010 general election, out of 243 seats, we won 206. So you cannot assess the strength of a party from one bye-election.

Liz Mathew: For the first time in many years, the NDA went into an election without Nitish Kumar's leadership in Bihar. Did his leaving have any impact?

No. It was Nitish ji's wish to go to the Rajya Sabha. He had been a member of the Lok Sabha, Assembly and Legislative Council; the Rajya Sabha was the only house left.

Jatin Anand: Student politics traditionally brings people above 18 into party organisations. But today politics seems to be influencing younger people. Should children below 18 be brought into politics?

It is changing continuously. The PM has said that youth are the future of the country. Lakhs of young people are connected with youth wings and come to meet us even today. The younger they are, the better it is for the country. They can contribute to constructive work.

Jatin Anand: Do you think the people of Bihar have accepted Samrat Choudhary?

You are talking about acceptability after three months. Right now, he is carrying forward the work Nitish ji started. Before leav-

ing, Nitish ji travelled across Bihar, visited every district and sanctioned the work that remained. A Rs 45,000-crore scheme has been sanctioned and is now being executed. Nitish ji's acceptability increased because of his work. We formed the Samata Party in 1995, but it was only after Nitish ji became Chief Minister that the situation in Bihar changed.

Shahid Pervez: The NDA won the 2025 Bihar election with Nitish Kumar as its face. Four or five months later, he moved to the Rajya Sabha. Isn't that a betrayal of the public mandate?

Nitish ji had already decided that he wanted to go to the Rajya Sabha. There was no Rajya Sabha election when the Assembly election was held, so he became Chief Minister and was the face of the election. In 2026, he felt that the RS opportunity would otherwise come only after two years. There was no betrayal of the public mandate. Samrat Choudhary was Nitish ji's choice.

Nikhil Ghanekar: Climate change is affecting fisheries. What policies are you bringing in to improve the resilience of communities dependent on these sectors?

Climate change affects the sea through storms and cyclones. The PM has launched an initiative which is putting transponders on vessels. These are connected to satellites. Fishermen who remain at sea for 15-20 days can stay in touch with their families through an Android phone connected to the transponder. Alerts can warn them about storms and tell them to move away from danger. The system can also indicate where fish are likely to be found, saving fuel.

Harikishan Sharma: But what about rising sea temperatures, changing rainfall and their impact on fish, endangered species, dairy and animal husbandry?

Climate change is a global problem and comes under the ministry of forest and environment. There are many reasons for it, including deforestation. That ministry is looking at it.

Nikhil Ghanekar: In Bihar, Mangur fish are being confiscated because of concerns about their impact on native species and livelihoods.

Mangur is being produced through farming. You can see how the farmed fish becomes massive in six months. People use injections to increase the size of animals or vegetables, but ultimately it affects health.

Nikhil Ghanekar: The PESA Act completes three decades this year. Its implementation has been delayed in several states. What is your view?

Under the 73rd Constitutional Amendment, the panchayat is an independent government. The Government of India has no control over it. The laws you are referring to are under the state governments. States have the right to make laws, so we do not interfere. Our role is to provide the grants recommended by the Finance Commission. We send the money to the states in a 90:10 ratio based on population and geographical conditions. States have to transfer it to panchayats within 10 days, otherwise the second instalment is not released. We also work on capacity building, including training women representatives, with trainers from institutions such as IIM Ahmedabad. The 16th Finance Commission has recommended that 20 per cent of the grant be performance-based. Panchayats will have to develop their own sources of revenue. If they depend only on grants, they will not be sustainable.

Swati Mishra: Your ministry promotes milk and egg production, while malnutrition remains a major problem. At the same time, some political leaders oppose the sale of eggs and meat on religious grounds.

You are combining the responsibilities of several ministries. My ministry looks at production. It does not deal with malnutrition or mid-day meals.

Damini Nath: What is your view on the proposed delimitation exercise, particularly from Bihar's perspective?

We will see when we come to it. Bihar has always supported women's empowerment. It was the first state to give 50 per cent reservation to women in Panchayati Raj in 2006 and in local bodies in 2007. Today, lakhs of women are in mainstream politics. In the last panchayat election, despite 50 per cent reservation, 53 per cent of those elected were women.

Harikishan Sharma: What is the government doing about stray animals, including cows and dogs?

Stray animals are a state subject. We are using artificial insemination and sex-sorted semen, through which around 90 per cent female calves are born. Most animals abandoned on roads are male because oxen are no longer needed for farming. Tractors have replaced them. With more female calves, livestock owners will have more milk and income, giving them an incentive to rear the animals rather than abandon them. But the issue of stray animals remains a state subject.

{ WEEKLY CAPSULE }

Depression stalls brain neurons

A MAJOR STUDY by the Columbia University Irving Medical Center found that adults with depression show disrupted production of neurons in the hippocampus, potentially weakening the brain's ability to separate new experiences from painful memories. The researchers also identified broad molecular changes that could open the door to new treatments tailored to different biological forms of depression. The findings provide the first evidence that neurogenesis, the process of producing new neurons, stalls in the brains of adults with major depressive disorder.



Shingles vaccine slows dementia

OLDER ADULTS who received the Shingrix shingles vaccine were 24 per cent less likely to be diagnosed with dementia over four years in a study of more than 500,000 people. Researchers at Brown University estimate the difference could amount to roughly one dementia case prevented for every 17 people vaccinated. Dementia developed in 18.8 per cent of vaccinated participants, compared with 24.6 per cent of those who were not vaccinated. The study included Medicare claims and electronic health records from patients admitted to more than 5,500 skilled nursing facilities.



Brain 'brake' that calms pain

RESEARCHERS AT Washington University School of Medicine discovered a brain-based "brake" that can shut down chronic nerve pain in mice by calming an overactive pain circuit. Targeting this system more precisely could one day lead to powerful pain relief without affecting opioid receptors throughout the entire body. These receptors were already known for their role in stress, but the new findings suggest they can also quiet a pain-producing circuit and reduce chronic neuropathic pain caused by nerve injury. Neuropathic pain develops when injured nerve fibres repeatedly send abnormal signals to the brain.



Gene decides diet effect on LDL

LOW-CARB diets have become increasingly popular but their effects on cholesterol are far from uniform. Some people see little change, while others experience a substantial increase. New research suggests that genetics may help explain why. The findings indicate that saturated fat, which can make up a larger share of some low-carb diets, may interact with a person's genetic makeup to raise low-density lipoprotein (LDL) cholesterol, a major contributor to heart disease risk. This genetic influence could help explain why two people following similar diets can have different cholesterol responses.



Common drugs change your gut

COMMON MEDICATIONS may reshape the gut microbiome long after the last dose is taken. In a study of more than 2,500 people, researchers found lasting microbial changes linked not only to antibiotics but also to antidepressants, beta-blockers, acid-reducing drugs and benzodiazepines. Effects were detectable years later, suggesting past medication use may strongly influence the gut bacteria people carry today. One striking finding involved benzodiazepines, commonly prescribed for anxiety. Their associations with the gut microbiome were comparable to those seen with broad-spectrum antibiotics.





CONSULTATION ROOM

DRAMIT SEN

CHILD AND ADOLESCENT PSYCHIATRIST;
DIRECTOR, CHILDREN FIRST

Meta's child safety deal can change digital childhood

The settlement marks a crucial shift in responsibility from parents to tech cos

META'S AGREEMENT to settle the US states' landmark case over Facebook and Instagram's impact on children is significant because of its size and because it signals a possible change in who bears responsibility for children's online safety. Meta has agreed to pay up to about \$18 billion and introduce protections for under-18 users, including a default two-hour daily limit, a midnight-to-6 am block, muted notifications during school hours, stronger age assurance, parental controls and greater restrictions on harmful content. The agreement follows allegations that Meta encouraged compulsive use and mishandled children's data.

The importance of the settlement lies in the shift away from the familiar argument that parents alone must control children's digital lives. For years, technology companies have pointed to parental supervision, while families have struggled to manage products engineered around engagement, notifications, recommendation systems and endless scrolling. The agreement places responsibility back on the platforms. It, therefore, represents more than a financial penalty: it challenges the idea that a profitable digital environment can be treated as neutral while its youngest users carry the risks.

This matters because the post-Covid generation of children and teenagers has grown up with an extraordinary expansion of screen-based life. In clinical practice, screen addiction is a real and serious problem. Children may reach a point where they stop attending school, withdraw from friends and family, lose interest in ordinary activities and become unable to regulate their use of phones, gaming or social media. Often there is an underlying vulnerability — anxiety, depression, learning difficulty, neurodevelopmental difference or family distress — that makes the virtual world attractive. That does not make the technology harmless; it makes vulnerable children more deserving of protection.

The developmental concern is not simply the number of hours spent on a screen, but what is being consumed and what is being displaced. Sustained play, reading, creative activity, physical movement, face-to-face conversation and downtime help children practise attention, language, emotional regulation and social skills. When every pause is filled by a device, children may lose opportunities for reflection and assimilation of the day's experiences. In clinical assessment, difficulties with attention, frustration tolerance, impulse control, organisation and emotional regulation can become strikingly visible.

Neuroscience adds weight to the concern. A systematic review and meta-analysis of problematic internet use found convergent reductions in grey matter in frontal and anterior cingulate regions involved in reward processing and top-down inhibitory control. Reviews of problematic gaming in adolescents similarly identify alterations in prefrontal, attention, emotion-regulation and reward networks. These findings are associations, not proof that social media alone damages every child. But they reinforce the need to take compulsive digital behaviour seriously.

Mental health is another concern. Research has linked heavier social-media use with anxiety, depressive symptoms, body dissatisfaction and disordered eating. A 2026 meta-analysis of 45 studies involving more than 33,000 adolescents found significant associations between social-media engagement and body-image and eating-disorder symptoms, with stronger associations for Instagram. The digital environment can also expose children to self-harm material, eating-disorder content, exploitation, misogyny, violent imagery and other age-inappropriate material. Recommendation systems can intensify exposure by repeatedly feeding users what keeps them engaged. Yet this is not an argument for banning technology. Digital tools can expand access to education, support differently abled learners and create opportunities for creativity, connection and participation.

That is why the Meta settlement could become a turning point. The two-hour limit, night-time restrictions, school-hour notification controls, age assurance, reduced social-comparison features and stronger parental controls are useful steps. The crucial question is whether platforms will change underlying addictive design and recommendation systems. Schools, governments and technology companies must share responsibility. Schools can establish clear rules, reduce unnecessary access to social media on school devices and teach digital literacy. Governments can demand transparency, independent audits and age-appropriate design. Companies should remove addictive features, limit harmful recommendations and make child-safety protections the default rather than an optional setting.

— As told to Rinku Ghosh

Peptide boom: Miracle molecules or hype?

Rinku Ghosh

THE LATEST wellness craze comes in tiny chains of amino acids — the building blocks of protein — and it is being sold with very big promises. Peptides are increasingly being touted as the next frontier in weight loss, muscle recovery, anti-ageing and longevity, with products available online, through wellness clinics and, in some cases, directly delivered to consumers for self-administration. The fad has now moved from online forums and biohacking circles into the real world: Bengaluru announced the first "Peptide Party" on August 29, an invite-only gathering, which was later cancelled by the administration. It got more than 200 registrations for around 50 places, underlining just how quickly the fascination has spread.

But the hype drowns this absolute truth: While a handful of peptide-based medicines have been rigorously tested and approved, many of the compounds now being marketed for "biohacking", recovery and longevity have little or no adequate evidence from human clinical trials. Dr Anoop Misra, Executive Chairman, Fortis C-Doc for Diabetes and Allied Sciences, who has been researching the subject, found that the growing peptide market is blurring the line between established medicines and experimental compounds. "The word 'peptide' itself can sound reassuring because some of the world's most successful modern medicines are peptides. But scientific credibility does not automatically extend from semaglutide or insulin to every compound sold online under the same broad label," he told *The Indian Express*.

What are peptides and where are they available?

Peptides are short chains of amino acids — the same building blocks that make up proteins but smaller. Some peptides, such as insulin and semaglutide, are well-established medicines manufactured in regulated facilities and available only by prescription.

However, several others — including BPC-157, TB-500, epitallon, MOTS-c and others — are sold openly online by "research chemical" suppliers. They may be shipped as injectable vials directly to people's homes, often without a prescription. A growing number of wellness and longevity clinics in India also offer them off-label, sometimes as part of "anti-ageing", "recovery" or "longevity" packages.

Some websites claim that "many peptides used in longevity and optimisation protocols are available through licensed compounding pharmacies." This can create an impression of safety and legitimacy that may not necessarily be justified. Many "peptide capsules" are also available online, sometimes costing Rs 10,000–15,000 for 60 capsules.

Do these peptides actually work as claimed?

For approved and properly tested medicines such as semaglutide and tirzepatide, the answer is yes — their benefits are supported by large, well-designed clinical trials.

For many of the peptides being sold online, however, the honest answer is, we simply do not know. Most claims are based on animal studies, laboratory findings, theoretical mechanisms or personal anecdotes rather than controlled human clinical trials.

What are peptide rave parties?

These refer to social gatherings or online communities where people come together to discuss, and sometimes use, peptide products for weight loss, muscle building, recovery, anti-ageing or "longevity." Participants may share personal experiences and discuss which peptide to use, how much to take, how frequently to take it and which route of administration to use — oral, topical or injectable.

Doses and schedules may then be changed according to how individuals feel the peptide is working, rather than on the basis of clinical trials or medical advice. The concern is that such settings can normalise peptide stacking, self-injection and unsupervised dose changes, while creating a false sense of safety because other people report similar experiences.

In reality, many people having the same experience does not make an unapproved



GETTYIMAGES

peptide safe or effective. Anecdotes are not a substitute for clinical evidence.

What's behind the sudden peptide craze?

The highly visible success of drugs such as Ozempic has made the word "peptide" sound almost synonymous with guaranteed results. That credibility has spilled over to completely different peptides now being promoted for muscle recovery, sleep, skin health, anti-ageing and longevity. Biohacking culture, celebrity endorsements and aggressive social-media promotion have further fuelled the trend.

The result is a rapidly expanding market in which scientific evidence and regulatory oversight are struggling to keep pace.

How different are approved medicines from the peptides sold online?

They are hugely different. Semaglutide, for example, underwent years of large-scale human clinical trials, is manufactured in regulated and inspected facilities, and is prescribed with appropriate medical monitoring. In contrast, many peptides sold online have little or no adequate human clinical evidence supporting their safety or effectiveness.

What are the biggest health risks of unsupervised use?

Potential risks include immune reactions, infections at the injection site, unpredictable effects on hormones or organ function, and adverse effects that may go unnoticed because there is no medical monitoring. Another major problem is that doses may not be standardised and the actual amount of peptide in a product may differ from what is stated on the label.

BPC-157, for example, is a synthetic 15-amino-acid peptide derived from a protein associated with the stomach. It has shown potential cell-protective effects in laboratory and animal studies. Despite its growing popularity among athletes and its availability through non-regulated sources, there is very limited human clinical evidence.

In July 2026, the US FDA (Food and Drug Administration) recommended against adding BPC-157 to the 503A compounding list, citing the lack of adequate human evidence demonstrating its safety and effectiveness. Non-clinical evaluations



SCAN THE QR CODE TO READ MORE HEALTH SPECIAL STORIES

have also raised concerns regarding safety and product quality, including findings of blood-clotting abnormalities and liver changes in animal studies, as well as concerns about inconsistent quality between batches. Injection or inhalation may also trigger unwanted immune reactions.

There have been ongoing debates and challenges involving industry groups, political figures and patient demand on relaxing regulatory status of BPC-157 and pharmacy compounding. Such developments, however, should not be interpreted as proof that the peptide has been established as safe or effective.

What does the "research chemical" label mean, and why should buyers be cautious?

The term can function as a regulatory workaround. Sellers may label a product "not for human consumption" or "for research use only" while simultaneously marketing it in a way that clearly encourages human use, including self-injection. It is important to understand that "research chemical" is not a safety certification. If anything, it should make consumers more cautious because the product may not have undergone the quality, safety and efficacy testing required for an approved medicine.

Can buyers be sure of what they are actually getting?

Often, they cannot. Testing of some peptides obtained online in Belgium found contamination with toxic heavy metals such as arsenic and lead. Testing by a US laboratory specialising in these products has also found that a proportion of samples did not match their labels in terms of purity or quantity.

Peptides can be relatively fragile molecules and may be affected by inappropriate storage or transportation, including inadequate temperature control. This means that a product may potentially deteriorate before it even reaches the consumer.

Research examining online peptide forums has also shown how digital communities can develop their own form of "folk pharmacology", where users collectively exchange information and experiences about drugs, doses, combinations and administration methods without the safeguards of formal medical evidence.

DOC I HAVE A question

PEPTIDE, PROTEIN OR HORMONE? WHAT'S THE DIFFERENCE?

AMINO ACID The basic building block. Amino acids join together to form peptides and proteins.

PEPTIDE A relatively short chain of amino acids. There is no single universally agreed cut-off separating a peptide from a protein, but peptides are generally shorter.

PROTEIN A larger, folded chain or chains of amino acids that perform a huge range of functions in the body — from building tissues and transporting molecules.

PEPTIDE HORMONE Some hormones are peptides. They act as chemical messengers, carrying signals between cells and organs.

WHY DOES THIS MATTER? Peptide is a description of what something is made of, not what it does. Two peptides can have completely different structures, biological effects, medical uses and levels of evidence. That is why the fact that a well-established drug such as insulin or semaglutide is a peptide tells us little about an unrelated experimental peptide.



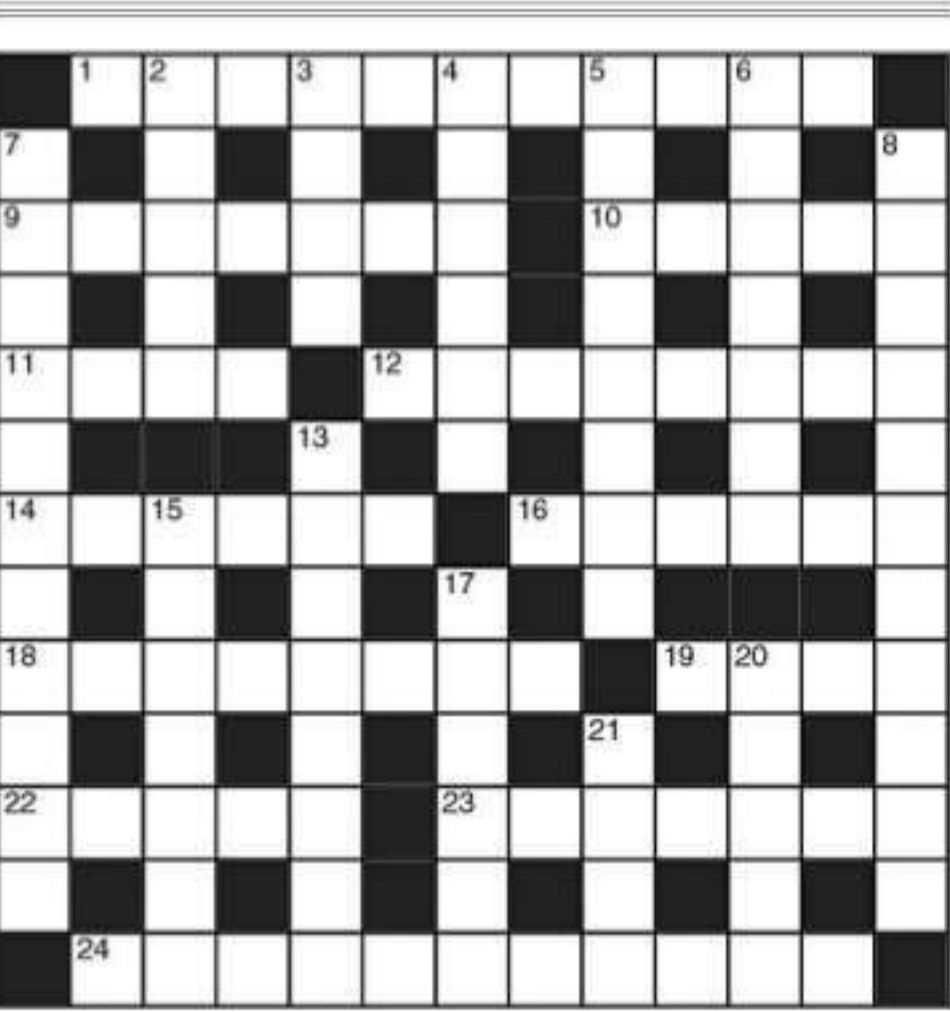
What should people check, and when should they avoid a peptide entirely?

Before considering any peptide, people should ask three basic questions: Has it been prescribed by a qualified doctor after proper medical evaluation? Is it being dispensed by a licensed pharmacy with a traceable manufacturer and batch number? Is there credible, published human clinical-trial evidence supporting its safety and effectiveness?

People should be particularly cautious if a product is self-sourced online, labelled as a "research chemical," promoted as part of an influencer-recommended stack, or advertised as providing rapid results without medical supervision.

CROSSWORD

6081



ACROSS
1 Exhibit the iris to make a patriotic display (4,3,4)
9 Just a piano? (7)
10 I held wrong capital (5)
11 Lane ducks maybe (4)
12 Adventurous men who went to the top at sea (8)
14 It's written about the sailor's refuge (6)
16 Incense — a green variety (6)
18 Poison counter (8)
19 It took at least two days to build; possibly more (4)
22 Pass on to a punctuation mark (5)
23 One may take it to avoid it (7)
24 Case perhaps for outdoor pursuits (5,6)

DOWN
2 Hear mother repaired to the women's quarters (5)
3 Carry on fighting for one's pay (4)
4 Hired assassin? Good show, old boy! (3,3)
5 Trifling job for a musician (8)
6 State capital of Natal at variance (7)
7 A procession of empty protest (6,5)
8 The best side of a club (5,6)
13 Nominally she's discretion itself (8)
15 Caress a girl on the knee (7)
17 Still it could affect one's reception (6)
20 Man in Spain loses hard game (5)
21 Fishy article used as a tailpiece (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6080 ACROSS: 1 Walnut, 4 Scrabble, 9 Nobody, 10 Engraved, 12 Lily, 13 Mural, 14 Onus, 17 Step on the gas, 20 Joint concern, 23 Rood, 24 Fiend, 25 Otto, 28 Overlook, 29 Cobweb, 30 Shove off, 31 Loaded
DOWN: 1 Windlass, 2 Labelled, 3 Urdu, 5 Convallescent, 6 Acre, 7 Bovine, 8 Eldest, 11 Putting it off, 15 Donor, 16 Pains, 18 Bestowed, 19 Entombed, 21 Brooms, 22 Bolero, 26 Blue, 27 Polo

JUMBLD WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

Give me the luxuries of life and I will willingly do without the — Frank Lloyd Wright (11)

CMEEE

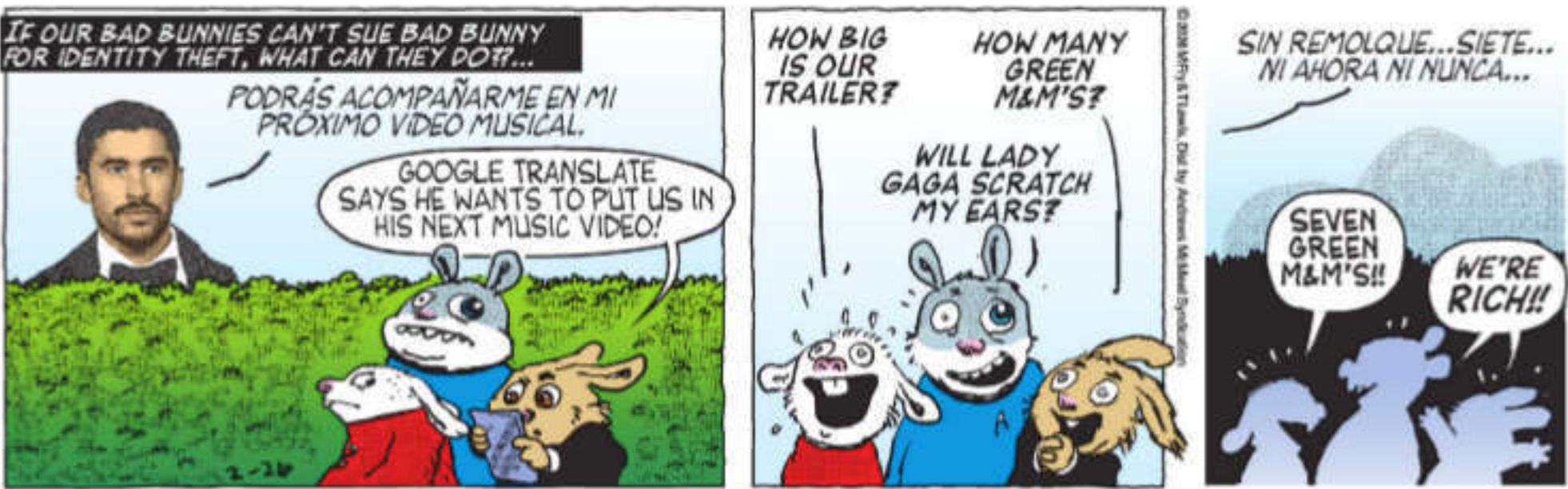
FNIS

CHINST

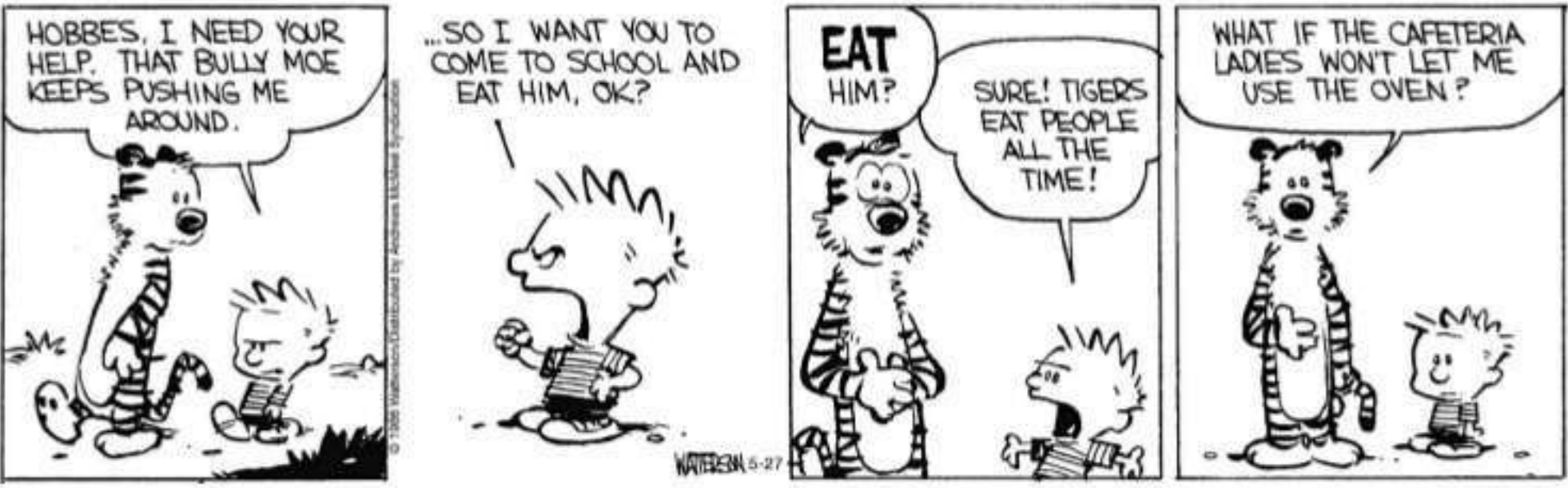
CHOTCS

SOLUTIONS: Enceee, Fnis, Sntich, Scotch necessities - Frank Lloyd Wright

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 1s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL
1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6427

7		3	5			4		
5		1		8	9			
	8	6	3	2				5
	6		4			8	9	
	5						7	
	9	2			1		3	
4				6	3	9	2	
				8	5		3	7
			8		7	1		6

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6426

9	3	2	8	1	7	5	6	4
4	6	5	2	3	9	7	8	1
8	7	1	4	5	6	9	2	3
2	1	8	5	7	4	3	9	6
5	9	7	3	6	2	4	1	8
6	4	3	9	8	1	2	7	5
3	8	9	1	2	5	6	4	7
7	5	4	6	9	8	1	3	2
1	2	6	7	4	3	8	5	9

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): This is a powerful day for you because the Moon is in your sign. This will encourage you to make plans — cautiously. Meanwhile, you're ready to roll up your sleeves and work. Tonight: You're strong.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Today is a mixture of work and play for you. Opportunities to enjoy sports events, the arts, the theater and the entertainment world are at hand. You might see ways to secure something related to home and family. Tonight: Enjoy your privacy.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Even though your strong focus now is on home, family and perhaps home repairs. In addition to this, today is a good day to think about long-range future goals, especially in practical terms. Be aware of the Moon Alert. Tonight: Be friendly.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): You have lots of energy this week. In addition to which, you will keep busy with short trips, appointments and chatting to everyone. You'll enjoy entertaining at home. Today is a good day for solid financial plans. Tonight: Respect someone in authority.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Money, cash flow and earnings have been on your mind. However, today Jupiter in your sign is dancing favourably with Saturn. Trust your ability to make plans about future travel and higher education. Tonight: Explore and learn.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): The Sun and Mercury are in your sign, which makes you chatty. You might want to buy beautiful things, if so, check the the Moon alert. Take a moment to do some serious thinking about shared property and your debt. Tonight: Check your finances.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): If you're involved with a friend, or a group today, you might help others come up with a group goal. This is an excellent day to explore this, but don't settle on anything. Tonight: Listen and cooperate.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Today you might make some plans about your future, especially your profession, your career and your name in the community. Nevertheless, commit to nothing. Tonight: Get better organised.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): You make an excellent impression on others now, which is why it's a great time to talk to bosses and parents. You might discuss travel plans and issues related to children. Wait until later in the week to agree to anything. Tonight: Be creative and playful.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Family discussions might have profitable suggestions for family or dealing with shared property. Don't agree to anything today because things might change, especially after tomorrow. Just put things in your databank. Tonight: Relax at home.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): A discussion with a partner, or close friend will be practical and productive today. You might even want to jump on the bandwagon to get things rolling. Don't be too eager. Tonight: Discussions.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Today you have increasing optimism about your job and ability to earn money. You might listen to the advice of someone who is enthusiastic and encouraging. Get your data, but wait until later in the week to act because tomorrow could be a game-changer. Tonight: Check your possessions.

Mangalore SEZ Limited

Mangalore Special Economic Zone, Sy.No. 168-3A, Plot No. U1 Administrative Building, Bajpe Village, Mangalore - 574 142 Dakshina Kannada, Karnataka

INVITATION FOR BIDS

Mangalore SEZ Limited (MSEZL) invites tenders from eligible bidders for the following work through e-tendering:

No.	Contract Package No	Name of Work	Proposal due date
1.	MSEZL/ Short Term PP-2/26-27	Procurement of renewable power on short-term basis under wheeling & banking through tariff based competitive bidding process	07.09.2026

Please refer website www.mstcecommerce.com and www.mangaloresez.com for further details.

Sd/-, Chief Executive Officer
Mangalore SEZ Ltd, Mangaluru

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

BORDER SECURITY FORCE
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Officers on their Balidan Diwas.

SUB INSPECTOR HANS RAM
106 BN BSF
17.07.1950 – 31.08.2000

SUB INSPECTOR JAGDISH CHAND
145 BN BSF
22.05.1954 – 31.08.2002

HEAD CONSTABLE BINOD KUMAR SINGH
145 BN BSF
04.03.1965 – 31.08.2002

CONSTABLE RAJENDER SINGH
90 BN BSF
02.10.1968 – 31.08.2005

CONSTABLE ISHWAR HARI JAMATIA
153 BN BSF
10.04.1970 – 31.08.2000

CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE

Veer Balidani Sub Inspector Rajender Prasad
39 Bn
5-7-1970 To 31-8-1995

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Sub Inspector Rajender Prasad of 39 Bn, on deputation to NSG, who made the supreme sacrifice while combating terrorists despite being severely injured during an operation on 31 August 1995 in Punjab. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

Veer Balidani Constable Mallikarjun R.
28 Bn
1-6-1983 To 31-8-2009

Veer Balidani Constable R. Raja Shekar
28 Bn
11-6-1982 To 31-8-2009

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to two valiant troopers of 28 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice in a cowardly attack by a militant in a crowded area of Fancy Chowk, Srinagar, J&K on 31 August 2009. CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.

Telangana Tourism Development Corporation Limited
Tourism House, 3-5-891, Himayatnagar, Hyderabad – 29
Tel: 040-2326 2151 to 57 Fax: 040-2326 1801

e-tender notice no. TGTC/WF/W1/07/2026 Date:29/08/2026
REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL NOTIFICATION

Telangana Tourism Development Corporation (TGTCDC) invites Request For Proposal (RFP) from eligible entities for the selection of agency(ies) for the development, operation, and maintenance of a floating restaurant, luxury dine-in cruise boat, and house boat at designated water bodies in Telangana on a Public-Private Partnership (PPP) basis through the e-procurement platform. The RFP document & updates if any can be downloaded from e-procurement platform: <https://www.tender.telangana.gov.in> w.e.f. 31/08/2026.

DIPR R.O.No.480-PP/CL-AGENCY/ADVT/2026-27 Dt:29.08.2026 Sd/-MANAGING DIRECTOR

Classifieds

LOST & FOUND

I Ankit Madan s/o Harish Kumar lost Allotment letter of my flat CS1/404 CAPETOWN SUPERTech SEC 74 NOIDA. FINDER PL CONTACT ON 9999596672

0050296507-1

"IMPORTANT"

Whilst care is taken prior to acceptance of advertising copy, it is not possible to verify its contents. The Indian Express (P) Limited cannot be held responsible for such contents, nor for any loss or damage incurred as a result of transactions with companies, associations or individuals advertising in its newspapers or Publications. We therefore recommend that readers make necessary inquiries before sending any monies or entering into any agreements with advertisers or otherwise acting on an advertisement in any manner whatsoever.

AXIS FINANCE LIMITED
(CIN U65921MH1995PLC212675)
Axis House, C-2, Media International Centre, Pandurang Budhkar Marg, West Mumbai - 400 025

APPENDIX IV [See Rule 8(i)]
SYMBOLIC POSSESSION NOTICE
(For immovable property)
[As per Appendix IV read with rule 8(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002]

Whereas, The undersigned being the Authorized Officer of the **Axis Finance Limited (AFL)**, under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of Powers conferred under Section 13 (12) read with the Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002, issued a demand notice dated 17th June, 2026 calling upon the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) / Mortgagor(s)

1. Parveen Goel (Borrower)
Address: H. No. 1312, Gali No. 89, Shanti Nagar, Tri Nagar, North West Delhi, Delhi 110035
Email: parveen4679@gmail.com Mob: 9711555575

2. Goel Telecom (Co-Borrower 1)
Address: 1824, Shanti Nagar Road, Trinagar, North West Delhi, Delhi 110035
Email: PARVEEN4679@GMAIL.COM Mob: 9711555575

3. Meena Goel (Co-Borrower 2)
Address: H. No. 1312, Gali No. 89, Shanti Nagar, Tri Nagar, North West Delhi, Delhi 110035
Email: PARVEEN4679@GMAIL.COM Mob: 9711555575

(Hereinafter collectively referred as **"Borrowers"**) who have mortgaged the property more particularly described hereunder to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being **₹1,03,405/- (Rupees Eighty One Lakh Three Thousand Four Hundred And Five Only)** due as on 05th August, 2026 and further interest thereon at the contractual rates together with costs, charges, etc. of Axis Finance Ltd until the full payment or realization in full.

The Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) / Mortgagor(s) attention is invited to provisions of sub section (8) & sub section (13) of section 13 of the said Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

Property details – **ALL THAT PIECE AND PARCEL OF COMMERCIAL SPACE/UNIT BEARING NO.007, ADMEASURING SUPER AREA OF 51.91 SQ MTRS (558.76 SQ.FT), SITUATED ON THE GROUND FLOOR OF CONVENIENCE SHOPPING COMPLEX IN THE GROUP HOUSING COLONY KNOWN AS M3M MERLIN, SITUATED IN THE REVENUE ESTATE OF VILLAGE BADSHAHPUR AT SECTOR-67, TEHSIL BADSHAHPUR, GURUGRAM, HARYANA, INDIA ALONGWITH PROPORTIONATE, UNDIVIDED, IMPARTIBLE SHARES AND INTEREST IN THE LAND ALONGWITH OTHER CO-OWNER, UNDERNEATH THE TOWER IN WHICH THE SAID UNIT IS LOCATED AND BOUNDED AS-**

AT OR TOWARD EAST- R-008
AT OR TOWARD WEST-R-006
AT OR TOWARD NORTH- VERANDAH
AT OR TOWARD SOUTH- DRIVEWAY

Date: 27.08.2026 Place: Gurugram

Authorized Officer
Axis Finance Ltd.

TRANSMISSION CORPORATION OF ANDHRA PRADESH LIMITED
(A Government of Andhra Pradesh Undertaking & An ISO 27001:2022 Certified Company)

TENDER NOTICE

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Veer Balidani Constable S. Govind Swamy
5 Bn
30-5-1969 To 31-8-1990

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable S. Govind Swamy of 5 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice in a cowardly grenade attack by a militant in Srinagar, J&K on 31 August 1990. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

Veer Balidani Constable Anusuya Prasad
55 Bn

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Anusuya Prasad of 55 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice on 31 August 1975 after being grievously injured in an encounter with insurgents on 29 August 1975 in Aizawl, Mizoram. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

CENTRUM HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED
Group Company of **peoplehome**
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DEMAND NOTICE

Under Section 13(2) of the Securitisation And Reconstruction of Financial Assets And Enforcement Of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with Rule 3 (1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

The undersigned is the Authorised Officer of **Centrum Housing Finance Ltd** under Securitisation And Reconstruction Of Financial Assets And Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (the said Act). In exercise of powers conferred under Section 13(12) of the said Act read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002, the Authorised Officer has issued Demand Notices under section 13(2) of the said Act, calling upon the following Borrower(s) (the said Borrower), to repay the amounts mentioned in the respective Demand Notices/ issued to them that are also given below. In connection with above, Notice is hereby given, once again, to the said Borrower to pay to **Centrum Housing Finance Ltd**, within 60 days from the publication of this Notice, the amounts indicated herein below, together with further interest and other charges till date of repayment of the dues in full, as detailed in the said Demand Notices, from the dates mentioned below till the date of payment and/or realization, payable under the loan agreement read with other documents/writings, if any, executed by the said Borrowers. As security for due repayment of the loan, the following assets have been mortgaged to **Centrum Housing Finance Ltd** by the said Borrowers respectively.

Sr. No.	Loan Account No./ Name of the Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)	Total Outstanding Dues (Rs.)	NPA Date Sec.13(2) Notice Date FCL Date	Description of secured asset (immovable property)
1	MTCMT21006370 / Ratanpal Singh / Manisha Devi	Rs.11,43,333.00 (Rupees Eleven Lakh Forty-three Thousand Three Hundred Thirty Three Only)	04-07-2026 12-08-2026 11-08-2026	In The Rights, Piece And Parcel of Immovable Property Bearing Plot On Khasra No. 1155,1312,1368, adm. 200.74 sqmts., Village Aanoppur Dibai, Pargana and Tehsil -Garhmukteshwar, District Hapur-245101, Uttar Pradesh. Boundaries:- East : 25ft wide Road West : Property of Pahalah North : Property of Pahalah South : House of Pahalah
2	MTCSSR22008309 / Lalit Kashyap / Swati Chauhan	Rs.12,31,088.00 (Rupees Twelve Lakh Thirty One Thousand Eighty Eight Only)	04-07-2026 17-08-2026 11-08-2026	In The Rights, Piece And Parcel of Immovable Property Bearing Part of Khasra no. 52 Mi and 63 Mi, adm. 83.87 sqmts., Wake Gram Sunehra (At Present Andar haddu Nagar Nigam Roorkee), Pargana and Tehsil Roorkee, Hardwar-247664, Uttarakhand. Boundaries:- East : H/o Others West : Plot of seller North : Indra Vihar South : 16ft wide Road
3	MTCMT24015040 / Ranvir Singh / Manish Pal	Rs.23,97,213.00 (Rupees Twenty Three Lakh Ninety Seven Thousand Two Hundred Thirteen Only)	04-07-2026 19-08-2026 11-08-2026	1. In The Rights, Piece And Parcel of Immovable Property Bearing Plot No. 236, adm. 80.26 sqmts., Khasra No. 214 Mi, Vill- Dantal, Near Sharadhapuri, Pargana Tehsil, Distt.- Meerut-250001, Uttar Pradesh. Boundaries of Plot No. 236: East : Plot No. 237 West :15 ft wide Road North : 24 ft Prop. Rajpal South : 25ft wide Road 2. In The Rights, Piece And Parcel of Immovable Property Bearing Plot No. 237, adm. 80.26 sqmts., Khasra No. 214 Mi, Vill- Dantal, Near Sharadhapuri, Pargana Tehsil, Distt.- Meerut-250001, Uttar Pradesh. Boundaries of Plot No. 237: East : Plot No. 238 West :Plot No. 236 North : 24 ft Prop. Rajpal South : 25ft wide Road
4	MTCSSR24016937 / Pappu Kumar / Kavita Devi/ Nikhil Kumar	Rs.7,94,314.00 (Rupees Seven Lakh Ninety Four Thousand Three Hundred Fourteen Only)	09-07-2026 12-08-2026 11-08-2026	In The Rights, Piece And Parcel of Immovable Property Bearing Khasra No. 57, adm. 137.87 sqmts., Wake Abadi Gram Daindur, Pargana Gangoh, Tehsil Nakur, Distt. Saharanpur-247341, Uttar Pradesh. Boundaries:- East : Rasta 6 Meter Wide West : Mata Rani Madir North :H/o Lillu South : H/o Laxman Kumar
5	MSGP24016554 / Mahendra Kumar / Arti Sharma	Rs.7,14,567.00 (Rupees Seven Lakh Fourteen Thousand Five Hundred SixtySeven Only)	03-08-2026 12-08-2026 14-08-2026	In The Rights, Piece And Parcel of Immovable Property Bearing Arazi No.768, adm. 101.25 sqmts., Mauza Chandwari Tappa Uttar Haweli, Pargana Hasanpur Magahar, Tehsil Sahjanwa, Distt.-Corakhpur-273209, Uttar Pradesh. Boundaries:- East : Rasta 2-5 Mts West :Plot Mahendra North :H/o Shivanand South : H/o Jahind
6	AGRMH24018642 Gopal Singh Priya Devi	Rs.7,39,780.00 (Rupees Seven Lakh ThirtyNine Thousand Seven Hundred Eighty Only)	09-07-2026 19-08-2026 20-07-2026	In The Rights, Piece And Parcel of Immovable Property on Plot bearing Khasra No. 80, adm. 46.16 sqmts., Radhika Dham Devipura, Mauza-Govindpur, Tehsil and Distt. Mathura-281004, Uttar Pradesh. Boundaries:- East : Road 18 feet West :Vacant land of party North :Plot of Surekha South : Land of Gulab

If the said Borrowers shall fail to make payment to **Centrum Housing Finance Ltd** as aforesaid, **Centrum Housing Finance Ltd** shall proceed against the above secured assets under Section 13(4) of the Act and the applicable Rules, entirely at the risks of the said Borrowers as to the costs and consequences. The said Borrowers are prohibited under the Act from transferring the aforesaid assets, whether by way of sale, lease or otherwise without the prior written consent of **Centrum Housing Finance Ltd**. Any person who contravenes or abets contravention of the provisions of the said Act or Rules made thereunder, shall be liable for imprisonment and/or penalty as provided under the Act. Place : Uttar Pradesh/ Date :31.08.2026

Sd/-, Authorised Officer For Centrum Housing Finance Ltd

England beat Pakistan by 194 runs to win Test series at Lord's



Ollie Robinson (R) took a total of 16 wickets in the two Tests. AP

Reuters
London, August 30

ENGLAND BEAT Pakistan by 194 runs in the second Test and sealed their first home Test series victory for two years as they bowled the visitors out for 194 at Lord's on Sunday.

The outcome was a formality as Pakistan were reduced to 14-3 before lunch chasing an unlikely target of 389 but Saud Shakeel provided some resistance with a magnificent fighting 97.

Ollie Robinson was Pakistan's chief tormentor again as he took four wickets for 24 to go with the four for 11 he bagged in the first innings, taking his total in the two tests to 16.

After a rain-hit Saturday, England resumed on day four on 177-7 but were all out for 208 after Pakistan quick Mohammad Abbas helped mop up to finish with five wickets.

Robinson removed Azan Awaish with a delivery that nipped back off a length and three balls later produced a stunning delivery that hit the top of Abdullah Shafique's off stump, leaving Pakistan reeling on 7-2. There was no respite before lunch for Pakistan as captain Babar Azam tried to fend off a vicious Jofra Archer bouncer but could only edge it via his helmet to Jordan Cox at third slip.

Shan Masood and Shakeel dug in though and at least steered Pakistan to their highest score of the series so far. Robinson removed Masood for 26 after lunch, but Shakeel provided some after-noon entertainment as he struck 13 fours and two sixes in a brilliant knock.

There was genuine disappointment around the ground when he fell three runs short of a deserved century, trying to launch Josh Tongue over the deep square leg boundary but picking out Harry Brook, before walking off to a hearty reception. With Pakistan opener Imam-ul-Haq again unable to bat because of an injury sustained in the field on Thursday, England only needed nine wickets to finish the contest and Tongue completed the victory by dismissing Mohammad Ali. The third and final test will start at Edgbaston on September 9.

The outcome was a formality as Pakistan were reduced to 14-3 before lunch chasing an unlikely target of 389 but Saud Shakeel provided some resistance with a magnificent 97

WOMEN'S ASIA CUP

Big victory margin, but familiar failings remain

India thrash Thailand by 94 runs in opener, but over-reliance on openers remains a worry for the team

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, August 30

ON THE eve of India's Women's Asia Cup opener against Thailand, Amol Muzumdar had made a pledge. After nine defeats in 16 T20Is this calendar year, India's head coach wanted his team to set the tone for the remainder of 2026 through this tournament. In sport's most fundamental currency — victory — the start was as promised.

India began their Asia Cup campaign with a 94-run demolition of Thailand at the Dubai International Cricket Stadium on Sunday. Asked to bat first, they made 159/9 before bowling the underdogs out for 65. The emphatic result, though, came courtesy of a few individual performances that papered over some familiar collective cracks. The gulf in quality between the two teams was considerable — a nine-place difference in the T20I rankings underlined it — but Thailand still managed to expose some of the frailties that had bothered India at the Women's T20 World Cup. Chief among them was India's overwhelming dependence on their openers.

Quick start

Smriti Mandhana and Shafali Verma were the only Indians among the World Cup's top 10 run-scorers. They began the Asia Cup in much the same vein. India raced to 38 from their first 17 deliveries, 19 of those coming from Mandhana off just 10 balls, before she was run out off the 18th delivery of the match.

Shafali ensured the momentum did not suffer. The Powerplay brought India 65 runs. Her partners could not match either her range of strokes or her power, but Shafali continued undeterred. Pratika Rawal, making her T20I debut before playing a game in the Women's Premier League, scored a 22-ball 18, her



Deepthi Sharma scalped three wickets without conceding any runs to derail Thailand's innings. CREIMAS

strike rate of 122.22 piling beside Shafali's.

Skipper Harmanpreet Kaur blew hot and cold in England. And cold it was, on this occasion as well, losing her wicket to Thipatcha Putthawong, who led the women's T20I wicket-takers' leaderboard at the time. Despite the repeated setbacks, Shafali had taken India's score to 112 in 12.4 overs before losing her wicket. In the subsequent 44 deliveries, India mustered only 47 runs.

Bharti Fulmali's attempt to take her WPL form into international cricket continued without much success, as she made 13 from 14 balls. Her T20I career remains in its infancy, but she has crossed 20 runs only once in seven innings.

Richa Ghosh's stay lasted a solitary delivery. Her recent T20I form has hardly been encouraging, and three of her four T20I ducks have now come in the Women's Asia Cup. On her 150th T20I appearance — only two women have represented India more often — Deepthi Sharma made five. Prema Rawat, on her second international appearance, scored a run more.

And so, in the post-Shafali phase of the innings, India unravelled from 112/3 to 137/9. The

The gulf in quality between the two teams was considerable but Thailand still managed to expose some of the frailties that had bothered India at the Women's T20 World Cup

next 22 runs owed as much to India's Nos 10 and 11, Shree Charani and Kranti Gaud, as they did to Thailand's underwhelming fielding.

Stronger suit

Bowling, meanwhile, was unlikely to be a source of anxiety. India had recorded the second-best bowling average at the T20 World Cup. That, coupled with Thailand's highest-ever score against India being 74, had hinted at the second phase of the game being a foregone conclusion. It was.

Gaud, fresh from etching her name on the Lord's honours board, needed only five deliveries to provide India their first breakthrough. The more efficacious pacer in this game, however, was her partner, Nandani Sharma. The

24-year-old had benched the pair of Renuka Thakur and Arundhati Reddy — combined 119 T20Is between the pair — and showed why with figures of 4-0-18-3.

Deepthi, who India would ideally want to contribute more with the bat, made her historic appearance even more memorable with three wickets, taking her to the top of the women's T20I wicket-takers' list. Then there was Charani, the supporting act in this game, who has increasingly become a protagonist in her own right. Among players from Test-playing nations, no bowler has taken more T20I wickets this year than the left-arm spinner. She took two wickets in this game.

With a margin that large, searching for shortcomings can easily resemble desperate nit-picking. But Harmanpreet, more than most, will know that the scoreline cannot obscure the immense room for improvement, with more difficult fixtures coming up.

BRIEF SCORES: India Women 159/9 (Shafali Verma 64; Suleeporn Laomi 3/26) defeated Thailand Women 65 all out (Nannapat Koncharoenkai 41; Deepthi Sharma 3/0) by 94 runs.

Unsung Abhijit combines with Shami and Mukesh to restrict Central Zone to modest 266

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, August 30

WHEN A bowling attack has two India internationals in Mohammed Shami and Mukesh Kumar, the expectation is that they will do most of the damage. It is not often, then, that a domestic pacer bowling alongside them stands out more.

On Sunday, Abhijit Sarkar did just that on the opening day of East Zone's Duleep Trophy semi-final against Central Zone at the BCCI's Centre of Excellence (CoE) Ground 1 in Bengaluru.

Sarkar made the early inroads before Shami and Mukesh used the older ball well as East Zone bowled Central Zone out for 266 in 80.1 overs on Day 1. Sarkar finished with 3/38 from 16.1 overs, including six maidens, while Mukesh took 3/56 and Shami 2/42. First-class debutant Kounain Quraishi also took two wickets when Central Zone threatened to recover.

East Zone were familiar with the conditions, having won their quarter-final against North East Zone at the same venue, and made a strong start after opting to bowl. Shami began by testing Aman Mokhadde and Aryan Juyal, but Sarkar provided the breakthroughs. He hit a good length consistently and found enough away movement to have Mokhadde caught by Abhimanyu Easwaran at slip.

Four overs later, he struck again. Sarkar brought the ball into Kunal Chandel, who tried to work it through the leg side, played around it and was trapped in front. Chandel reviewed, but ball-tracking returned three reds, leaving Central Zone 36/2.

Sarkar's impact went beyond the wickets. His accuracy made scoring difficult and allowed East Zone to maintain pressure when Shami and Mukesh were out of the attack. His first eight overs cost a mere 13 runs. Anukul Roy also kept things tight as Central Zone rebuilt.

The pressure showed in Rajat Patidar's innings. The Central Zone captain took 35 balls to reach double figures before Shami returned and began troubling him. He nearly bowled Patidar off an inside edge and then beat him outside off.

The wicket eventually came through Mukesh. A short ball outside off caught Patidar half-committed to the pull and an under-edge crashed into the stumps, sending him back for 12.

As the ball grew older, Shami and Mukesh came into their own. Mukesh ended Juyal's 113-ball stay for 46, getting the ball to move away and take the outside edge. The on-field umpire gave it not out, but stand-in captain Vaibhav Sooryavanshi successfully reviewed the decision. Sooryavanshi had taken charge after Kishan left the field with a thumb injury. Kishan later returned to captain, though Kumar Kushagra continued behind the stumps.



Mohammed Shami (C) celebrates after taking a wicket. PTI

Kaverappa triggers North Zone collapse on Day One

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 30

AS MANY as 12 wickets fell on the opening day of the Duleep Trophy semifinal with only 235 runs scored.

The decision to bat first didn't pay dividends for North Zone as they were bowled out for 195 in less than 60 overs. The South Zone reply didn't begin on an auspicious note and they finished the day at 40/2 with two of their best batters — Ricky Bhui and Shaik Rasheed — already dismissed.

The story of the North Zone innings was written around two mini-collapses. They were comfortably placed at 71/1 before losing three wickets for 24 runs. After they had recovered to 161/4, another stumble saw them lose their last 6 wickets for merely 34 runs.

It was Vidwath Kaverappa who was the wrecker-in-chief with figures of 4/66. Jammu and Kashmir opener Qamran Iqbal almost batted through the innings, being the ninth batsman out for 76 off 182 balls.

His 53-run stand for the second wicket with Ayush Doseja (23) and the 66-run partnership with skipper Kanhaiya Wadhawan (35) were the only positives for North Zone. Apart from these three, the highest scorer for the team was Abdul Samad with 16.

If South Zone had hoped for an incident-free end to the first day with the bat, they were mistaken. In Arshdeep Singh, Gurnoor Brar and Anshul Kamboj, North Zone have a potent pace attack, and the openers didn't have things going their way.

It seemed that they had weathered the storm when Bhui and Narayan Jagadeesan took South Zone to 34 without loss. But there was a sting in the tail as Bhui was castled by Kamboj for 5 before Rasheed was trapped in front by Brar without opening his account.

Jagadeesan had captain Tilak Varma for company when stumps were drawn. **BRIEF SCORES: North Zone 195 all out in 59.1 overs (Qamran Iqbal 76; Vidwath Kaverappa 4/66) vs South Zone 40/2 in 18 overs.**

There was sameness to the bowling: Gavaskar

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 30

GOING INTO the final day of the Colombo Test, all India had to do was pick up the remaining four Sri Lankan wickets and try to chase any required runs. However, things did not go to plan for Shubman Gill's men as Sonal Dinusha helped the Sri Lankan lower order put on a firm resistance to frustrate the Indian batters.

Former Indian cricketer Sunil Gavaskar acknowledged that the off-spinner might have

been a bit nervous, but also said India's inability to dismiss Sri Lanka's tail is a concern.

"The debutant off-spinner looked an honest trier with little variety to trouble batters at this level. Sure, he could have been nervous considering that he was making his debut, yet there was no deception through the air and an over-reliance on the pitch for assistance," Gavaskar wrote in his Mid-Day column.

"If they couldn't dismiss the lower order batting on a pitch where there was some turn, it

does make Indian cricket fans a bit nervous. There was a sameness to the bowling. On a pitch that got slower as the match progressed, the fast bowlers struggled to get the ball up towards the batters' shoulders. Here perhaps the extra pace and height of Gurnoor Brar may well have come in handy," he added.

Kuldeep Yadav, who played the first Test, was out due to illness for the second game. The former opener opined that Kuldeep Yadav, a left-arm wrist spinner, could have troubled

the Sri Lankan lower order, and that Jasprit Bumrah's yorkers too might have been pretty brutal.

"Kuldeep Yadav's absence also did not help, as a good wrist spinner can get the lower-order batters out in a jiffy most of the time," said Gavaskar.

"A fast bowler with a good yorker is also terrific to have in the side when the opposition batters are looking good. So Bumrah was badly missed, especially when the batters thwarted India on the final day of the second Test."

LEGEND'S TAKE

Anand backs Praggnanandhaa for the first board at the Chess Olympiad

Amit Kamath & Mayank Chaudhary
Mumbai/New Delhi, August 30

IT PROMISES to be one of the hottest debates in Indian chess: who plays for India on board one at the upcoming Chess Olympiad, with at least three contenders in the race — D Gukesh, R Praggnanandhaa and Arjun Erigaisi. It's a question that has even the OG of Indian chess Viswanathan Anand curious.

"I have no part in the board order selection for India. I don't know what the order will be. I don't think Srinath Narayanan (the Indian team's non-playing captain) takes the decision unilaterally. I think he also talks to the players and figures out what they're comfortable with. But

these guys will say yes to everything. They're flexible. They'll say, 'your decision, I'll go with it.'", Anand told The Indian Express in an interview.

The five-time world champion didn't believe it was a "contentious decision", regardless of the call.

"Right now, it's very tempting to drop Praggnanandhaa on the first board. I think that's probably what it's going to be like. As for the others, I know that Arjun likes to drop down. He already showed this last time, at the 2024 Olympiad, where he played board number three. And for the rest, I'm just as curious as to what the final composition will be."

Gukesh is the reigning world champion, and the man who won India two gold medals on board one across the last two

Olympiads. Praggnanandhaa is the in-form player, having won Norway Chess and the Grand Chess Tour Finals. Arjun is India's top-rated player, per the August 2026 rating list.

Arjun sits at world No. 9, with a rating of 2759; Praggnanandhaa is 12th, at 2750; Nihal Sarin is 25th, at 2718; Gukesh has slipped to 31st, at 2703, having lost 74 rating points since January 2025, when he was the newly-minted world champion. Vidit Gujrathi is 33rd, at 2697.

The playing order isn't just a matter of prestige. The person on the first board faces every opposing nation's top player at the Olympiad. Anand also weighed in on the board order for the women's Olympiad team, who are also hoping to defend their gold medal. This



Vishy Anand (C) believes players will be flexible on board order. FILE

time, Koneru Humpy will be available after missing the last edition. Harika Dronavalli, meanwhile, will not be part of the side, with Vantika Agrawal

and Savitha Shri rounding out the five-player squad.

"On the women's side, I think it's slightly simpler. You have R Vaishali and Divya

Deshmukh really for the top two boards. I don't know how they'll swap it around. And then Koneru and Vantika - I think probably Humpy on third and Vantika on fourth. It seems more straightforward, but maybe they also want to juggle it a bit," he said.

No foregone conclusion At the 2024 Olympiad, India were in rampaging form in the open section, scything through the field and losing just once in the 44 games they played over 11 rounds. This time around, India is not looking as imperious as two years ago.

Ask Anand if India can retain their Olympiad gold, and he says: "The gold was not assured even with that team in 2024. But an Olympiad always comes down to a few moments and some unpredictability. For

the same reason, it's very difficult to repeat."

However, he is not lacking in confidence in his compatriots.

"But I don't see a particular problem (in India winning gold again). Gukesh has had a difficult year and so on, but there's no reason why the curve doesn't turn again. I think there are other very good teams, Uzbekistan and the US certainly, and you also have a few other teams with lots of young players. The chess scene is exciting in general. I don't particularly have a prediction, but I've not given up on the Indian team."

These days, Anand is the FIDE interim president, but still enjoys playing in team events. He recently played in the German Bundesliga and the World Rapid and Blitz

Teams event. In a week's time, he will play on the top board for the PBG Alaskan Knights in the fourth season of the Global Chess League (GCL), after three seasons with the Ganges Grandmasters team.

"When you've decided to play less, each event is something you look forward to, maybe, slightly more," Anand says before praising the buzz he experiences during the GCL. "It's fun being with a team. The atmosphere in GCL is generally quite relaxed. The team normally looks after us very well."

He is technically from another era, but Anand would have enjoyed being part of the current Indian Olympiad team.

"I had thought about this in 2024 and this year as well. It's not possible, but why not? I think it would be a fun team."

Tanvi, 15, stuns two Top 100 players to win Pontianak IC



Tanvi Patri. BAI

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 30

RANKED 132nd IN the world, Indian teenager Tanvi Patri stunned two Top 100 players on consecutive days to win the Pontianak International Challenge in Indonesia on Sunday.

Yesterday in the semifinal, Tanvi knocked out top seed and world no 51 Rachel Chan of Canada defeating her 21-9, 21-19 in the straight. In the final today, she dominated world no 82 Kim Min Sun of South Korea.

The Indian shuttler won 21-5, 21-6 in just 32 minutes. This is first title of the season for Tanvi who had finished runners up at the Antica Singapore Challenge last week.

One of the highest-rated teenagers in India, Tanvi spent her formative years training in China.

PPBA coach Sagar Chopra said that Tanvi's strong technical base was evident from the outset. "She has trained in China, so she is technically very strong — everything, from her movement to court coverage to the sense of when to play a stroke. There are some shuttles which we, as coaches, think she won't reach, but she gets under them. This is something very rare in a 13-year-old," he told the *The Indian Express* in an interview previously.

Panda Sisters win

At Lagos International Challenge, Indian women's doubles pair Ruparelia and Swetaparna Panda defeated compatriots and top seed Kavipriya Selvam and Simran Singhi to win their first title of the season.

The Panda sisters won the all Indian affair 21-14, 25-23 in 45 minutes defeating the higher ranked Indian pair who recently played at the World Championships in New Delhi.

Similarly to the women's doubles, the men's singles and mixed doubles were also all Indian finals. Gnana Dattu defeated Hmar Lalthazuala in the final 21-9, 22-20 to win his first international title of the season.

In the mixed doubles, Sathwik Reddy and Radhika Sharma retired in the third game of the final as Dhruv Rawat and Manisha K lifted the title. Dhruv and Manisha were leading 16-11 in the decider when the other Indian pair retired.

One of the highest-rated teenagers in India, Tanvi spent her formative years training in China.

DEVELOPING AN 'INDIAN STYLE'

The apps and drills making India a doubles force in badminton

With 3 of India's last 6 Worlds medals coming in paired events, getting targeted coaching is paying off

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, August 30

'KOREAN DEFENCE' is a full-fledged drill that entire training sessions at Hyderabad's Pulela Gopichand badminton academy are devoted to, in recent years. It's fast-paced, low-crouched relentless extending of a rally in which hypnotic shuttle exchanges both unlock and unleash reflexes - for that's the Operating System of doubles: speed, laced with power.

While Taufik Hidayat, Lin Dan, Lee Chong Wei, Lee Hyun-Il and Tai Tzu-ying were emulated for their game styles as singles legends, Korean doubles stalwart Lee Yong Dae and current World champs, Baek Ha Na and Lee So-hee, have been the gold standard in terms of footwork, stance, rhythm and racquet angles. Three of India's last six World Championship medals have come in doubles, and it reflects in the training lingo, the buzzwords, catchphrases and the actual court drills and off-court habits that are slowly ushering in a doubles culture.

Even the applications downloaded on phones are geared towards improving reflexes and mental agility needed in doubles.

Treesa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand kept India's World Championships streak going with a bronze in Delhi, after taking out World Nos. 7 and 4 pairings on the way. But it's Satwik-sairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty who deserve a lion's share of the credit in placing doubles front and centre for completing a decade together with multiple achievements.

But with women's doubles also scoring its second Worlds medal for India now, the vocabulary and the lens with



India's World Championships bronze medal-winning pair of Treesa Jolly (R) and Gayatri Gopichand (L). FILE

which it got viewed is changing quickly. Badminton's next generation has arrived, and it speaks 'Doubles'.

Training the eye

On an average training day, it won't merely be the crowded court with 4-6 players engaged in fast exchanges, hooting, whistling and bantering about as doubles courts tend to be. Doubles shuttlers now have their eyes trained, with colour cones at four corners serving as cues for which shot to play and where on a verbal prompt. In another colour-coded drill, two different coloured shuttles are fed at fast clip with players required to play either attacking counter-drives and pushes or soft drops and cross-court blocks depending on the colour of the shuttle.

Spending nearly two months' training only on net dribbles might've sounded like an unconventional way to prepare for a World Championships, but much of the doubles coaching work going on at Hyderabad, in developing an 'In-

dian style', relies on Indian smarts and good hand skills to break down a rally while keeping pace with the East Asian speed on the flat drive game.

So while the Korean style works on transitions from defence to offence with racquets redirecting the shuttle, India's top mixed doubles shuttler Tanisha Crasto adds that they are using tennis balls bouncing off walls and ground for plain reflex-activations.

BlazePods or digital reaction lights are deployed where during a flat-drive or mid-court monotone passage of play, the players have to stay alert to randomly flashing lights of their designated colour. This increases peripheral alertness because so much is happening in a doubles game at the same time.

"Building reflexes and reducing reaction times is the goal. We all have different games, but I use the 'One Brain' app on my phone for reflex training," Tanisha says.

Changing culture

Doubles often faces the prob-

lem of Indian parents pushing their wards towards singles because they don't want to deal with partnership hassles. So while increasing depth after trusting coaches and stepping back is just the first step, the real doubles struggle starts after committing to a partner.

"The serve-and-receive is totally different from singles," coach Sumeeth Reddy explains. The assortment of wicked serves - tumble, straight-fast, legal-spin and flick - get deservedly disproportionate time as coach Gopichand ominously says,

"You will see a bunch of Indians honing those serves and using them."

The drives-game (flat parallels) is something that's not seen in singles, but is on the menu in doubles. Attack-defence also means two vastly different things in doubles than singles.

"In singles, you are looking for gaps. Doubles is not about finding gaps," Sumeeth says. "It's about sensing which opponent is slow or tentative on the day, and targeting them with the right attack."

The nature of the nemesis has undergone a change too. The training courts in Hyderabad that a decade ago were devoted to solving the Yihan Wang-puzzle for Saina-Sindhu, now have Liu Shengshu and Tan Ning on their dashboard.

"It's not good when you lose to them," Treesa says, adding every loss has given the Indians enough arsenal to strike the next time, but deciphering the Tan tumble-serve and devising counters will happen in training.

"It's a matter of time. We just need to believe we can beat those players," she says of the 1-7 head-to-head against the dominant World No 1s, who won silver in Delhi.

"We both are here to do something big," Treesa says of what drives her and Gayatri, a pairing that many clamoured to split up and disregard before the bronze.

Five of the last six World Championships medals for India have now come from the Hyderabad training base; three in doubles. India's doubles DNA is commensurately changing.

• BRIEFLY



Cole Palmer (centre) celebrates with teammates after scoring. AP

Palmer scores for Chelsea in second straight Premier League win

COLE PALMER showed more signs of a return to his top form by completing the scoring for Chelsea in their wild 4-3 win over Brighton in the Premier League on Sunday. In front of England coach Thomas Tuchel, Palmer ran 30 metres before curling home a shot from the edge of the area for Chelsea's fourth goal at Stamford Bridge to end Brighton's realistic hopes of a comeback in an end-to-end thriller. Romeo Lavia and Pedro Neto put Chelsea 2-0 ahead by the 14th minute before Joao Pedro added a third in the 32nd for Xabi Alonso's team. Malick Yalcouye pulled a goal back for Brighton just before halftime, and the visitors further reduced the deficit when Pedro deflected a cross from Pascal Gross into his own net in the 63rd. Palmer's goal clinched a second straight victory for Chelsea, who opened their league campaign by beating Fulham 3-2. Palmer scored in that game, too. AP

Nabi to play three matches for Surrey

AUQIB NABI left for the UK to play three matches for Surrey in the County Championship Division One with an eye on India's tour of New Zealand in October. The Jammu and Kashmir pacer was recently drafted into the Indian squad as a replacement for the injured Jasprit Bumrah in the two-Test series in Sri Lanka but did not get a chance to make his debut. PTI

Messi nets four goals as Miami rout Montreal

LIONEL MESSI scored thrice in the second half to finish off his first four-goal effort in MLS play while adding an assist, and Inter Miami scored six unanswered goals in a 7-1 romp over CF Montreal. Messi snapped a 1-1 tie in the 40th minute when he found the net for the 15th time, and scored again in the 52nd, 83rd minutes and in stoppage time. AP

Ruparelia, Negi win India Junior GP titles

DEV RUPARELIA and Ishita Negi won the boys' and girls' titles, respectively, at the India Junior International Badminton Grand Prix, while Pavan and Punith Suresh claimed the boys' doubles crown in Pune. Ruparelia beat Nishchal Chand 21-16, 21-16 in the boys' final and Negi beat Maharashtra's Gatha Suryawanshi 21-19, 21-18 in the girls' final. PTI

Abhay wins 13th PSA Tour title in Malaysia

TOP SEED Abhay Singh clinched the Tuanku Muhriz Trophy squash event, a USD 15,000 PSA Challenger event in Negeri Sembilan, Malaysia, defeating third seed Henry Leung of Hong Kong in five games. World no. 24 Singh defeated Leung, ranked 59 in the world, 11-7 6-11 3-11 11-5 12-10 to bag his 13th PSA Tour title in 18 finals. PTI

Germany make sole chance count to down Spain, bag fourth World Cup

Prithvi Raj
New Delhi, August 30

"IT WAS painful," Spain men's hockey team skipper Marc Miralles said with a smile after defending champions Germany defeated his side 1-0 to retain the Hockey World Cup title.

If one looks at the numbers of the final, it indeed appears painful as Spain did everything right on paper, except finishing the chances created. Spain had double the circle entries (24 as compared to Germany's 12), almost double the number of shots (9 as compared to 5), and more penalty corner chances.

However, Germany took the only viable chance they

had and Michel Struthoff scored the most memorable goal among his eight international strikes to hand the Germans their fourth world title.

"Before the tournament, everyone was saying: Germany this year? No. Everybody was talking about the other teams but we showed what we are capable of," quipped Christopher Ruhr, who is a two-time world champion now.

With their fourth title, Germany are tied with Pakistan for most hockey World Cups (WCs). Interestingly, Pakistan's last WC title came in 1994, eight years before Germany won their first title in 2002.

After losing to India in the



Germany now have four World Cup titles in hockey. FIH

bronze medal match at the Tokyo Olympics in 2021, the German team has gone on to win

two world titles, an Olympic silver, and a European title. This is Andre Hanning's fourth major

title as a coach since he took over the head coach role in 2022.

Playing against Spain, who had stunned Olympic champions Netherlands in the semis, Germany sat deep in their half and absorbed everything Spain threw at them. Pol Cabre and Jose Basterra were brilliant on the flanks, regularly finding pockets to create chances, but the German defence stood strong.

At the half-time break, both teams were goalless.

In the third quarter, Spain amped up the attack and played beautiful and fluid hockey. But ironically, despite ten circle entries and three shots on target, it was Germany's one circle entry

in the quarter that decided the World Cup final.

The German right and left flanks co-ordinated into almost poetic motion in the 44th minute. Michel popped on the baseline to receive a pass from the midfield, moved from left to right, dodging one Spanish defender and rounding up goalkeeper Luis Calzado before simply lifting the ball into the net.

With the lead in hand, the German team put their bodies on the line to protect it. As captain Miralles flicked from the penalty corner, it hit Germany's first rusher, Prinz Thies, who had to leave the field.

In the final quarter, Spain

threw everything they had but the German defence held firm. Coach Max Caldas replaced goalkeeper Calzado with four minutes remaining to put an outfielder but the Germans were resolute.

Miralles said that the German team understood the tempo better. "We had so many chances. But they understood the tempo of the game better," he said.

"They were unbelievably tough to beat," Ruhr said before adding that the celebrations will go on till next week.

Fairly so, they deserve it after equalizing one of the most dominant records in the world of hockey.

• LEGEND LEFT EMOTIONAL

Federer's love for the sport comes out during induction to Tennis Hall of Fame

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 30

MIRKA FEDERER summed it up even before husband Roger took the stage. The titles, the records, the elegance, while extraordinary, are only part of the Swiss legend's rich legacy. "What makes me proudest," Mirka said on Sunday, isn't what Roger accomplished when the world was watching. "It's who he is when nobody's watching."

And thus when Roger was inducted into the International Tennis Hall of Fame in Newport, Rhode Island, it was a celebration of the remarkable human — not just the player who wielded his racquet like a wand. While the grace and effortless ease on court "never stopped amazing" Mirka, she was more impressed by the devoted father, kind husband, loving son and ever-present friend.

Her moving introduction brought Roger to tears, and the

emotions resurfaced throughout his subsequent speech. He kept using humour to lighten the moment, joking in between that his speech might go on till sunrise given the lengthy tear breaks. Though he has now joined the Hall of Fame, Federer said fame was never his objective; he was motivated by his love for the sport.

"We play tennis, we're tennis players. That for me is what it's about: the sense of play," Federer added. "Yes, this sport takes work and practice. But the sense of play always carried me through. And when the work and play blend together, that's the best feeling of all."

In his 28-minute address, Federer took his audience on a nostalgic, vicarious ride, right from his days as a 13-year-old ballboy to the 103 ATP titles, acknowledging the roles played by friends, adversaries and mentors along the way.

Thanking every ballboy who

stood through his matches, Federer recounted his own thrill at witnessing stars from up close.

"I'll never forget how the game looked from there and how it felt. The thrill of standing so close to the players, feeding them the ball, handing them the towel, seeing them sweat, watching them fight it out, figure out the adversity, the intensity," the Swiss maestro said.

He then described his playing journey, on which he embarked as a three-year-old. Federer said he started with double-handed forehands and backhands as a kid, a far cry from his famous one-handed whiplash of a backhand in his professional days.

Not him alone

He reiterated the importance of the supporting acts that make up the tennis ecosystem.

"Tennis is never about the players alone. It's moms and dads like mine taking their kids



Roger Federer with his wife Mirka at the induction ceremony. AP

to matches, cheering them on. It's coaches who teach children how to win and how to bounce back when they lose. It's people who sweep the courts or pick up the balls. It's young players like me who get a chance to be a ball kid. And also, by the way, it's all linespeople," he added.

Emotions got overwhelming for Federer halfway through his

speech, when he spoke about Stefan Edberg, who "provided huge personal inspiration for the everyday grind on the tour". He choked up again when speaking about his longtime coach Severin Luthi, before he went on to thank Mirka, calling her "my coach, hitting partner, reality check and stylist".

Federer said he was "in-

"I'm still writing my love letter to tennis. My time as a player is done, but tennis will always stand at the intersection of everything I care most about: my family, our friendships, the past 40 years, the future we're building."

ROGER FEDERER
AT HIS HALL OF FAME INDUCTION

credibly lucky" to have played with different generations of tennis players, from Andre Agassi and Lleyton Hewitt to Andy Roddick, and then Rafael Nadal and Novak Djokovic. He sprinkled some more humour

by way of the number of headbands and socks he expended.

"I'm talking about the numbers that really paint a picture. Between 1998 and when I first went on the ATP Tour, and when I retired in 2022, I wore more than 5,000 headbands," said Federer. "That's more than (Bjorn) Borg and (John) McEnroe combined. And if you think that's impressive, I wore probably over 7,000 pairs of socks. That's probably twice as many as most of my opponents, because I doubled them up," he said.

While jokingly asking for tissues and sunglasses "to protect" himself, Federer delivered the ultimate punchline. "I'm still writing my love letter to tennis. My time as a player is done, but tennis will always stand at the intersection of everything I care most about: my family, our friendships, the past 40 years, the future we're building."

"Tennis for me is responsible for it all."

Pegula shakes off nerves to win opening match

New York: Jessica Pegula shook off nerves that contributed to a slow start against Elena-Gabriela Ruse, winning her opening match at the U.S. Open on Sunday in straight sets. Leading off at Arthur Ashe Stadium, the American missed her first nine opportunities to break Ruse but found a rhythm and began dominating. Pegula won 92% of her first-serve points on the way to a 6-3, 6-2 victory in 83 minutes. 19th seeded Jasmine Paolini also advanced in women's singles, defeating Veronika Erjavec 6-3, 3-6, 6-4. Kamilla Rakhimova beat No. 27 seed Barbara Krejickova 7-6 (4), 6-2. ASSOCIATED PRESS